

talent sprint
Part of Accenture

Accenture
LearnVantage

Reinvent for the
"Age of Intelligence"

National AI Olympiad

Benchmark your AI readiness

8 - 9 August, 2026



Laptops, Mobile Phones, Tablets for winners
Projects showcase for top rankers
Certificate and Reports for participants



To check your AI Quotient, Register today!

talentsprint.com/naio

ts-naio@accenture.com



Take your AI journey to the next level



Upgrade your AI Quotient

40 Hours
Live Online
Sessions

20+
AI Tools
Covered

12 Unique
Hands-on
Projects

20
Skill-based
Challenges

Add-on
Self-paced
Content

6 Months
Unlimited
Access

Experience Artificial Intelligence in Action

Claude |
 Gemini |
 ChatGPT |
 Copilot |
 Cursor |
 Zapier |
 PartyRock |
 LangChain |
 FireFly |
 Docker |
 Gradio |
 Perplexity |
 n8n |
 Flowise |
 Vector DB |
 Pandas |
 Pinecone |
 Hugging Face |
 Python |
 Veo >> and more

Choose your track

Functional
Ideal for non tech
background

Technical
Ideal for tech
background

Claude Pro
Ideal for
developers

To upgrade your AI Quotient, Register Now!

Offer Price
₹7,800/6 months
(Program Value: ₹23,600)

talentsprint.com/ai-infinity
ai-infinity@accenture.com
 1800 108 3535



Be a part of most
awarded **AI programs**



Excellence in
Inclusive & Accessible
Learning Solutions
ET Education



Innovative
EdTech Product
of the Year
BW Education



Most Disruptive
Category Creation
& Innovation
ET Brand Equity



Most Disruptive
Education &
EdTech
ET Brand Equity



Accreditation



DEGREE DESIGNED FOR CAREERS OF THE FUTURE

Full-time eBBA (Hons.)

from IIM Jammu



Placement opportunities with
800+ companies for new-age jobs

Direct entry option to eMBA Degree
after third year as per CGPA score

Unique blend of Industry and Academia

60% ACADEMIC
COMPONENT

FROM
INDIAN INSTITUTE OF
MANAGEMENT, JAMMU



40% INDUSTRY-LED
LEARNING

FROM
ACCENTURE CENTRE OF
ADVANCED STUDIES

Accenture
LearnVantage



6 months industry
internship



Industry use cases and
hands-on projects



720 hours of
industry sessions



Relevant industry
certifications



Duration
Four-year,
Full-time Degree



Blended format
Live Online +
Campus Visits



Immersive learning
45 hours of engagement
per week



Valid entrance scores
JIPMAT, CUET, JEE or
IIMJ admission test

Specializations
Cloud and AI, Data and AI

LIMITED SEATS AVAILABLE

Classes starting from Sep 2026

Secure your
child's future, now!

Eligibility

12th or equivalent from a
recognized board or council

APPLY TODAY!

ebba.iimj.ac.in
73373 39787

SCAN TO APPLY



THE PUBLIC EXAMINATIONS (PREVENTION OF UNFAIR MEANS) AMENDMENT BILL, 2026, SET TO BE BROUGHT IN PARLIAMENT TODAY

PM sets up high-powered task force on exam reforms led by Nandan Nilekani

Minister Pralhad Joshi meets chief of NTA, top Education Ministry officials

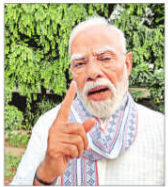
Jatin Anand, Harikishan Sharma & Damini Nath
New Delhi, July 26

A DAY after the protest at Jantar Mantar over the NEET-UG paper leak was called off following Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation as Union Education Minister, Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday announced a high-powered task force on exam reforms led by Infosys co-founder Nandan Nilekani.

"Based on its report, the work to make our examination system more dependable will be done as soon as possible," the Prime Minister said in an Instagram video.

"For the future of students, the Government of India is continuously taking several steps. Those who played with the future of students are rotting in jails. We have established fast-track courts; in Parliament tomorrow, we are moving towards making a new law with tough provisions. We have to think of the future. That our education system becomes reliable, transparent and uses technology to the maximum," Modi said.

"Keeping all these things in mind, it has been decided to create a high-powered task force



PM Narendra Modi speaks in a video message posted on social media. VIDEO GRAB

under world renowned technology expert Shri Nandan Nilekani, which will focus on examination reform," Modi said.

Nilekani had earlier headed the Aadhaar digital ID initiative under the UPA government. The new task force also includes former ISRO chairman S Somnath, former IB Director Tapan Deka, IIT Madras director V Kamakoti, former Education Secretary Anita Karwal and retired IAS officer Amrit Lal Meena who has been included as a "logistics expert".

According to officials, the "multidisciplinary group of domain experts" will "help +CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



A deserted Jantar Mantar on Sunday, a day after the Cockroach Janta Party called off its protest. PRAVEEN KHANNA

Opposition's House plan: Target Shah over protest crackdown

Adjournment motions planned; Rahul writes to Home Minister

Asad Rehman & Jatin Anand
New Delhi, July 26



Leader of Opp Rahul Gandhi

A DAY after the resignation of former Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan after nationwide protests, the Opposition is now gearing up to target Union Home Minister Amit Shah as Parliament reconvenes on Monday.

Sources said a host of Opposition parties are drafting adjourn-

ment motions, demanding answers from Shah for the violence and "use of lethal weapons" by the police during the protests against paper leaks in Delhi on July 20. Opposition sources said the Congress, Trinamool Congress (TMC), CPI(M) and others will now try to shift the focus of

the paper leak issue to the alleged use of excessive force against protesters.

Indications were there on Sunday that the fight against the government during the ongoing Monsoon Session will be taken to Shah as Lok Sabha Leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi wrote to the Home minister, seeking accountability for the "barbaric assault" on student protesters.

Writing to Shah on the eve of Parliament reconvening, Gandhi said, "Our students were demanding a fair and accountable education system. Instead of being heard, security forces assaulted them with

+CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Business as Usual
By EP UNNY



Now, NDA sees a bit of Gen Z dissent at home

Sukrita Baruah, Jatin Anand & Asad Rehman
Guwahati, New Delhi, July 26

THE DAUGHTERS of an Assam minister from Asom Gana Parishad, a senior BJP MP from Odisha and a former BJP MLA from Uttar Pradesh. They are among those who may worry the NDA the most in the aftermath of the youth-led protests against exam paper leaks.

As the ruling party grappled with mounting pressure last week to remove Dharmendra Pradhan as the Education Minister, one of the factors likely to have compelled it to accept the demand was that the heat had reached closer to home and a section of its own support base backed the protests.

Among those who joined a demonstration in Guwahati on July 23 in support of the Cockroach Janta Party's (CJP) dharna in Delhi's Jantar Mantar was Assam Cabinet Minister Keshab Mahanta's daughter

+CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

THIRD SUCH INCIDENT IN ABOUT A WEEK

Another ship with 4 Indians targeted at Ukraine port, MEA issues advisory

Two confirmed safe, information awaited on other two: Indian Embassy

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, July 26

THE WORLD PAGE 14



RUSSIA, UKRAINE REPORT CIVILIANS KILLED IN STRIKES

IN THE third such incident in about a week, a merchant vessel with four Indians aboard came under attack at Ukraine's Odessa port on Saturday. While two seafarers are safe, information on the other two is still awaited, the Indian Embassy in Kyiv said on Sunday.

With five deaths of Indian seafarers in the region since July 18, India on Sunday issued an advisory urging its citizens to carefully assess the security situation before taking up jobs in maritime zones witnessing conflicts, especially in the Black Sea area.

The latest attack on the MV AGN Ragnar occurred at the Port of Odessa, one of Ukraine's key Black Sea ports that has been a frequent target of missile and drone attacks since the outbreak of the Russia-Ukraine conflict in 2022.

"Embassy of India in Ukraine is closely monitoring the situation following the incident involving MV AGN Rag-

nar, which was struck at the Port of Odessa on July 25," the Indian Embassy said in a post on social media. "Four Indian nationals were on board the vessel. As per the latest information, two have been confirmed safe, and information is awaited regarding the other two nationals," it said.

Saying that search and rescue operations were underway, the Indian Embassy said it was in constant touch with the concerned authorities to ascertain the status of the missing crew members and extend all

+CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

EXPRESS special

Rajasthan farmers object to GI tag for Unjha (Gujarat) jeera and saunf

Harish Damodaran & Parimal A Dabhi
New Delhi, Ahmedabad, July 26



Champa Choudhary at her jeera field in Undoo village of Barmer district in Rajasthan

"JEERA KI kheti hum karte hain, Unjha toh sirf mandi hai (we cultivate jeera, Unjha is just a market)," says Champa Choudhary.

The 30-year-old is among Rajasthan's many jeera (cumin) and saunf (fennel) farmers aggrieved by the grant of Geographical Indication (GI) tags for 'Unjha Jeera' and 'Unjha Fennel'. The GIs have been registered in the name of the Agriculture Produce Market Committee (APMC) of Unjha, in Gujarat's Mehsana district.

"In Unjha, jeera is only traded, not produced. How can there be an Unjha Jeera when the crop isn't even grown in that area?" asks Choudhary, who farms jeera on 70 out of her 100 bigha (16.7 hectares) holding in Undoo village of Barmer district's Sheo tehsil.

Her statement is backed by +CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

E. EXPLAINED

A spicy battle

Unjha in Gujarat is synonymous with jeera and saunf, being India's biggest market for the two seed spices. Rajasthan's farmers who sell in this market, however, challenge a recent GI recognition to 'Unjha Jeera' and 'Unjha Fennel'. Unjha does not produce enough of these to deserve the tag, they say.

Happening today

THE SUPREME COURT will hear two separate petitions alleging police excesses on student protesters.

TRACK THIS AND MORE ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

NATION

PAGE 8



BIHAR PROTEST: THREE SUFFER BULLET INJURIES

CRPF INQUIRY INTO CRACKDOWN ON PROTESTERS

RAF man fired 7 rounds from pellet gun, 5 hit protesters: Probe

Mahender Singh Manral
New Delhi, July 26

THE CENTRAL Reserve Police Force (CRPF) is learnt to have found that a person from its Rapid Action Force (RAF), who was deployed in Connaught Place area during the July 20 protest march to Parliament, fired at least seven rounds from his pellet gun. Five rounds hit protesters, while two struck the ground, sources told The Indian Express.

As reported by The Indian Express earlier, the CRPF had initiated an inquiry into whether pellet guns were used



RAF personnel during the protest on July 20. GAJENDRA YADAV

by RAF personnel during the crackdown on protesters. At least three persons were treated in hospitals for pellet

gun injuries sustained during the protest march — Irshad Sheikh, 25, who works in +CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

EDITORIAL PAGE
YOUNG HAVE BEEN HEARD, A LARGER LISTENING MUST BEGIN PAGE 10



"Social media has emerged as a big, unknown power... It can create and it can also destroy overnight" RAVIKISHAN ACTOR AND BUMP PAGE 12

DELHI TEEN IS INDIA'S FIRST WORLD TITLE HOLDER AMONG WOMEN

From 'curse' to crown: How Delhi teen Anahat scripted Indian squash history

Shivani Naik
Mumbai, July 26

IT WAS Anahat Singh's fifth bid, and, importantly, final chance to get it right at the World Juniors Championships in Canada.

She had four quarterfinals, one bronze, plenty of deja vu, and even a French coach to match. Gregory Gaultier had been in her tactical corner as coach, the squash legend most famous for losing four Senior World Championship finals before winning the fifth, to teach her precisely how to handle this last week.

The 18-year-old from Delhi, whose father is a lawyer and mother an interior designer,

had called the World Juniors a "curse" because she kept missing the title. When she broke the curse, she became India's first-ever world title holder among women.

On Saturday in Ontario, finally, the teen prodigy made up for all misses and ended Egypt's run of 13 straight titles, after beating three from the squash powerhouse in the quarters, semis and finals.

The attacking player with Indian flair and Gregorian gumption defeated Ruyqiya Salem 11-3, 11-7, 11-9 to ensure a non-Egyptian won the World Juniors for the first time since 2011. India's last finalist was Joshana Chinappa in 2005.

"I still feel like I'm dreaming," Anahat told World Squash. "This tournament has been the worst tournament for me. I have been losing in the semis and quarters over the last four years. I have always said, if anyone asked, 'This tournament's a curse', and I have never been able to play well in the event. This is my last year [as a junior] and my only chance to win it. It means the world."

Anahat played badminton in her early years, picked the wristy deception from there and was star-struck by her hero PVSindhu at the last Commonwealth Games. She is also World No 20 in seniors, and had won her first Professional Squash Association title in Washington



Anahat Singh defeated Egypt's Ruyqiya Salem in the finals. PSA

earlier. She was preparing for her exams in May. "I'm pushing through school work for exams in May," she had said. By July, she had passed a bigger test in

the glass coliseum. Multiple title-winner and her predecessor Dipika Pallikal, just like Joshana, tried many times but always came up

SPORT PAGE 17



MIRABETH CHANU GETS INDIA'S FIRST CWG 2026 GOLD

against the Egyptians. The powerhouse has set the benchmark in world squash for many decades, creating an incredible ecosystem — world-class

coaching, fierce domestic competition and a culture where young players grow up believing they belong at the very top. "So when you play an Egyptian, you are not just playing an individual; you are playing someone who has come through one of the toughest systems in the sport," Dipika explained.

Breaking that stranglehold was extremely difficult because they are technically gifted, tactically smart and mentally very resilient. "Every win against them is earned. That's why whenever someone from outside Egypt wins a major title, it's a significant moment for world squash. So for her to beat that streak of Egyptians winning this title and get one for India is fan-

tastic," Dipika said. India's best squash brain Saurav Ghosal mentors Anahat, while Stephane Galfi runs her day-to-day training and moulded her mindset — stay attacking, but prepare for Plan B, C and D.

"Anahat is a good court mover and likes to dominate the volley," Gaultier had said earlier, adding that the coaching team would help her identify crucial junctures when to attack Egyptians who were skilled, had no fear, and played with a certain stomp.

After wins over Lily Wilson (Australia), Pui Yin Choe (Hong Kong) and Douce Ye San Lee (Malaysia), Anahat dropped +CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

before accepting such assignments," the MEA said in its advisory on Sunday.

It said the situation in and around the Black Sea and adjoining maritime areas "remains highly volatile due to the ongoing conflict." Commercial vessels operating in or transiting these waters are facing significant security risks, including piracy and drone attacks," it said.

It appealed to those seeking employment to obtain "comprehensive information from employers/recruitment agencies and ship operators regarding the vessel's intended route, ports of call, security arrangements, insurance coverage, and emergency response procedures."

It also urged employers to employ internationally applicable standards and provide adequate provisions for medical care, evacuation, repatriation, and compensation in the event of an emergency," the MEA said.

It also asked them to keep their family members informed of their itinerary and maintain regular contact with them. Those requiring consular assistance are advised to contact the Embassy of India or Consulates in the region," the MEA said.



Million Folios

trusted by **39%**
of Mutual Fund Investors in India.

Wealth creation backed by our:

- Strong Processes
- Disciplined Risk Management

 | mf.nipponindiaim.com

Contact your Stock Broker, Mutual Fund Distributor or Investment Advisor  **1860 266 0111***

You can follow us on



Scan the QR code to download our Investor App

Install Now



rediffusion.in

The Unique Investors count for Mutual Fund industry is 6,19,39,221 (Source: AMFI), and that for Nippon India Mutual Fund is 2,41,27,924. Market Share: 38.95%. The folio count for Nippon India Mutual Fund is: 4,01,67,296. Data as on: 30th June 2026. *Monday to Saturday 8 AM to 9 PM. Call charges applicable.

Nippon India Mutual Fund, MF/022/95/1

Mutual Fund investments are subject to market risks, read all scheme related documents carefully.

{ AFTER 36-DAY CJP SIT-IN }

Day after, Jantar Mantar is scrubbed; echoes and memories of struggle and triumph linger

Pragynesh
New Delhi, July 26

THE GRAFFITI on the walls were the first to go. On Sunday afternoon, workers from the New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) applied a coat of white paint over the red and blue police booths at Jantar Mantar. A spray-painted 'Jedesh hamara hai' (the country is ours) vanished. A cockroach holding a pen, sketched hastily on another booth, also disappeared under the fresh coat of paint.

A little further down, along the red boundary wall leading towards Kerala House, messages left behind by supporters met the same fate. One that read 'thanks for the protest thing, do it again' was swallowed by uneven splashes of white.

The clean-up has begun. Road dividers, damaged under the weight of thousands who climbed over them during the past week, are being repaired. Traffic signboards streaked with black spray paint were scrubbed clean, while water tankers washed away the dust and footprints.

Trucks from the New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) were loaded with posters, left-over food and other belongings. Near the barricades, municipal workers gathered the last remnants into piles — shawls, thin mattresses stitched together from old clothes, steel tumblers, broken chairs, and the blue-and-yellow tarpaulin sheets that sheltered protesters from the sun and rain for over a month. Just hours earlier, these



NDMC workers whitewash sketches and slogans at the site of CJP's protest on Sunday. PRAVEEN KHANNA

streets looked very different. Thousands dined at Bolly-wood number Chak De India, hugged one another and celebrated as the 36-day-long agitation led by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) achieved a win with Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation. On Sunday, even as the crowds were gone, the security

60 tonnes of waste cleared, more than 100 NDMC staffers at site

Mishal Mussaddique
New Delhi, July 26

HOURS AFTER the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) called off its month-long protest on Saturday night, following the resignation of Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, the New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) launched an extensive cleanup drive, working through the night to restore the protest site.

Dr Ankita Rai, Chief Medical Officer (CMO) at the NDMC, said 70 sanitation workers were deployed from 10 pm on Saturday to 5 am on Sunday, and 35 more workers were deployed later.

"Around 40 tonnes of waste was cleared last night and 20 tonnes this morning. At midnight, we deployed an earth-mover to remove the residual waste near the stage area and near Kerala House, which was not accessible to us when the protests were going on. We wet-cleaned the area throughout to remove the smell which usually arises when the area is enclosed for so long," said Rai.

Apart from the earth-mover, the operation was carried out with eight auto-tippers, two heavy trucks, and three high-pressure jetting machines, according to NDMC officials.

Rai said Jantar Mantar was cleared in a quick and efficient manner to open up the site to both tourists and residents. "Intense cleaning, washing and restoration works were undertaken rapidly at Jantar Mantar, Tolstoy Road, Sansad Marg, Jai Singh Road, Janpath and surrounding areas of Connaught Place so that we can open up the site to the public as soon as possible," she said.

Chahal added: "Our officers and employees worked continuously throughout the night and during the day to ensure the public faced no inconvenience."

By Sunday afternoon, almost every trace of the protest was gone. Yet the memory of what unfolded here over 36 days will be harder to erase. In a government where, as Rajnath Singh once remarked, "isteefi nahi hote", Gen Z, armed with phones and numerous reels, moved the political needle.

expect a stage to be erected or believe the government will concede to their demands.

"We are here to raise an issue which became dead long ago. It's different to add fuel to an already burning fire. But to get the momentum to start a fire is a lot more difficult," says T.L. Srestha, 52, one of the protesters, referring to the CJP wave.

Across the road, tea seller Dinesh Sharma watched the CJP site being dismantled from the wooden stall with a stove, where he has spent the last two decades selling tea. He has seen it all, he said, all the agitations and protests. But the CJP one was different, he added.

"They (youngsters) were so aggressive. They would not sit in one place. They kept jumping, hooting," he said. "I had sold tea during the Anna (Hazare) movement. But this was a different energy. I have never seen so many phones out, and so many videos being made simultaneously," added Sharma, his customers now having dwindled to a few paramilitary personnel guarding the area.

One of the officers said they haven't received orders to leave the site. "We have to be here tonight as well, till everything is cleared."

By Sunday afternoon, almost every trace of the protest was gone. Yet the memory of what unfolded here over 36 days will be harder to erase. In a government where, as Rajnath Singh once remarked, "isteefi nahi hote", Gen Z, armed with phones and numerous reels, moved the political needle.

'Will come back to meet my fellow cockroaches': Tears, laddoos, reels mark end of Gen Z stir

Drishiti Jain & Devansh Mittal
New Delhi, July 26

CLOSE TO midnight on Saturday, six men began dismantling the makeshift iron stage at Jantar Mantar. The celebrations that erupted hours earlier after Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan announced his resignation had subsided, and the long queues at the Kerala House and Tolstoy Marg entrances had thinned.

Yet, several supporters lingered. Some climbed police barricades, fanning those who had stayed back. Others in groups sharing food, while a few took photographs beside candles lit in memory of students who died by suicide after the alleged NEET paper leak. Many simply stood looking at the now-empty stage that, for 36 days, had united them under the Cockroach Janta Party banner.

Vivek Kumar, aka Viru Bhai, turned 20 on Saturday. When *The Indian Express* last met him in early July, he had quit his job at a Gurgaon mall, joking that he was pursuing a course in "politics" at the protest site. After spending over a month at Jantar Mantar, he found it difficult to leave. This year's birthday, he said, had brought him nearly 15 times as many wishes as last year's. "Andar se rona aa raha hai, ek connection sa feel ho gaya tha yahan (I feel like crying. I'd started to feel a real connection here)," he said. "No body came with ego or attitude, they were real and memorable people," Vivek added.

He glanced towards the stage, where he had spent weeks volunteering, and said he feels proud to have been part of the movement. "In 10-15 years, I'll tell my children their father helped bring about the education minister's resignation on his birthday and they'd better study," he said, laughing. Vivek, who dreams of starting his own political party in his hometown Hajipur in Bihar, was set to board a train home on Sunday. "I'm still learning, I'll go back and join a party campaign in Bihar. In a week, I'll go to Manipal. I met a supporter here who asked me to come and help them raise their voice," he said.

Just then, two people passed by carrying a stack of laddoos. Across the site, many sat on the ground reflecting on the past few weeks. "All my friends are jealous

that we were here when Pradhan resigned. They said: 'You should have called us, we would have also come,'" said a bare-chested 21-year-old Intiaz Ali, as he checked out the views on his Instagram stories. After a day of dancing, sloganeering and cake-cutting, Ali and his three friends settled onto the Tolstoy Road footpath for the night, debating which song would best fit the reels they had shot. "On Thursday evening, we were just having tea when we decided enough was enough. We had to come to Delhi, even if it meant getting beaten by jathas," said Ali, who travelled nearly 24 hours from Murshidabad in West Bengal with his friends.

They were among around a hundred sleeping on the pavements outside Jantar Mantar. Along the Kerala House stretch, supporters unfolded mosquito nets while checking train schedules. Others still milled around the protest site for one last look at the camp that had become the heart of the movement.

For Santosh Nirala, a 42-year-old man from Saranagar in Chhattisgarh, the journey ended in a twinge of disappointment. He and a friend were attending a wedding and boarded a train to Delhi 15 minutes after the ceremony ended on Saturday. While passing through Agra Junction, they read the news. "A passenger told me the minister had resigned... I couldn't believe it. The first person I'd called was my daughter," said Santosh, adding that she took the NEET exam this year. "I'm not a student, but my children are. There are many things that need to be corrected."

A few hours later, police teams reached the site and requested the supporters to leave as the garbage that had piled up for over a month had to be cleared. Soon, garbage trucks rolled in. By around 1 am, the protest site, where a two-month-old online satirical platform had grown into one of the country's first large-scale Gen Z-led protest movements, witnessing fiery speeches, songs and slogans, had fallen silent.

Vivek remained standing, leaning against a stone pillar, his eyes fixed on the empty space where the stage had stood. "I'll come back to meet my fellow cockroaches," he added.



Protesters at the site on Saturday night. ABHINAV SAHA

PROTESTERS LEAVE NOTES AT JANTAR MANTAR

'Reduce fees ... make questions more practical': As tarpaulin falls, some suggestions in a box

Dheeraj Mishra
New Delhi, July 26

WITH EDUCATION Minister Dharmendra Pradhan stepping down and Cockroach Janta Party calling off its protest, the jubilation wound down late Saturday night at Jantar Mantar, the slogans of victory transitioning to a simmering calm. As leaders left the site, a crowd of unknown faces stayed back to soak in the memories — and scribble down suggestions for the future on bits of paper.

Around 8 pm, Aarti of Krantikari Yuva Sangathan (KYS), a Delhi-based student organisation, gave a last call for action after 36 days of protest even as the yellow tarpaulin sheet on the main stage came tumbling down.

"We have won today. But please do share your valuable feedback on what changes are needed in the education system before you leave," she announced through the loudspeaker. The protesters began lining up. From a student in Arunachal Pradesh to a graduate from Delhi School of Economics, and even a 12-year-old, they recorded their last words from the protest site in chits that went into a brown "feedback box" — over 1,800 chits in all.

A young protester, Piyush

Patil, wrote: "High quality mid-day meals for every student. Focus on science and ignore reference to religion. All schools should have the same quality of education."

With the joy of victory, came a quiet sense of ache, of having to leave the site, with many making the promise to continue the protest. "I did not want this to stop (to be honest). I wish we also work towards a better environment. And, as for education, I feel mental health should also be considered simultaneously. That said, the solidarity shown gives me hope. I hope the struggle for a better future does not stop!" wrote a protester, signing off with a triple heart.

A person, who signed as "Inquilab" (revolution), wrote: "Please have engaging sessions. Have more discussions in your classrooms. Make students aware of History, politics, science and other subjects. Listen to students. Make questions more practical."

A graduate from Delhi School of Economics said major economy bodies have failed in the last decades to improve the condition of India and the nation needs more economic and policymakers, and hence seats in such institutions should be increased. "Unity, Harmony, Integrity."



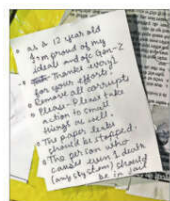
We are the Gen-Z!!!. *Abhi to li angdai hai, aage aur ladai hai* (We have merely stretched, the battle still lies ahead)," wrote Pradishini, a protester.

A student from Arunachal Pradesh, Kanika Kabak, wrote: "(Better) education system should start right from primary level, because elementary stages shape the student."

The movement at Jantar Mantar saw unprecedented camaraderie among people like Jai Baghel, a resident of Chhattisgarh, who volunteered without their personal interest. He wrote, "I volunteered for this protest without any external support or backing. I led a team of 49 volunteers throughout the movement. I'm proud and happy to have been a part of this protest."

In some cases, the feedback was not limited to issues on the table: Sadhana (62) wrote about "significant issues regarding electricity and water supply" in Gujarat. And, Avani Shukla from UP wanted "government officials, ministers and MLAs" to "send their children to schools where children of the common man study."

A protester wrote that at Jantar Mantar, they realised they were "Hindustani". "Yaha aakar hamen bahut achha laga hai. Hame Yaha bahut safe feel hua hai. Auryaha hum sab ko aakar pata chala ki hum sab Hindustani hai, Love my India (We really enjoyed our time here. We felt very safe. Coming here made us realise that we are all Indians — love my India)," the letter read.



(Left) A protester shares her feedback before leaving Jantar Mantar, Saturday; a note left by a 12-year-old. DHEERAJ MISHRA

A 12-year-old student wrote: "I am proud of my ideals and of course Gen-Z. Thanks everyone for your efforts. Remove all the corrupts. Please, please take action on small things as well. The paper leaks should be stopped. The Person who causes even 1 death (any system) should be in Jail. This is a proud moment. I have realised that democracy exists...". Another protester said no paper should be given so much importance that the student put their life at risk.

"It is the duty of the government to protect the trust of the students and the constitutional institutions. Build a culture in the society where students do not have to rely only on the examination. There should be

multiple platforms and opportunities for the students to make their career," the suggestion read. Mohd Samsher Alam wrote: "Our schools should be well enough to deliver that education so that we can clear competitive exams like NEET, JEE, CUET etc. We do not have to take coaching and waste our money, energy and time for it."

A student wrote that the fees of private schools should be regulated and the government should be provided with education in AI, sports, yoga etc., as the poor are not able to send their children to private schools. Another student, Aqil, wrote: "EK Law aana chahiye ki agar dobara paper leak hua toh minister ko resign karna hi hoga. (There should be a law mandating that the minister must resign if the exam paper is leaked again)."

One chit simply read: "Aditya was here."

Wrapping up, Aarti of KYS said: "First of all, this movement is still ongoing. Our main question is: what changed after the resignation? We are carrying this lingering question forward through the feedback process. The right to equal education for all — whether the child of a President or a labourer — remains unfulfilled. It is a long battle, and the struggle continues."

After getting a Master's degree from Ambedkar University and now studying for a PhD at IIT, Neha leads AISA as its national president. Frustration over paper leaks and the mismanagement of job and competitive exams had been building up over years, Neha said. "And we had exhausted every other form of protest," she said.

"So we thought, OK, this (going on a hunger strike) is another form of protest, let's explore this as well. Basically, let's explore everything in pursuit of our demands."

In the beginning, the protest drew only a small number

of people, but Neha and her comrades refused to be heartened.

"Our hunger strike was any way about exposing the government... exposing the fact that no matter what the government says, it will simply choose to watch us away smack in the middle of the capital of this country, and not have an unaccountable and completely incapable Minister of Education resign," she said.

So when Pradhan finally quit on Saturday, Neha could not believe it at first. "Earlier too, several memes and fake resignation letters had circulated. So I asked a comrade to read the en-

tire two pages (of Pradhan's post on X) before I could finally believe that, oh yes, this has happened," she said.

"We were all hugging each other. We were happy that we would have to continue the protest at Jantar Mantar. At last, we will be able to sleep," she said. But she also knows that her struggle will continue. "As student activists, we know this is a job that we must keep doing until things are better in this world... Until that happens, I guess we're all going to be at it. You'll be asking me what is happening in the movement. And we'll be there to give you the answer."

● UTTARAKHAND GIRL, 29, STARTED OUT WITH LEFT STUDENT POLITICS AFTER COMING TO DELHI, NEVER LOOKED BACK

Had exhausted all options, we thought let's explore hunger strike too: AISA chief

Vidheesha Kuntamalla
New Delhi, July 26

WHENEVER SOMEONE asked Neha how she was holding up through the hunger strike at Jantar Mantar, she found herself looking at another, much older protester, also on a fast, a few metres away.

There was this 60-year-old man, "Neha said, referring to activist Sonam Wangchuk. "He's not even from Delhi, and he's braving this (hot and humid) climate. If he is sitting, we will sit for another four days. He's sitting for four days, we'll sit for nine days," she said. Neha, 29, was not on the

same platform as Wangchuk. He occupied the main stage at the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) protest, while Neha and five other student activists from the Left students' outfit All India Students' Association (AISA) protested on a platform nearby. "We got a lot of inspiration from his presence," Neha said. At least two of her comrades were taken to hospital after some days of fasting. Three, including Neha, continued for 23 days, until July 20, when they were persuaded to break their fast by Opposition MPs and leaders of civil society.

As the days passed, Neha lost several kilograms and her body took a toll. But she was convinced that giving up would mean abandoning a generation of students who were angry and frustrated over years of paper leaks and exam failures.

The hunger strike was not a part of the plan initially, Neha, a scholar of Theatre and Performance Studies at Jawaharlal Nehru University, said. "But after we learnt that Sonam Wangchuk would go on a fast, we had a discussion with them (CJP), and decided that as a student organisation we too would go on a hunger strike to demand the resignation of (Education Minister) Dharmendra Pradhan," she said.



AISA national president Neha. EXPRESS

Neha would go on to become one of the most recognisable faces of the movement that eventually culminated in the resignation of Pradhan.

Neha, the daughter of an Armyman, was raised in Khatima

PIT WAS DUG BY GNIDA AT RESIDENTIAL SOCIETY TO CONSTRUCT TUBE WELL; THREE ARRESTED

Even a car could've sunk, says father as boy, 6, falls into pit in Gr Noida, dies

Drishti Jain
Noida, July 26

A SIX-YEAR-OLD boy died after falling into a water-filled pit dug for constructing a tubewell in Greater Noida on Saturday evening, police said. According to Shivan Yadav (42), the father of six-year-old Avyaan, who died in the accident, the child was playing with his friends around 5:30 pm in the Kaladham Society in Greater Noida where the family lives. The pit, he added, was dug for the construction work recently by the Greater Noida Industrial Development Authority (GNIDA) as he claimed negligence by the officials concerned.

Police on Sunday said that three persons — the contractor and two GNIDA officials, who were overseeing the construction work, have been arrested. The contractor has been identified as Manoj Jain (53), a resident of Ghaziabad, said Ravi Shankar Nim, DCP, Greater Noida.



The site of the incident.

Another police officer added that GNIDA officials had been identified as Technical Supervisor Akash Kumar and Supervisor Johnny Kumar. Meanwhile, the Authority has also ordered a probe into the incident.

In the FIR registered at the Knowledge Park police station, Yadav, who works as a teacher at a school in Delhi, was quoted as saying that the death of his son was caused by the negligence of the officials and lack of safety measures at the site.

On Saturday evening, Avyaan had gone out with his

mother to play, his father recalled, adding that she had told him to not go very far with his friends. "While they were playing, his mother came inside the pit. When he fell inside the pit, his friend rushed to call for help. Soon my friend who is also an artist, Harmeet Ratan, jumped inside the pit and pulled my son back after which we took him to Yatharth Hospital, but the doctors at the hospital declared him dead," recounted Yadav.

"The pit is so deep that even a car would have fallen inside... how could my child have survived in that pit?" Yadav asked.

In his complaint to police, Yadav requested for an investigation to probe if the construction work was being carried out after permission from the RWA members, and if any danger signs, barricades or reflectors were put at the site. The pit was around 10-15 feet deep, he said. He also sought to know if the residents were informed about the precautions to be taken near the site. "I want an investigation,

and action should be taken against the officials responsible," he told *The Indian Express*.

Police said that a case has been registered, and further legal action is underway. The case has been filed under sections of Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita for Culpable Homicide Not Amounting to Murder (105) and Endangering Life or Safety of Others (125).

In a statement, GNIDA on Sunday said that a preliminary review has revealed negligence on the part of the contractor, who commenced construction work without ensuring adequate safety arrangements at the worksite. "Taking strict action, the Authority has submitted a complaint to the Knowledge Park Police Station, seeking registration of an FIR against Manoj Kumar Jain, proprietor of the contractor firm Supreme Industrial Corporation. Complaints have also been filed against Technical Supervisor Akash Kumar and Supervisor

Johnny Kumar, GNIDA, for alleged negligence in the discharge of their duties," the statement read, adding that the contractor's company has also been blacklisted.

N G Ravi Kumar, CEO, GNIDA, has ordered a detailed inquiry into the incident, according to officials.

The CEO has directed all work circles to ensure that construction work begins only after proper barricading and all necessary safety measures are in place. "Any violation of these safety norms will invite strict action against both the concerned work circle staff and the contractor," he said.

According to officials, the work to install a new tube well at Kaladham Society commenced three days ago to improve the water supply system. "The contractor failed to inform senior officials of the Water Department before starting the work. A pit was excavated for the tube well, which subsequently filled with water," said an officer.

Security guard tries to rescue sanitation worker inside sewage tank at Noida residential society, both dead

Drishti Jain
Noida, July 26

A SANITATION worker and a security guard were suffocated to death inside a sewage treatment plant at a residential society in Noida, police said on Sunday. Four people have been apprehended for questioning, according to officers.

The incident occurred on the intervening night of Saturday and Sunday at Eldeco Society in Sector 150. The sanitation worker has been identified as Shashikant Sharma (40), a resident of Karauli district in Rajasthan, and the security guard has been identified as Akash (22), a native of Firozabad in Uttar Pradesh.



Sewage treatment plant at Eldeco Society in Sector 150. ABHINAV SAHA

Ravi Shankar Nim, DCP, Greater Noida said, "On Sunday, we received information that two people had died during the cleaning of a sewer tank. Police personnel and the fire brigade team reached the spot

and took them to Kailash Hospital. Later during the treatment, they were declared dead. We have registered an FIR based on the complaint by the families of the victim and have detained four people for questioning."

According to officers, Sharma lost consciousness inside the tank located in the basement of the society while cleaning it. Akash had gone inside it in an attempt to rescue him. According to other security guards at the site, Akash who used to stay with his family in Kundli, had started working at the site nearly three months back, while his father also worked as a guard at the same place.

"He usually worked during the day, but he was working extra hours and also doing night shifts. I came to know about the incident in the morning when I came for duty," said another security guard at the

society who did not wish to be named. Remembering him as "a young energetic soul," he said, "We used to eat together. He was young and still learning, but very disciplined. One friend in the morning told me that yesterday while he was on duty, the contractual worker was cleaning the STP. When he did not come up for a few hours, a maintenance officer came rushing to call Akash, who then went inside to rescue him. But he too did not return. Another guard was able to get inside partially to help them," he said, adding that the incident has left them stressed.

"Is this the value of a life?" he questioned while looking at the towering buildings.

AS PROTEST BY CJP AT JANTAR MANTAR ENDS

Remove offensive posts against PM: Police to social media platforms

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 26

THE DELHI Police has asked social media platforms to remove objectionable videos and posts, targeting Prime Minister Narendra Modi, which were allegedly shared during the Cockerroach Janata Party's (CJP) protest at the Jantar Mantar, said officers.

A senior police officer said the exercise to remove objectionable content from social media is ongoing. "In this case, multiple posts were uploaded on various social media platforms, and they have been removed," the officer said.

The officer added that notices have been issued to three social media platforms directing them to remove content containing objectionable language and offensive remarks about the Prime Minister.

Delhi Police's social media monitoring team is reportedly identifying such content across various platforms on an ongoing basis, according to sources.

Once objectionable content is detected, notices are sent to the social media platforms concerned, requesting appropriate

action, including the removal of the posts. The monitoring exercise is continuing as part of the police's efforts to track and act against such online content, sources added.

The Delhi Police has also identified around 450 social media accounts that allegedly shared deepfake and AI-generated content related to the protests. The officer said these accounts have also been recommended for blocking through the respective social media platforms.

On Saturday, the CJP called off its 36-day protest after the government accepted its demands, including the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan.

This was days after clashes broke out between Delhi Police personnel and students on July 20 during the Sansad Chalo March, leaving several people on both sides injured.

Delhi Police later registered 15 FIRs in connection with the violence, but subsequently decided to withdraw them.

The Delhi Police is probing a wider conspiracy, if it was hatched during the peaceful protest march towards the Parliament.

Process to withdraw FIRs against protesters may begin soon

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 26

A DAY after the Centre accepted the three demands of the Cockerroach Janata Party (CJP) to end their 36-day long protest against NEET paper leak and other issues, Delhi Police officers said they are awaiting formal approval from the government to initiate the legal process for quashing the FIRs against protesters filed after clashes during the stir.

Sources said that on Saturday evening, after the Centre accepted the demands, including the withdrawal of all cases against the protesters, two CJP members, Ashutosh Rana and Saurav Das, met Delhi Police Commissioner Anurag Kumar at his office.

They were informed that the legal process to withdraw the cases would begin as soon as the police receive the government's approval, according to sources.

Sources said the process is likely to begin on Monday after a meeting of officers from the Delhi Police's legal cell, subject to formal approval from the government.

Between July 20 and July 26, Delhi Police registered 15 FIRs, including cases of attempt to murder and assault on police personnel. One FIR was also registered to investigate the alleged larger conspiracy behind the July 20 clashes when the CJP held the Sansad Chalo march.

According to officers, cases involving minor offences can be withdrawn relatively easily. However, FIRs containing serious charges — such as attempt to murder or attacks on police personnel — will require judicial approval before they can be closed.

Officers said that an FIR does not automatically become void merely because of a political agreement or mutual settlement.



Protesters celebrate Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation at Jantar Mantar on Saturday. PRAVEEN KHANNA

Months after HC rap, Govt appoints heads for DCW, minorities panel

Devansh Mittal
New Delhi, July 26

MONTHS AFTER being pulled up by the Delhi High Court over long-standing vacancies, the Delhi government has appointed chairpersons and members to women and minority rights watchdogs in the Capital.

The Chief Minister's Office on Sunday said Lata Gupta has been appointed the Chairperson of the Delhi Commission for Women (DCW), with Shyam Bala, Malti Verma, Lata Sodhi, Sanrika Sharma Jha and Renu Bhalai as its members. Nirmla Jain has been appointed the Chairperson of the Delhi Minorities Commission (DMC), while Kuldeep Singh and Mohammad Haroon were nominated as members.

The High Court had pulled up the government five months ago for not appointing a chairperson and members to the DCW, which has not had a chief after the tenure of its previous chief, Swati Malviwal, ended in January 2024 following her nomination to the Rajya Sabha.

The DMC has also not had a head or members since August 2023. The court had in April also sought an explanation from the government for prolonged delay in the appointments at DMC.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the commissions were "not merely statutory bodies but important platforms that strengthen public trust and amplify the voices of the weaker and disadvantaged sections of society".

According to the government, this is a significant decision aimed at strengthening the protection of women's rights, promoting their empowerment, and ensuring the welfare of minority communities as well as protection of their constitutional rights.

Lata Gupta is a senior BJP



Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta with newly-appointed members. EXPRESS

leader who began her public life in student politics and has served as the Delhi BJP vice-president, former Shahdara district president and former general secretary of the party's women's wing. She was a municipal councillor from Shakarpur (2007-12) and Pandav Nagar (2012-17) wards, and became the first woman chairperson of the Standing Committee of the Municipal Corporation of Delhi.

Jain has served as the Mayor of the East Delhi Municipal Corporation in 2020-21.

He has been a councillor from Shahdara, chaired the MCD's Standing Committee on appointments and discipline in 2009 and was the Leader of House in EDMC from 2018 to 2020.

The DCW was created under the Delhi Commission for Women Act, 1994, with the aim of investigating and examining all matters relating to the safeguards provided to women as per the Constitution and other laws, states its website. The DMC was set up under the Delhi Minorities Commission Act, 1999, to safeguard the rights and interests of the minority communities in Delhi.

• Skywatch



Forecast: July 27, 2026
Generally cloudy sky. Light to moderate rain.

MAX: 34-36
1.1°C above normal

MIN: 25-27
0.3°C above normal

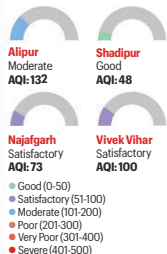
• Sunrise: 5:41 AM (July 28)

• Sunset: 7:16 PM (June 27)

• Moonrise: 5:56 PM (June 27)

• Moonset: 4:09 AM (July 28)

• AQI Tracker



Elevated corridor proposed on Aruna Asaf Ali Marg to ease congestion, feasibility study underway

Devansh Mittal
New Delhi, July 26

TO EASE congestion at one of South Delhi's busiest stretches, the Public Works Department (PWD) earlier this week moved ahead to gauge if an elevated corridor should be built on Aruna Asaf Ali Marg.

The said corridor is a key arterial route connecting Mahipalpur and Mehrauli with Outer Ring Road. However, heavy traffic, multiple intersections and local movement result in persistent congestion, especially during the peak hours. Officials said that the proposed elevated corridor is intended to segregate traffic and thus provide substantial relief to nearby road networks.

On July 20, the PWD approved a budget of nearly Rs 2 crore for a detailed feasibility study of the proposed elevated road. The proposal followed a decision taken at a meeting chaired by the Secretary to the Chief Minister on March 10, during which the PWD was directed to engage a consultant for feasibility studies of elevated corridors to reduce traffic congestion in South Delhi.

The said stretch runs from

Kishangarh village near Vasant Kunj to IIT flyover at the Outer Ring Road-Aurobindo Marg junction, covering around 5.5-6 km. The corridor passes by the Jawaharlal Nehru University, Vasant Kunj and the ICSSR campus.

PWD Minister Parvash Sahib Singh said the proposed project is expected to provide "a signal-free corridor along one of South Delhi's busiest stretches, significantly reducing travel time for commuters". Major bottlenecks, officials said, include the traffic signal near Fortis Hospital, three cuts and two traffic lights in Kishangarh village, and intersections near JNU, Sanjay Van, the Qutub Institutional Area and Ber Sarai, where "traffic moves at a crawl... causing delays for thousands of commuters every day".

The Minister said the feasibility study is aimed at examining existing and projected traffic volumes, engineering design alternatives, construction feasibility, environmental impact, land acquisition requirements and overall project cost before recommending the final alignment and design of the elevated corridor.

EXPRESS explained.Live

LOSE FAT NOT HEALTH

The science behind weight loss

Dr. Anoop Misra
Executive Chairman of Fortis C-DOC Hospital for Diabetes and Allied Sciences

In conversation with
Rinku Ghosh
Senior Associate Editor
The Indian Express

Scan to Register

Why is losing weight becoming harder despite eating less?

Which diet actually works — intermittent fasting, keto, low-carb, Mediterranean, or calorie counting?

Can you lose weight without giving up your favourite foods?

Why do people regain weight after dieting, and how can the 'yo-yo effect' be prevented?

Do weight-loss medications and injections really work, and who should take them?

How do hormones, sleep, stress, thyroid problems, PMOS and menopause affect weight loss?

29 July 2026 | **06:00 PM** | Join us on **ZOOM**

The Indian EXPRESS
— JOURNALISM OF COURAGE —



राजस्थान में
प्रधानमंत्री श्री नरेन्द्र मोदी के नेतृत्व में
1 लाख 78 हजार 397
सरकारी पदों पर नियुक्तियां
पारदर्शी भर्तियों से बढ़ा
युवाओं का विश्वास



पिछले 2.5 साल में युवाओं को मिले
सरकारी नौकरियों के नए अवसर

जिला	नियुक्त कार्मिक	जिला	नियुक्त कार्मिक	जिला	नियुक्त कार्मिक	जिला	नियुक्त कार्मिक	जिला	नियुक्त कार्मिक
अजमेर	6729	भीलवाड़ा	5042	डीडवाना-कुचामन	2191	जोधपुर	6960	प्रतापगढ़	2585
अलवर	6488	बीकानेर	5166	डूंगरपुर	4947	करौली	3997	राजसमंद	2432
बालोतरा	1923	बूंदी	3454	हनुमानगढ़	3948	खैरथल-तिजारा	1288	सलूमबर	913
बांसवाड़ा	5298	चित्तौड़गढ़	3469	जयपुर	20734	कोटा	4506	सवाईमाधोपुर	3812
बारां	3423	चूरू	4743	जैसलमेर	2052	कोटपूतली-बहरोड़	2503	सीकर	7287
बाड़मेर	5277	दौसा	5384	जालौर	2829	नागौर	5707	सिरोही	2026
ब्यावर	2148	डीग	2196	झालावाड़	3567	पाली	3719	श्रीगंगानगर	3264
भरतपुर	5081	धौलपुर	3342	झुंझुनू	5781	फलोदी	1134	टोंक	4465
								उदयपुर	6587

51,427 अभ्यर्थियों की परीक्षा पूर्ण - भर्ती प्रक्रियाधीन

आगामी समय में होने वाली भर्तियां - 81,023 पद

माह	कुल पद	परीक्षा का नाम
जुलाई - सितम्बर	9,268	वरिष्ठ कंप्यूटर अनुदेशक, बेसिक कंप्यूटर अनुदेशक, सांख्यिकी अधिकारी, शारीरिक शिक्षा अध्यापक, कनिष्ठ विधि अधिकारी, कारखाना एवं बॉयलर निरीक्षक, कारखाना निरीक्षक (रसायन)
अक्टूबर - दिसम्बर	45,325	कनिष्ठ अभियंता, कनिष्ठ लेखाकार, जूनियर असिस्टेंट / कमर्शियल असिस्टेंट, कनिष्ठ तकनीकी पर्यवेक्षक (संविदा), राजस्थान राज्य एवं अधीनस्थ सेवाएं (संयुक्त) कनिष्ठ अभियंता, चिकित्सा अधिकारी, नर्सिंग एवं पैरामेडिकल, सहायक निदेशक एवं वरिष्ठ वैज्ञानिक अधिकारी, संरक्षण अधिकारी, संविदा शिक्षण एसोसिएट
जनवरी - मार्च 2027	26,430	ग्राम विकास अधिकारी, कांस्टेबल, अन्य

70,031 पदों पर भर्ती की तैयारी

राजस्थान सरकार - युवाओं के सपने करे साकार

DAY AFTER CLASHES DURING BIHAR BANDH



Protesters damage a police vehicle during the Bihar Bandh over the alleged NEET paper leak in Patna on Saturday. **PTI**

'Came from village to get caste, income certificates, got shot at'

Himanshu Harsh
Patna, July 26

A DAY after clashes between protesters and police in Bihar's Siwan, police acknowledged on Sunday that "aerial firing was carried out", alleging that protesters had "directly attacked" police during Saturday's violence. However, one of those who suffered a bullet injury claimed that he had come to Siwan from his village to get some certificates and was going to the District Magistrate's office when he was hit in the leg by a bullet.

Three people sustained bullet injuries and several police personnel, including Superintendent of Police (SP) Purnan Kumar Jha, were injured in Bihar's Siwan district on Saturday during a statewide bandh over the NEET paper leak and the recent police action against student protesters in Delhi. More than 400 people were taken into custody, police said.

Speaking to *The Indian Express* on Sunday, SP Jha said, "It is not yet clear whether the bullets in all three cases were fired by the police or elsewhere." He said it had been confirmed that one of the injured, identified as Bulat Kumar Gond, suffered a gunshot wound to his leg during the police firing. However, he added that police deployment was absent at the two other locations where bullet injuries were reported.

Gond, a resident of Dumrah Buzurg village under Garauli police station limits, said he had travelled to Siwan to obtain caste, income and residence certificates when he was caught in the violence.

PM: Youth should visit border villages to understand India

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, July 26

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi on Sunday said the objective of the Viksit Vibrant Village (VVV) programme, under which youths visit border villages and live with local communities, is to give opportunities to youngsters to step onto the ground to understand and connect with India instead of relying on virtual means.

Interacting with the participants — many of whom are Gen Z — of the VVV programme on Sunday, Modi said the "vibrant villages" across Ladakh, Himachal Pradesh and Uttarakhand, Modi said that in the country's border villages, the aspiration for development and the spirit of patriotism are equally cherished.

The PM said that during the

Developed India Young Leaders Dialogue, he had presented an idea before the youth. "The idea was that why not have the youth, instead of using virtual medium, step onto the ground to know India..."

In his virtual interaction, the PM said developed villages are the cornerstone of a developed India and his government has considered border villages as the country's first village. "This journey of the developed Vibrant Village is itself a medium to connect everyone, to connect with everyone," he said.

"When the youth of the country connects with the land, it makes the vision of a developed India even more expansive. This youth, in their heart, strengthens the resolve to live for the country, to do something for the country," he said.

Rajnath: Our intention clear, talks with Pak only on PoK

Bashaarat Masood
Srinagar, July 26

DEFENCE MINISTER Rajnath Singh said on Sunday that no talks with Pakistan are in the offing, and that even if there were to be talks, they would only be about Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK).

"Our intention is clear. There will be no talks with Pakistan," Singh said in his speech on the occasion of Kargil Vijay Diwas at the Kargil War Memorial in Dras. "If talks happen, they will happen only regarding PoK, which is a part of India illegally occupied by Pakistan," he said.

Twenty-seven years after the Indian Army forced Pakistan to withdraw from the Kargil peaks it had occupied, the Defence Minister warned the neighbouring country against any "misadventure".

"India will respond harshly and with the same strategic approach in case of a misadventure by Pakistan," Singh said, referring to last year's Operation Sindoor, in which Indian forces struck terrorist targets in Pakistan and PoK in response to the Pahalgam terror attack. "I want to give a clear message. Every nefarious act aimed at undermining India's sovereignty will face the same fate," he added.

Accusing Pakistan of institutionalising terrorism as a state policy, Singh said that



Defence Minister Rajnath Singh pays tribute to fallen soldiers on the occasion of the 27th Kargil Vijay Diwas at Dras in Ladakh on Sunday. **PTI**

while India is progressing through innovation and technology, Pakistan continues to promote terrorism, radicalisation and infiltration.

'Our paths are different'

"India is giving software to the world, while Pakistan is giving (terrorist) sleeper cells to the world. India is building data centres and Pakistan is building radical centres. India is connecting the world through UPI, while Pakistan is connecting terrorism through hawala. In other words, our paths are different..." he said, adding,

"India is building a start-up ecosystem and Pakistan is building a terror ecosystem. India is making semiconductor while Pakistan is preparing suicide bombers. India is known for space missions and Pakistan is running proxy wars. India is sending satellites into space while Pakistan is still engaged in sending terrorists across borders."

The Defence Minister also said India would no longer distinguish between terrorists and their support structure.

"Pakistan has now made terrorism a part of its government policy. The distinction between the military and mili-

itants there has been erased. The Army there not only provides protection to terrorist organisations but also works hand in hand with them," he said. "Therefore, during Operation Sindoor itself, we made it clear that India would no longer see terrorists and the governments that nurture them as separate."

Paying tribute to the soldiers killed during the Kargil war, the Defence Minister said that Kargil was not just a military victory but also a diplomatic victory for India and a defining moment that showcased "courage, determination and sacrifices" of the soldiers.

EXPRESS special

Amid protests & clashes, legislative assembly of PoK heads to polls today

Divya A
New Delhi, July 26

AMID VIOLENT protests and clashes that have been going on for several weeks now, the legislative assembly of Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK) will head to election on Monday. The polls will be held in three phases, ending August 10, authorities have announced.

While unrest has been brewing in PoK for more than a year, the spate of violent clashes in recent weeks — in the run-up to elections — has left at least 20 people dead at the hands of security personnel, and several others injured, according to news agency PTI.

Primarily led by civil society coalition Joint Awami Action Committee (JAAC), now banned by the Pakistan government, the latest spate of demonstrations, sources said, reflect the growing anger over economic hardship, political disenfranchisement and increasing restrictions on civil liberties.

A source in the security establishment said, "Widespread public anger is directed at the legislative assembly seats reserved for non-residents — a manipulative tactic used by the federal government to plant loyalists and dilute genuine local representation."

Sources said that is one of the reasons why the party ruling Islamabad usually wins PoK elections — be it Pakistan People's Party in 2011, Pakistan Muslim League-Nawaz in 2016 or Imran Khan's Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf in 2021.

Of the 53 seats in the legis-



The spate of violent clashes in recent weeks has left at least 20 people dead at the hands of security personnel in PoK. **FILE**

lative assembly of PoK, eight are reserved for women, technocrats and clerics. Of the remaining 45, 12 are reserved for migrants settled in different parts of Pakistan. It is these 12 seats that have been a bone of contention with locals demanding that this reservation be abolished.

'Integral part of India'

According to sources closely monitoring developments in the area, the ongoing unrest was triggered by "a total collapse of local governance, with authorities imposing an economic blockade that has caused critical shortages of subsidised wheat and essential medicines."

They say that the anger is also driven by what is called "economic extraction." "The dams in PoK generate power far beyond the local demand of about 400 MW, yet residents face up to 15-20 hours of load shedding and pay tariffs several times the cost of generation," they added.

The protesters' 38-point charter directly targets the alleged financial corruption and unchecked privileges of the ruling elite. The source also pegged the number of lives lost to indiscriminate firing by security forces on peaceful protesters at 150.

New Delhi maintains that PoK is an integral part of India under illegal occupation. The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said that the recent public unrest is the direct result of "Islamabad's decades-long systemic economic exploitation, denial of fundamental rights, and administrative oppression."

On July 14, MEA Spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said, "The ongoing protests in Pakistan-occupied Jammu & Kashmir are a direct consequence, and indeed evidence, of decades of exploitation, the denial of fundamental rights, and administrative repression under Pakistan's illegal and forcible occupation of the region."

"Instead of addressing the legitimate grievances of the local population, the authorities there have resorted to excessive police brutality," he said, adding that this has included action against vulnerable civilians, including women and children. "We expect the international community to hold Pakistan accountable for these grave human rights abuses," Jaiswal added.

On July 17, the Office of the United Nations Human Rights Commissioner also took note of the situation, calling for "prompt, thorough and impartial investigations into all deaths that have occurred due to the unrest".

Fresh escalation

The latest wave of protests was triggered after the Pakistani government banned JAAC under anti-terrorism laws.

Following the ban, JAAC leader Sardar Aman Khan appealed for assistance from India. "We need India's help. There is a shortage of rations..." Khan was seen saying in a video that has been widely shared on social media.

Sources said that Pakistan is "weaponising anti-terror laws to crush civil liberties, banning the JAAC and arbitrarily arresting over 600 civil rights activists and local leaders."

Meanwhile, sources said that Pakistan Army Chief Asim Munir is marketing a "theoretical 60 trillion mineral dream" resting heavily on Gilgit-Baltistan, where an army-linked firm was caught extracting ore without local approval in 2025.

• BRIEFLY



Smoke billows from the firecracker unit near Sengamalapati in Sivakasi, Virudhunagar district, Tamil Nadu, on Sunday. **PTI**

TAMIL NADU

Two dead, one critically injured in explosion at illegal firecracker unit

TWO PEOPLE died and one was critically injured in an explosion at a firecracker manufacturing unit that was allegedly operating out of a tin shed near Sengamalapati in Virudhunagar district on Sunday morning, police said. One of the deceased has been identified as Ramprakash (38), they said. Ramprakash's brother, Ramachandran (40), sustained 60% burn injuries and is undergoing treatment. According to a senior police officer, the brothers had been manufacturing firecrackers illegally. The blast occurred early Sunday morning. Fire and rescue personnel and the police rushed to the spot to extinguish the blaze and rescue victims. A case has been registered and a probe is on. **ENS**

Four workers die in cylinder blast in Assam

AT LEAST FOUR workers died in a suspected cylinder explosion at an iron casting unit in Cachar district of Assam on Sunday, police said. The incident took place in the afternoon at Kade Global Infrastructure LLP and IRID Casting Works LLP in Pangram, a senior officer said. The explosion was caused by an LPG cylinder, the officer said. The deceased are Kiran Munda, Apur Baraik, Shyamal Gour, and Sagar Nath, the Chief Minister's Office (CMO) said. CM Sarma has also announced Rs 5 lakh each to the families of the deceased. **ENS**

Pak-linked terror module busted in Punjab, 1 held

THE PUNJAB POLICE Sunday claimed to have busted an ISI-sponsored Babbar Khalsa International (BKI) module, operated by foreign based handlers, and arrested its key operative from Jalandhar. The operation also led to the recovery of an Improvised Explosive Device (IED) packed with 1.3 kg of explosive, along with shrapnel and ball bearings, indicating preparations for a high-impact attack. Director General of Police Gaurav Yadav said. The accused, Satbir Singh, a resident of village Padadiana in Adampur, Jalandhar. **ENS**

MANN KI BAAT

PM salutes Kargil war heroes; says 'conserve rainwater'

Vikas Pathak
New Delhi, July 26

IN HIS Mann Ki Baat address to the nation on Sunday, a day after students called off their Jantar Mantar protest following the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan as Minister of Education, Prime Minister Narendra Modi spoke about the Kargil victory in 1999 and the talent of India's youth and urged people to conserve rainwater.

"There are certain days in our lives that do not require a calendar to be remembered. Today, the 26th of July, is one such date. Today is Kargil Vijay Diwas. This day fills us with pride. This day reminds us of the extraordinary courage of our brave soldiers. Towering peaks of Kargil, harsh weather, the challenge posed by the enemy... Our soldiers faced every such circumstance, yet their spirit was greater than every challenge," Modi said.

"They sacrificed their all for the defence of Maa Bharati. Today, on Kargil Vijay Diwas, I respectfully bow to all the brave martyrs and soldiers."

"The India of today not only remembers her heroes but also conveys their saga to the new generation. With this very sentiment, a special 'Shourya Vijay Yatra' has been organised this year. Having started on the 14th of July from the National War Memorial in Delhi, this motorcade rally will reach the Kargil War Memorial in Dras. Its message is — 'One Ride, One Nation, One Salute'. This journey reminds us that the sacrifice made for the nation can never be forgotten." "Lauding the technological growth of the country, Modi said: "Today, alongside the courage of her soldiers, India is also continuously strengthening her technological capabilities. A few days ago, INS Mahendragiri was inducted into the Indian Navy. This modern warship has been designed and built in India itself. More than 75% of the materials used



PM Narendra Modi

in it are indigenous. It is a symbol of the growing strength of an 'Atmanirbhar Bharat'."

"This very month, the DRDO also successfully tested the Praka Long-Range Guided Rocket. Behind this success lies the collective perseverance of our scientists and engineers. Only two-three days ago, the DRDO also successfully tested the Kusha missile," he said.

The PM said be it defence production, defence exports, or political cooperation with friendly nations, India is continuously scaling new heights.

Recalling the last episode of Mann Ki Baat, when he had spoken about the 'Catch the Rain' campaign, he said he was delighted with the successes of the movement and called upon people to contribute to water conservation. Praising India's youth, Modi cited their success in sports. "P V Sindhu has become the first Indian to win the Japan Open title in badminton. The Indian women's cricket team also won its first-ever Test match at the Lord's stadium in London. This is a historic victory..." he said.

"...In the long history of the Lord's, this was the first Test match played by a women's team. It was on this very ground that India won her first Cricket World Cup in 1983. Now, our 'Bharat Shakti' has brought glory to the nation there."

He called upon people to hoist the Tricolour at their homes on August 15, and requested them to share their ideas and suggestions for Independence Day on MyGov.in.

As monsoon revives, 'intense' rain likely to hit over 10 states

Express News Service
Bengaluru, July 26

AFTER A long lull, the South-west monsoon has shown signs of revival.

Over 10 states, including Odisha and West Bengal, are bracing for very heavy rain spells, predicted until Monday. "Intense rain" warning has been issued till July 30 over Gangetic West Bengal, Jharkhand, Bihar, Chhattisgarh and the eastern and western regions of Madhya Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh.

Extremely heavy rain will continue in coastal Odisha and West Bengal till Monday. The 24-hour rainfall recorded over

Jagatsinghpur on Sunday was 330 mm. The India Meteorological Department (IMD) on Sunday said a depression had formed in the north Bay of Bengal region, off the Odisha coast.

According to the Met office, this system was located about 130 km south-southeast of Sagar Island and 140 km south-east of Digha in West Bengal and about 170 km east of Chandball and 180 km east of Chhatrapati Sambhaji Maharaj in Odisha.

"It is very likely to move north-westwards, intensifying further into a deep depression during the next 24 hours. It will cross north Odisha and West Bengal coasts, between Paradip and Sagar islands, around fore-

noon or noon on Monday," the IMD said.

"Extreme heavy" rainfall is expected in Sundargarh, Geonjhar and Mayurbhanj districts on Monday. The IMD has issued a 'red alert' (take action) for these districts.

The weather office has advised fishermen not to venture into the sea along and off the Odisha coast till July 29. Local administrations have ordered schools to remain closed in Jagatsinghpur and Mayurbhanj districts on Monday.

Jammu and Kashmir, Haryana, Punjab, Delhi and most of northeast India regions will experience intermittent rain till August 1.



A flooded stretch on Ahmedabad-Rajkot national highway on Sunday. **REUTERS**

Follow @ieExplained

#ExpressExplained

If there are questions of current or contemporary relevance that you would like explained, please write to explained@indianexpress.com

SCIENCE

This year's Fields Medal confirms China's rising maths prowess

Amitabh Sinha
New Delhi, July 26

TWO CHINESE mathematicians are among the four to have been awarded this year's Fields Medal, making it one of the rare occasions when more than one person from the same country is on the list.

The Fields Medal is the highest prize in mathematics, considered equivalent to the Nobel, only more selective. It is awarded once every four years, and those under 40 years are eligible.

This is the first time a Chinese national has won. Yu Deng and Hong Wang have been teaching at American universities, where most of their prize-winning work also happened, but they are Chinese nationals and products of Chinese universities.

The other two winners are John Pardon, a US national, and Jacob Tsimerman, a Soviet-born Canadian.

How China built an ecosystem

The Fields Medal has garnered special attention this year because of the two Chinese nationals on the list, both recognised for their role in resolving some long-standing puzzles in mathematics. It is being seen as a validation of China's consistent efforts to improve the quality of higher education and basic research in the last few decades.

China's emergence in science and technology has been noticeable for a while now. At least two of its universities consistently rank among the top 20 in the world and four or five feature in the top 50. Its expenditure on research and development (R&D) has grown from less than 1% of its GDP in 2000 to about 2.6% now. Considering that China's GDP

has itself grown by over 10 times during this period, the investments have been massive.

According to the latest OECD Science, Technology and Innovation Outlook, China is now spending almost as much as the US on R&D in purchasing power parity terms. Its research base has increased by over 20% in the last 20 years, and now stands at more than 2.28 million, the highest in the world. It is also one of the top

contributors of research papers in the most prestigious scientific journals.

But China is still largely absent from the world's greatest scientific laurels. It has had just three Nobel Prize winners in the sciences, but it is only a matter of time before this begins to change, and the Fields Medal will could very well be the beginning of a dominance at such awards.

Both Deng and Wang are alumni of Beijing's Peking University, which consistently features in the world's top 20. It is among institutions that received sustained government support under elite education initiatives.

Maths mastery

The Fields Medal recognition might be new, but China's emerging talent in mathematics has been evident for quite some time now.

At the International Mathematical Olympiad, the world's toughest high-school level mathematics competition, China has won more team and individual gold medals than any other country. Since 2000, Chinese teams have secured the first rank all but eight times. They have never finished outside the top three since 1997.

China's rise in artificial intelligence could also be attributed to its proficiency in mathematics. Foundational advancements in AI are rooted in mathematical theories, and China's capabilities in AI are probably second only to the US.

A strong tradition of mathematics has existed in India, too, but it has yet to build a critical mass of leading mathematicians at its universities and institutions. Some of the best Indian mathematicians are working at institutions abroad. Two Indian-origin Indians have so far won the Fields Medal. Manjul Bhargava in 2014 and Akshay Venkatesh in 2018. Bhargava is Canadian-American and Venkatesh moved to Australia as a child.

GEOPOLITICS

Indus Waters Treaty: India's plans, Pakistan's protests



SHUBHAJIT ROY

PAKISTAN HAS been targeting India in recent weeks over the Indus Waters Treaty (IWT), which New Delhi placed in abeyance after the Pahalgam terror attack last April. Pakistan's Defence Minister Khawaja Asif recently said his country would not hesitate to go to war for its water security.

The Indian government's argument, that "blood and water cannot flow together", has at times been perceived to be directed at its domestic political constituency. That weakens its argument in front of the global audience, which often is sympathetic to Pakistan portraying itself as the lower riparian victim.

Pakistan's actions

India maintains it has honoured the treaty amid wars, military crises, terror attacks and prolonged periods of bilateral hostility as Pakistan pursued a policy of cross-border terrorism. According to New Delhi, such treaties cannot remain insulated from persistent acts of hostility.

India feels that Pakistan's conduct reflects a pattern of obstruction. Virtually every Indian project on the Western Rivers (meant for Pakistan's use) — irrespective of its size, storage capacity or technical design — has been objected to by Pakistan. Indian officials argue that the treaty's dispute resolution provisions, intended as an exceptional mechanism to resolve genuine differences, have been converted into instruments for delaying Indian projects.

New hydrological realities

The IWT reflects the technical and hydrological realities of the late 1950s. More than 60 years later, India's population has increased several-fold, resulting in higher demand for drinking water, irrigation, industry and urban development needs. States dependent upon the Indus Basin — including Punjab, Haryana and Rajasthan — face increasing water stress and developmental requirements that could not have been envisaged when the Treaty was signed.

The Indus Basin

India also faces a serious challenge of declining groundwater levels, particularly



The Salal dam on the Chenab. Pakistan had objected to it. WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

in Punjab and Haryana, making greater utilisation of available surface water an urgent national priority.

At the same time, the hydrological regime has evolved, with reduced availability in the Eastern Rivers (for India's use), while flows in the Western Rivers have not experienced a comparable decline.

Climate change has altered basin dynamics through greater hydrological variability, increasing the need for flood moderation, drought resilience, storage optimisation and adaptive operations. Engineering practices have undergone a profound transformation since 1960. Modern dam safety and sustainability require low-level outlets, drawdown flushing, gated spillways, advanced sediment management and flexible reservoir operations. These technologies were either unavailable or not widely recognised when the treaty was drafted.

India's commitments towards clean energy transition and climate goals require efficient development of hydropower infrastructure using state-of-the-art engineering practices, rather than technologies frozen in the engineering standards of the 1950s.

The IWT imposes extensive obligations on India concerning project design, storage limits, spillway configuration, operational procedures and advance information. While Pakistan has built hydropower projects on its rivers, it objects to similar initiatives by India.

Pakistan's water crisis

Pakistan's recurring claims of water insecurity linked to the IWT are contradicted by its official documents and public statements. The Pakistan National Water Policy acknowledges that approximately 35 million-acre feet (MAF) of water flows annually into the Arabian Sea without productive utilisation.

It records that nearly 30-40% of canal water is lost during conveyance, with barely about 58 MAF ultimately reaching farms out of more than 100 MAF diverted through the canal system.

These figures reveal that Pakistan's principal challenge is not upstream water availability but inefficient water management. Chronic canal seepage, ageing irrigation infrastructure, inadequate storage capacity, poor irrigation efficiency, delayed modernisation and inefficient cropping patterns continue to constrain Pakistan's agricultural productivity. These are domestic governance and infrastructure issues that cannot reasonably be attributed to India's hydropower projects.

Senior Pakistani leaders have publicly acknowledged as much. Former foreign minister Shah Mahmood Qureshi admitted that Pakistan's water shortages arise primarily from internal mismanagement rather than any diversion by India.

Pakistan has also attempted to portray fluctuations in the Chenab River as evidence of hostile manipulation. But officials say this ignores both hydrological realities

Dividing a river system

The Indus Waters Treaty divides the six rivers of the Indus system, giving India control of the Eastern Rivers (Ravi, Beas, and Sutlej), and Pakistan the Western Rivers (Indus, Jhelum, and Chenab).

Sections within India have long held that the IWT is one of the most generous water-sharing arrangements ever accepted by an upper riparian state.

Since the treaty was put in abeyance, Pakistan has been targeting India on international fora for 'treating a lower riparian state unfairly'

and established operational practices of run-of-the-river hydropower projects.

River flows at downstream locations such as Marala are influenced by seasonal snowmelt in the Himalayas. Variations in winter snowfall, delayed melting, or cooler spring temperatures naturally affect early-season discharge levels. Such fluctuations cannot, by themselves, be interpreted as evidence of deliberate interference. Temporary fluctuations in downstream river flows during sediment flushing or maintenance operations are normal, regulated engineering phenomena observed in reservoir operations across the world.

What India may now be looking at

Utilising waters: India is expediting projects designed to prevent the avoidable wastage of waters allocated to it. A key priority will be the accelerated development of hydropower projects on the Chenab basin. These are critical for India's clean energy transition, grid stability and regional development.

Major projects under implementation include the 1,856 MW Sawalkot Hydroelectric Project, the 1,000 MW Pakal Dul Project, the 850 MW Ratle Project, the 624 MW Kiru Project and the 540 MW Kwar Project.

The Ujh Multipurpose Project, on a tributary of the Ravi, will enable the storage and productive utilisation of waters that presently flow unutilised across the International Boundary while simultaneously providing irrigation, drinking water, flood moderation and hydropower benefits to Jammu & Kashmir and other states.

Flushing reservoirs: India will also restore the efficiency and sustainability of existing hydropower projects through modern reservoir and sediment management practices. For decades, essential maintenance measures such as sediment flushing and operation of low-level outlets were either delayed or constrained because of persistent objections from Pakistan, despite these being internationally accepted engineering practices.

The Salal Hydroelectric Project illustrates the consequences of such restrictions. Originally designed with a gross storage capacity of about 284 million cubic metres (MCM), the project had to plug its low-level sediment outlets following Pakistan's objections, depriving the reservoir of its primary sediment management mechanism. As a result, the reservoir silted up within a few years of commissioning, reducing its effective storage.

CLIMATE

Why Assam is experiencing unprecedented flooding this year

Sukrita Baruah
Guwahati, July 26

AT LEAST 66 lives lost in around a week, close to seven lakh people affected, and the government struggling to reach thousands of people — Assam is in the grip of an unprecedented wave of floods.

The people who live in the three most affected districts — the Upper Assam districts of Sivasagar, Charaideo, and Jorhat — say they have never experienced such flooding in their lifetimes.

Extent of devastation

Floodwaters had reached critical levels on July 19 and began spreading rapidly. At the height of the floods, over 7 lakh people were affected and 1.15 lakh had moved to relief camps. With the floodwaters gradually receding, the total population affected has dropped slightly to 6.54 lakh across 810 villages in 10 districts on Saturday, according to the Assam State Disaster Management Authority (ASDMA).

Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma said Friday that the government had been



Houses and villages submerged in Sivasagar, Assam. ANI

unable to reach parts of Sivasagar district even after water levels had come down. This, he said, was because of the receding floodwaters leaving behind layers of sediment several feet high.

Through the course of the week, the rivers Dikhow, Dhansiri, the Disang and the Janji and Darika — Brahmaputra tributaries that flow through this belt — have flowed above their 'danger levels'.

Extreme weather events

The Assam government had initially at-

tributed the flooding to a "cloudburst" in Mon in Nagaland on July 19, which is upstream to these tributaries.

A scientist at the Meteorological Centre Kohima, however, told *The Indian Express* that the area had not experienced a cloudburst (defined as rainfall exceeding 100 mm within one hour) but rather heavy rainfall of 137 mm over 8 to 9 hours on that day. This had also triggered multiple landslides in Mon, leaving nine people dead.

Sarma said Friday that the rainfall received over the course of July 18 and 19 in three Nagaland districts and Assam's Charaideo district was well over "normal levels". He said the speed at which water levels rose because of this was "unprecedented", and that the already swollen Brahmaputra hindered the drainage of tributaries into it.

Experts agree that with climate change, high intensity rainfall events of over 50 or 100 mm in one day, which cause damage and floods, are becoming more frequent, and will increase in coming years.

Combination of factors

Dhruvayoti Saharia, professor of

geography at Gauhati University who is studying the current wave of floods, said there has indeed been excessive rainfall.

"There is a mix of rainfall and anthropogenic factors. One contributing factor can be that in satellite images, we have seen excessive excavation on the river valley sides... likely because of mining. (This) would mean a large amount of mud flowing down, which reduces the river carrying capacity," he said.

Nayan Sharma, retired professor from IIT Roorkee specialising in water resources and river engineering, said that deforestation is one of several contributing factors and "100% afforestation" was needed in watershed areas.

"If the ground is barren, the water doesn't have enough time to percolate and it moves downhill very fast and carries a lot of silt. Which is what we're seeing, with a rapid loss of forest cover. This excess silt then raises the river bed and reduces carrying capacity," he said.

According to him, more effective forecasting using global precipitation monitoring systems would not make the scale of destruction "inevitable".

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE

How quantum computing and AI can help trigger a better immune response



EXPERT EXPLAINS

TIMOTHY PATRICK JENKINS

ASSOCIATE PROFESSOR OF BIOTECHNOLOGY, TECHNICAL UNIVERSITY OF DENMARK

COULD THE next breakthrough in cancer treatment come from combining artificial intelligence (AI) with quantum computing? Researchers at the Technical University of Denmark (DTU) have taken the first step by using a photonic quantum computer to improve how an AI model designs peptides, which help the body's immune system recognise diseased or infected cells.

A quantum computer differs from a normal or classical computer primarily in the way it is built and operates. While the latter

uses bits (basic unit of classical information) that are either 0 or 1, a quantum computer uses qubits (fundamental unit of quantum information) that can be both at the same time. A photonic quantum computer uses individual light particles, or photons, as qubits to encode and process information.

The DTU's proof-of-concept study, awaiting peer review, confirmed through laboratory tests that the AI-designed peptides could successfully bind to human leukocyte antigen (HLA) molecules present on a cell's surface — a critical first step in triggering an immune response. **Timothy Patrick Jenkins**, corresponding author of the study, told *AnaGha Jayakumar* that while the technology is still far from clinical use, it could eventually help scientists develop more personalised cancer vaccines and other immune-based therapies.

What are peptides, and why is designing them hard?

Peptides are short chains of amino acids, the building blocks of proteins. In im-

munology, they matter because cells display peptides on their surface, allowing your immune system to inspect them and decide what is healthy and what is foreign. Many vaccines work by showing the immune system the right peptide and training it to respond.

The HLA proteins, sitting on the surface of almost all your cells, are the immune molecules. They act like a display shelf, grabbing short peptides from inside the cell and holding them up on the surface so patrolling immune cells can inspect them. A peptide only gets shown to the immune system if it can bind and sit stably in the groove of an HLA molecule.

So binding is the entry ticket: no binding, no display, no immune recognition. Designing a peptide that binds a particular HLA is the first step in developing such vaccines or immune therapies.

The difficulty then is the sheer size of the

search space. Even for a short peptide, there are hundreds of billions of possible sequences, and only a tiny fraction binds well to any given person's HLA molecule. Finding those needles in that haystack, especially for immune types that are poorly represented in existing data, is hard.

What did AI do, and what did the quantum computer add?

The AI does the actual design work: it learns the patterns of real immune-binding peptides and proposes new ones. Every such model needs a random starting point for each new design. Normally, that's a simple, standard distribution from a classical computer.

We replaced it with samples from a photonic quantum processor, which produces a fundamentally different, more richly correlated kind of randomness that is hard to reproduce on a classical machine.

So the quantum computer didn't replace the AI; it changed the raw material the AI starts from. Handling the model these trusted, correlated starting points appears to push it to explore a wider, less obvious range of designs, rather than converging on familiar designs. That seems to matter most for the harder, understudied immune types where there is little data to guide it.

Why do the gains for data-poor HLA types matter?

HLA genes are among the most variable in the human genome. There are thousands of versions, and you inherit your particular set from your parents.

Versions may differ between individuals and between populations, so two people can display quite different peptides from the very same virus. This partly explains why a given infection or vaccine can provoke a stronger response in some people than others. It's also why some HLA types are well-studied and data-rich while others, often those more common in underrepresented

populations, have far less data.

Current tools work well for common HLA types. That means people with less-studied immune profiles are often less well served by AI-driven design. In our work, the quantum-derived starting distribution performed best for these rarer HLA types.

Why was lab validation important?

Prediction tools are less reliable for the rare immune types we cared about most, so a purely computational result would not have been convincing. We synthesised the top quantum-designed peptides and tested in the lab whether they actually bind well to HLA molecules. Across all three HLA types tested, the peptides bound their targets, with nearly all succeeding for two HLA types and about three-quarters for the most difficult one, whose unusual chemistry makes it challenging for existing predictors. Validation is what separates a real demonstration from an interesting simulation.

FULL INTERVIEW ON [INDIANEXPRESS.COM/EXPLAINED](https://indianexpress.com/explained)



The Indian EXPRESS
- FOUNDED BY -
RAMNATH GOENKA
IN 1932

BECAUSE THE TRUTH
INVOLVES US ALL

Young have been heard, a larger listening must begin

AS NEW beginnings are made, it becomes necessary to ring out the old. The resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, over a month after the start of students' protests triggered by the NEET exam paper leak, is welcome. The minister has done the right thing by making way for someone who will now have to earn the trust of the student community. A community that, to its enormous credit, came together in a leaderless agitation and made itself heard. The twin issues of education and unemployment, which are crucial for a nation's growth, and yet which have been treated with a lack of urgency for decades, are now centre stage. It is the achievement of the satirical online platform, the Cockroach Janta Party, which gave the call, and the youth who responded in large numbers, that a government whose instinct is to demonise the protester, has sent a heartening message: It is listening. In days to come, this listening has to be taken forward. To begin with, it will need an acknowledgement that there are no victors and vanquished — this is a rare and valuable moment precisely because it allows everyone to express their shared stakes in the issues at its core. It must not be tarnished by point-scoring or retribution.

Large challenges of politics and policy lie ahead. The Prime Minister has promised fast-track courts. A tougher law that provides these courts statutory backing, lays down the rules for investigations and trials, and increases punishments for those involved in paper leaks, is set to be introduced in Parliament. A law already exists — the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024. No lessons seem to have been learnt from the last NEET leak, also in 2024, or the recommendations of the committee constituted the same year under former ISRO chairperson K Radhakrishnan to review the NTA and secure the fairness of the public exam system. It will be the responsibility of the people's representatives — those who sit on the treasury benches as well as those in the Opposition — to ensure that they do not let down the students again. This is an opportunity to bring long-pending changes not just in the way examinations are held, but in the education ecosystem as a whole. Larger questions must be raised and debated in Parliament, to rearrange the way learning, skilling and access to opportunities are structured in a country of the young. All institutions have a role to play — the Supreme Court has said it will closely monitor the Centre's overhaul of NEET.

The SC will also hear petitions alleging police excesses against the protesting students. The question of disproportionate use of force by police on young protesters must be addressed transparently and fairly. Most of all, this moment demands generosity and open-mindedness from the powerful — when the young speak, it cannot afford to turn a deaf ear or resort to an older playbook of criminalising dissent. It also demands humility and patience from the young — to be enduring, change will need to be mediated by processes and institutions.

For antibiotics, the right dose is restraint

INDIA'S DEPENDENCE on antibiotics as a convenient cure-all for routine illnesses has reached an inflection point. A global study published in *The Lancet Public Health* has highlighted a worrying trend in the country's antibiotic use: An over-reliance on stronger medicines even as safer first-line medicines remain underused. The World Health Organisation classifies antibiotics into three categories — "access" drugs, which are recommended as first-line treatments for common infections; "watch" drugs, which are broader-spectrum medicines that should be reserved for specific situations; and "reserve" drugs, intended as a last line of defence against highly resistant infections. The study estimates India's optimal antibiotic use at \$9 to 14.7 defined daily doses per 1,000 people per day. Actual use, however, stands much higher at 18.3 doses, with "watch" antibiotics at 9.3 doses against a recommended 6 doses. "Access" antibiotics, at 4.5 doses, fall well short of what is needed.

The preference for "watch" drugs reveals the challenge in how antibiotics are understood, prescribed and consumed. A prescription for a broad-spectrum antibiotic can often feel like reassurance both to a patient seeking quick recovery and to a doctor working in an overstretched healthcare system. But even unnecessary doses narrow the options available for future infections. At the same time, the underuse of "reserve" antibiotics in genuinely resistant cases points to another systemic failure: Ensuring that the right medicine reaches the right patient at the right moment. Fragmented healthcare delivery, poor diagnostic access, and — beyond the clinic — the liberal use of antibiotics in livestock and agriculture, all feed India's rising burden of antimicrobial resistance, where bacteria become resistant to common drugs and infections become more difficult and expensive to treat.

Given the country's burden of infectious disease, antibiotics will remain indispensable. Addressing the problem, thus, begins with replacing quick-fix prescriptions with evidence-based care. National Action Plan on Antimicrobial Resistance 2.0 (2025-2029) places antimicrobial stewardship at the heart of the response, seeking to curb inappropriate usage across human healthcare, animal husbandry and agriculture. A stricter and more coordinated compliance mechanism across the pharmaceutical supply chain is essential to curb indiscriminate over-the-counter sales and irrational fixed-dose combinations.

Cockroaches have shown what it means to be courageous citizens, not subjects

THERE ARE glorious moments when the youth of the nation demonstrate that they are indeed the genuine trustees of posterity, to borrow Benjamin Disraeli's phrase. A generation that has been catastrophically failed by their elders, who bequeathed to them authoritarianism, communalism, a failing education system, an administrative state marked by impunity, and an atmosphere of suffocating fear, decided to take their future into their own hands. They made a regime and Prime Minister Narendra Modi, intoxicated with fantasies of total power, look out of touch, small and ridiculous. By itself, the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan will not bring change. But India's young have shown that the regime is vulnerable. We can still pull back from the abyss.

The movement was the product of an unlikely conjuncture. Protests against exam leaks are quite frequent in India. But it is an adage of politics that we discover power only in the doing of deeds and after the fact. An ill-considered word, "cockroach", used by a Chief Justice of India who has been emblematic of the singularly bad judgment and institutional degradation that marks Indian public life, gave the young an unlikely political identity. Sonam Wangchuk went on a hunger strike, bringing more attention to the movement, and precipitating what seemed like a crackdown. AISAS students led by Neha Bora and others continued the fight. The governments repression only fuelled the movement further.

The issue of fairness and quality in education cuts across party lines, and is a source of consternation even among BJP sup-

porters. Opposition parties, from the SP to the Congress, for once did the right thing — played second fiddle to a movement. All of them showed up, even if sometimes reluctantly. Mobilisers like Chandrasekhar and other organisations provided additional ground troops. The Cockroach Janta Party and Abhijeet Dipke outwitted the government on Instagram. The sheer youthfulness, creativity, and mocking power slowly began to draw out voices of celebrities and ordinary parents. These voices had all been suppressed or often complicit for over a decade. And a movement was born.

The movement has lifted, at least for the moment, the pall of fear that diminished us. It has brought the scandal that is Indian higher education onto the political agenda. The resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan unleashes two dynamics. The farmers' agitation had made the government withdraw legislation. But this is the first time that the government has acknowledged the need for taking responsibility and being held accountable. Responsibility and accountability had disappeared from our political lexicon. But the resignation has another potential. For the first time, a thought will cross the mind of other ministers that they might also someday be held accountable.

They will realise that even PM Modi can, when it suits him, use them as sacrificial pawns. They will need to protect themselves.

Pradhan's fault was not that he did not deliver. He delivered everything the Prime Minister seems to have wanted: Complete control of the KSS over India's higher education.



PRATAP BHANU MEHTA

The movement has lifted, at least for the moment, the pall of fear that diminished us. It has brought the scandal that is Indian higher education onto the political agenda

tion. He subordinated education to ideology and mediocrity. He promoted greater centralisation of higher education, and gave flip to a corrupt political economy of exams and testing. The government reduced the education budget as a share of GDP. No government in India has done well on higher education. The government stuck with him so long because he was succeeding by the metric they wanted him to succeed by. Every other minister should now think whether succeeding by the ideological metric of the RSS will protect them in the future.

The political fallout will be complicated. The government will now never recover its untrammelled authority; there will be internal confusion even among BJP supporters. The Opposition has hopefully realised that corroding the authority of the government with a broad front is far more important than their petty differences. It will be interesting to see if coalition partners now hesitate more in supporting BJP's far-reaching legislative agenda. But it is not going to be easy to stem the rot in Indian higher education. This government's stated agenda does not look good: Rather than just fast-track courts for exam leakers, the entire NTA structure needs to be dismantled. The proposed Higher Education Authority Bill will centralise power even more. In education, personnel is policy, and it is hard to imagine this government putting together even a minimally competent, independent and empowered talent pool.

It always bears repeating: For this government, the loss of face, and the potential loss of power, is existential. It may have retreated

for the moment, but it will almost certainly return with renewed determination, doubling down on repression, even if by stealth. It is to the Gen Z movement's credit, and to the advantage of its novelty, that it proved difficult to delegitimise it through the familiar tropes of a "foreign hand" or the spectre of anarchy. Whatever disorder did occur was the consequence of the government's actions, not those of the protesters. But citizens should expect more prohibitory orders on protest, more targeted harassment of individuals and institutions, and the continued incarceration of students such as Umar Khalid, whose prolonged detention remains a stark reminder of the communal and authoritarian core of this government's vision for education.

At one level, this movement brings to light a background failure: There are no institutional channels left for policy feedback or accountability. The street is our only channel. These students reminded us what it means to be courageous citizens, not subjects. But citizenship alone will not suffice; we will also have to recover the ethics of our professions. Chief Justices will have to uphold the majesty of the Constitution, not hunt for cockroaches. Academics, who have too long abdicated their vocation, will have to reclaim the university. Politicians will have to rediscover the obligation to be responsive rather than demand submission. Otherwise, India will remain trapped in a grim dialectic: Repression answered by protest, tyranny interrupted by moments of extraordinary courage, but tyranny nonetheless.

The writer is contributing editor,
The Indian Express

Rising rupee, new Trump tariffs — track the headwinds



ISHAN BAKSHI

OVER THE last few weeks, there have been some signs of foreign capital flows trickling back in. In July, foreign portfolio investors have so far poured in \$1.5 billion in the equity markets, reversing the trend of massive capital outflows witnessed in the months before. Last week, the RBI also disclosed that after the measures it had announced to boost capital flows, so far, \$174 billion had been mopped up through the FCNR(B) route, and another \$3.3 through other channels. In April and May, net FDI stood at \$6.5 billion, as compared to \$2.4 billion over the same period last year. Not only are gross FDI inflows higher, but so far, repatriation is lower than last year. These are encouraging signs. Yet, at the same time, concerns are also mounting. Fresh headwinds are buffeting the economy.

Global crude oil prices have edged upwards, hitting \$100 as the conflict of West Asia has reignited concerns over energy supplies. With the Houthis in Yemen attacking oil tankers in the Red Sea, the theatre of conflict has also expanded. After the Strait of Hormuz, now cargo movement through the Bab al-Mandab strait is at risk. The renewed conflict comes at a time when oil inventories are depleting. The combination of higher energy costs and possible constraints on supplies will have consequences for India at multiple levels. India's crude oil basket, which had fallen from \$114.48 per barrel in April to \$83.22 in June, has now edged up to \$103.33 per barrel as on July 23. If global crude oil prices are sustained at these levels, the economy will feel the pain. Inflationary pressures will mount. Though whether prices at the pump are raised will depend on the capacity of the oil companies and the government to absorb the price shock. The current account will also come under stress, financing which has been challenging.

In recent weeks, the Indian currency has once again come under pressure. While the rupee had recovered after the steep fall in May, it has once again begun to test those levels, ending Friday at 96.53 against the dollar — which measures the strength of the green-

back against a basket of six currencies — is strengthening. The Indian currency's weakness, however, predates the conflict in West Asia, raising questions over the country's growth prospects.

There is also uncertainty over the monsoon season and El Nino to contend with. Some believe that both kharif and rabi prospects don't seem great this year. A poor crop will have a bearing on food prices. Food inflation is already inching upwards — the consumer food price index stood at 5.32 per cent in June. Price pressures seem to be building up. The next meeting of the RBI's monetary policy committee, scheduled in early August, will shed light on the central bank's expectations of the trajectory of inflation — where food and fuel play a critical role — and interest rates.

And then there is the tariff issue. Last week, the US imposed a 10 per cent tariff on India, following the USTR's Section 301 investigation. India falls in the category of countries like Bangladesh, Canada, Mexico, UK and Malaysia on whom a 10 per cent tariff has been levied. Other countries such as Vietnam, Turkey and Australia face a slightly higher rate of 12.5 per cent. This, however, may not be the end of the country's tariff challenge. US President Donald Trump has also unveiled a phased tariff plan for imported generic medicines — 100 per cent after two years and 200 per cent thereafter.

Further, the outcome of another investigation by the United States Trade Representative into excess capacity and production in manufacturing sectors is also awaited. This investigation targets 16 countries including India, China, EU, Mexico, Taiwan and Vietnam. While it remains to be seen whether this investigation also proposes the levy of additional tariffs, it does seem that tariffs will remain an internal part of Trump's economic strategy.

All this makes for a challenging environment, navigating which will require coordinated action and deft handling by policy makers.

The writer is associate editor,
The Indian Express
ishan.bakshi@expressindia.com

'Satluj' shifts the binary, cuts across divides



SURINDER S JODHKA

BOLLYWOOD MOVIES are made for release in cinema theatres and, more recently, for OTT (over-the-top) platforms. Their makers want the movie to be widely seen. This is how they recover their costs and make money. However, in India, this also requires certification, failing which, the movie dies a quiet death.

The case of Himesh Trehan's *Punjab 95* has been different. After awaiting with the Censor Board for three months, the movie was released with an altered title, *Satluj*, on an OTT platform, but was pulled back in about 48 hours. Soon, it began circulating through informal networks across Punjab and beyond.

Satluj is about human rights activist Jaswant Singh Khalsa, who exposed atrocities allegedly committed by the Punjab police in the late 1980s and early 1990s, while they fought Sikh militancy. It focuses on his campaign against the large number of "disappearances", in which the police would allegedly pick up young Sikh men reportedly to be active Khalistanis, kill them, and secretly cremate their bodies or throw them into rivers and canals. One morning, Khalsa, too, is picked up from his home and disappears.

While some are questioning its facts, or accusing *Satluj* of showing a biased view of a complex reality, others have expressed the anxiety that it could revive Sikh militancy. Still others see in its release a cynical political move to polarise Punjab's voters. Perhaps the most interesting aspect is the film's reception among Sikhs. They have reportedly embraced it with an unprecedented sense of piety and solidarity. Its shows are being organised in *gurdwaras* and public halls across villages and towns in Punjab.

Like most other communities, the Sikhs in Punjab are divided along caste and class lines. Nearly one-third are listed as Scheduled Castes. The rural Jats and urban Khatri/Arora Sikhs also have sharp social divisions and differences. Their identification with Akali politics has also been varied. The Dalit Sikhs of Punjab, for example, did not support the Akali-led Punjabi Suba movement of the 1960s. They saw in it the possibility of the local landowners, their employers, becoming more coercive. The primary social base of Akali politics has remained the rural/agrarian castes. Likewise, the Sikhs living in Delhi, Haryana or Rajasthan have had their own distinct sense of community and modes of political identification. The Khalistan movement was no different. A majority of Sikhs never identified with it. However, they all suffered because of it, not only in 1984 but even later. They feel angry and agitated every time vested interests call them "Khalistanis" to undermine genuine political grievances. It is perhaps for this reason that *Satluj* emotionally unites them. Such a consensus across the Sikh community is rather extraordinary.

The Khalistan movement of the 1980s had multiple sides to it, but the world mainly heard one side of this story, that told by the Indian state. The film offers a different perspective — of those who were collateral in a plot not of their own making

The writer was a professor of Sociology at JNU

40 YEARS AGO

July 27, 1986



Five killed in Delhi riots

FIVE PERSONS were killed and 45 injured when mobs protesting against the killings at Muktsar in Punjab went on a spree of violence and arson in Tilak Nagar and adjoining areas of West Delhi. A number of houses, shops and vehicles were set on fire, while incidents of stone-throwing were reported from east, south and central parts of the city. Indefinite curfew has been imposed on Tilak Nagar police station areas. The Army has been asked to stand by, and a flag march was organised in Jansukpuri and Tilak Nagar.

Barnala told to nab killers

THE HOME Ministry has taken an extremely

serious view of the killings near Muktsar. The Home Minister, Buta Singh, who spoke to the Punjab Chief Minister, Surjit Singh Barnala, asked him to take immediate steps to nab the culprits. Barnala said that one of the four terrorists involved in the killing had been identified and that the security forces were hot on the heels of the killers.

Total bandh in Punjab

PUNJAB AND the Union Territory of Chandigarh observed a bandh today in protest against the killing of 14 bus passengers by terrorists near Muktsar. The bandh call given jointly by five political parties of Punjab and supported by various trade unions evoked massive response in urban areas including cities and

towns. Shops were closed in semi-urban areas also.

Anti-communal convention

CONDEMNING the killings of bus passengers at Muktsar in Punjab, several political parties and religious organisations appealed to all communities in Punjab and other states to safeguard communal unity in the country, cautioning that any provocative action would only help forces of disintegration. A meeting of politicians, social leaders and journalists, held under the chairmanship of I K Gujral, decided to hold an anti-communal convention in Delhi on August 9 and called upon all secular forces to "join hands and stand as a wall against communalism".

FREEZE FRAME

BY EP UNNY

WARNING



The Ideas Page

Reading the street — lessons from Jantar Mantar for the police



ABHINAV KUMAR

THE best of times, policing protests in democratic societies is a tricky business. No amount of training, equipment and manpower can adequately prepare a police force to take on a crowd of young student protestors who are fired by the recklessness and certainty of youthful idealism. The recently concluded protests at Jantar Mantar organised by the Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) hold many lessons for all serving police personnel. The scenes from Central Delhi over the past week — a tear gas drifting over Jantar Mantar, baton charges near Parliament, hundreds injured on both sides of the barricade — will be studied in police training academies for years. Whatever one's view of the CJP's politics, the operational lessons for law enforcement are worth extracting carefully, because crowd management failures of this scale rarely have a single cause. They are usually the product of several smaller misjudgements compounding under pressure.

Before I get to the professional lessons, let me first compliment my colleagues in Delhi police. Given the scale of the crowd and the passions on display, it is remarkable that no lives, either of our young citizens or of our uniformed personnel, were lost. Clearly, the principle of bare minimum force was admirably adhered to.

The manner in which these protests were conducted and concluded are also a testimony to the health and strength of democracy in India. However I would like to offer a word of advice to Gen Z protestors. Can we have less profanity to express your anger at the establishment please? The reels hurled abuse at the Prime Minister, a 76-year-old senior citizen, certainly marked a new low in our democratic discourse. The right to protest is not diminished when expressed in polite and temperate language.

Moving on to matters of professional policing, the CJP movement did not arrive as a

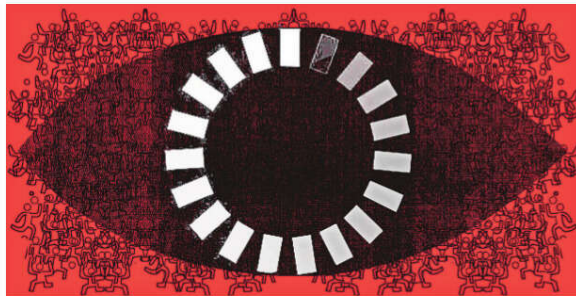


ILLUSTRATION: C R SAKSHI

conventional political rally with a known command structure. It began as satire, spread through memes and student networks, and only later crystallised into an organised force with spokespeople. Police intelligence built for tracking established parties and unions is often poorly suited to a movement that is decentralised in its early phase and only partially so by the time it reaches the streets. The first lesson is structural: Intelligence gathering has to track sentiment and online mobilisation, not just organisational rosters. By the time 10,000-plus people converged on a march to Parliament, the department needed to already understand who could actually speak for the crowd, and, just as important, who could not.

It is clear that in today's scenario, social-media monitoring in real time is an imperative for effective policing. All police forces across the country need to invest in setting up state-of-the-art social-media monitoring centres as a part of their intelligence wings as well as their operational command and control centres. Timely analysis of social-media activity can provide early warning of the buildup of large demonstrations, and provide valuable time to prepare for and prevent any violent confrontation.

Jantar Mantar exists precisely because the authorities long ago de-

Timely analysis of social-media activity can provide early warning of the buildup of large demonstrations and provide valuable time to prepare for and prevent any violent confrontation

cided that allowing a fixed, monitored space for large protests is safer than permitting open-ended marching. But a designated site only works if protestors believe the grievance is being heard there. When a march is explicitly aimed at Parliament rather than Jantar Mantar, that is itself a signal — one that calls for early, visible political engagement, not just a bigger barricade. Physical containment without any accompanying political or administrative outreach tends to convert frustration into confrontation. Engagement has to happen before the crowd is already moving, not after tear gas has been fired.

Reports of nearly 180 injuries, between security personnel and protestors, point to a genuinely chaotic confrontation rather than a one-sided crackdown. But in the era of ubiquitous phone cameras, the video that circulates afterward matters almost as much as the tactical outcome on the ground. Footage of young protestors being struck or dragged

does lasting damage to institutional legitimacy regardless of what provoked the initial clash. Modern crowd-control doctrine increasingly treats the "camera-eye view" as an operational variable. Units need clear rules of engagement, visible identification, and, where feasible, the discipline to de-escalate. A force that wins the street but loses the social-media narrative has not

fully succeeded.

The hospitalisation of hunger-striking activist, Sonam Wangchuk, appears to have been a turning point that swelled the march well beyond initial estimates. High-profile fasts sit at an uncomfortable intersection of medical duty and political optics; heavy-handed or poorly explained intervention almost always backfires. Police and administrators handling such situations need a pre-agreed protocol — ideally involving independent medical opinion and transparent communication — rather than an improvised decision made under time pressure.

It is notable that a genuine breakthrough — ministers meeting spokespeople, talk of a resolution — only came after the worst of the clashes. Waiting for a crisis to force negotiation is a costly sequencing error. Where a movement has emerged with identifiable spokespeople, opening a channel early is cheaper, in injuries and legitimacy. This is a coordination challenge as much as a policing one — it requires political leadership to move at the same speed as the street — but it is a lesson the police, as the ones absorbing the immediate physical and reputational cost of delay, have every incentive to push for.

Mass detentions followed by legal action against dozens of protestors send a message, but so does the pace and proportionality with which those cases are handled afterward. A movement built substantially by young, first-time protestors will judge the state as much by what happens after the cameras leave as by what happened at the barricade. Case backlogs or perceived selective prosecutions become grievances of their own, feeding the next cycle.

None of this erases the genuine difficulty of policing a fast-moving, socially-mediated protest movement with unclear leadership and enormous crowdsizes. But the through-line across most large-scale crowd-control failures — in India and elsewhere — is the same: Intelligence built for the wrong kind of movement, engagement offered too late, and force calibrated for the confrontation rather than for what happens when the footage goes online. Those are fixable problems, and they are the ones worth fixing before the next confrontation at Jantar Mantar.

The author is a serving IPS officer. Views are personal

Saudi-US deal exposes alarming contradictions of new world order



MANAV SACHDEVA

THE REPORTED Saudi-American nuclear cooperation agreement (if it lasts Trump's mood swings) represents a geopolitical inflexion point that exposes the fundamental contradictions at the heart of the current international order — the fragility of strategic partnerships, and the hollow nature of values-based foreign policy in an age of competitive great power interests.

On its surface, the deal is straightforward: The United States extends civilian nuclear technology to Saudi Arabia as part of a broader package aimed at normalising Israeli-Saudi relations, consolidating American influence in the Gulf, and offsetting Iranian regional reach. The optics are managed. The Saudis frame it as energy security for a hydrocarbon-dependent economy transitioning toward Vision 2030. The Americans frame it as non-proliferation-compliant, insisting that enrichment and reprocessing restrictions will be embedded in any agreement. Yet the subtext is unmistakable, and it is alarming: This is a pathway toward a nuclear-armed Saudi Arabia, and everyone at the table knows it.

The first casualty of this arrangement is any coherent American non-proliferation strategy. The Iran nuclear deal, painstakingly negotiated under Obama and methodically dismantled under Trump, was predicated on the principle that nuclear proliferation in the Middle East had to be arrested, that Iranian enrichment was the primary threat, and that a rules-based order required consistency. The Saudi agreement obliterates that principle. If the United States is now willing to facilitate nuclear technology transfer to Riyadh in exchange for regional alignment, the message to every aspiring nuclear power is crystalline: Proliferation is negotiable when strategic interests demand it.

This brings us to the second-order question: What does a nuclear-armed Saudi Arabia mean for Iran, and by extension, for the Shia-Sunni sectarian divide that has metastasised across the region?

The Saudi-Iranian rivalry has been the organising principle of Middle Eastern geopolitics for decades. It is sectarian in language and theology, but fundamentally it is about hegemony. This competition has raged through proxy wars in Syria, Iraq, Yemen, and Lebanon. It has shaped Pakistan's strategic calculus, influenced Gulf monarchies' foreign policies, and rolled Afghanistan.

A nuclear-armed Saudi Arabia fundamentally alters the power dynamic. It removes the Iranian presumption that technological and strategic initiative rests with Tehran. More dangerously, it injects a nuclear dimension into a sectarian conflict that has proven difficult to manage even in conventional terms. The psychological impact on Iran should not be underestimated. For Tehran, which has invested decades in its nuclear programme as both a shield and a symbol of national dignity and technological prowess, the sight of its Arab rival acquiring nuclear capacity through American largesse will be read as an existential provocation. The likely Iranian response is further acceleration of enrichment, pursuit of weapons capability outside any negotiating framework, and a hardening of revolutionary credentials at home. The sectarian divide, which has shown signs of pragmatic negotiation in certain contexts (the Iraqi political settlement, the Lebanese confessional model), will deepen. We should expect a renewed arms race in asymmetric capabilities, proxy conflicts, and sectarian mobilisation across the region.

The Israel dimension adds another layer of complexity and contradiction. For decades, Saudi Arabia and Israel shared a common enemy in Iran. That symmetry justified quiet cooperation. But now, with a nuclear Saudi Arabia on the horizon, Israel confronts a new version of the problem it has always sought to prevent: A nuclear Middle East that it does not dominate. The Israeli strategic establishment has long operated on the principle that it must maintain a decisive technological and military edge. A nuclear Saudi Arabia, even if theoretically non-threatening in intent, represents a diffusion of this monopoly that Tel Aviv has always found intolerable.

As Saudi nuclear capacity grows, the incentives for Israeli-Saudi cooperation will erode. What appears today as a grand bargain may tomorrow as a temporary alignment before deeper structural conflicts reassert themselves. This is particularly true if a future Israeli-Iranian conflict escalates. Will Saudi Arabia remain neutral? Will it defend American interests or its own? The agreement assumes a harmony of interests that history does not support.

The writer is a diplomat and former United Nations aid worker



ILLUSTRATION: SUVAJIT DEY

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Due process

THE EDITORIAL rightly asserts that due process is not an ornamental but constitutional armour ('Due process is not a waste of anyone's time', IE, July 24). When police action risks excess, judicial intervention becomes indispensable. Article 32 of the Constitution enshrines the citizen's right to approach the Supreme Court directly for the safeguarding of one's fundamental rights. Ambedkar famously described it as the "heart and soul" of the Constitution. Without courts stepping in, executive power risks sliding into arbitrariness. The apex court must remind the state that accountability is the price of power and that liberty cannot be trampled in the name of enforcement.

Abhinav Shah, Lucknow

What people want

THE STUDENTS' protests, triggered by entrance exam leaks, have captured the imagination of the whole country ('When young speak, politics must listen', IE, July 24). Clearly, the government cannot take the country's youth for granted or use state power to suppress "people's power". The impact of the protests seems to have persuaded the government to accede to the demands of the "cockroaches". Importantly, the protests have brought into sharp focus a failing educational system, the need for education reforms, the persistence of unemployment, and the need to create opportunities for young people. That the government does not give education the importance it deserves is evident from its failure to ensure that students are not cheated out of a fair chance in entrance exams and from its reduction in spending on education over the years. For any government concerned about the country's welfare, education should be a top priority. The government's failure to ensure the education front has brought thousands of students to the streets seeking accountability and education reforms.

C David Milton, Marathamand



SADAF HUSSAIN

ANTHONY BOURDIN wrote that "despite our ridiculously hypocritical attitudes towards immigration, we demand that Mexicans cook a large percentage of the food we eat." In Delhi, we demand that a man from Kishanganj (Bihar) or Kausani (Uttarakhand) cook a large part of what this city eats, under a name that erases him: Punjabi or Mughlai, anything but Bihar or Pakhadi. These are the men to watch now, because the closing of the Strait of Hormuz is doing one thing to them and another to the households at the other end of the class ladder, and the two are moving in opposite directions.

India imports around 60 per cent of its LPG, and until the US and Israel's war with Iran, roughly 90 per cent of those imports came through the Strait of Hormuz. As the war escalated, the government invoked the Essential Commodities Act, stretched the gap between domestic refills from 21 days to 25 to stop people hoarding cylinders, and raised the price of a cylinder by Rs 60 within days.

People who, in normal times, want their food fresh, local and organic, do the opposite under a supply shock. They fill the pantry with tins, packets, the industrially processed food they spend the rest of the year signalling their distance from. Pierre Bourdieu, whose 1984 book *Distinction*, remains the sharpest thing written

What separated the households that survived from the households that broke was not income. The ones that survived had a plot to return to and a harvest they could eat without paying much for it

on how class hides inside taste, put it flatly: "Taste classifies, and it classifies the classifier." The organic vegetable and the imported tin are both purchases. What differs is who can afford to stockpile against a war.

Now let's follow the cook again. When the gas that runs his stall or his employer's kitchen stops coming and the work dries up, he does not stockpile. He gets on a train to the village in Bihar because the room in the city costs money he is no longer earning, and because in the village there is family, and there is, sometimes, land.

We like to tell ourselves the cook goes home and eats clean, off his own field, closer to the soil, free of a packet he could never afford. This is mostly false, and we know it, because we watched it five years ago. In the CMIE's household panel, which tracked families through the Covid-19 reverse migration, diets did not improve when the workers went home. They craved. Eggs, meat, fruit, and vegetables felt hardest. Food spending in the poorest districts never climbed back, even after the economy recovered.

What separated the households that survived from the households that broke was not income. The ones that survived had a plot to return to and a harvest they could eat without paying much for it. That is the fault line

this war is exposing: Not rich against poor, but rooted against rootless.

The behavioural economist Sendhil Mullainathan and psychologist Eldar Shafir write in 2013 that scarcity is "having less than you feel you need". It makes us "tunnel", which they define as the pull "to focus single-mindedly on managing the scarcity at hand". The point usually lost is that the tunnel is the same for everyone. Only the exit differs, and the exit is bought with resources.

The worst place to be standing is in the middle. The second-generation urban migrant, the man whose family sold or lost the village land a generation ago, has no plot to retreat to and no pantry to stockpile. He has only the market, at the precise moment a war 3,000 km away has broken it.

For two decades, we cheered as people left the land for wage work in cities. In ordinary times that migration lifted them. But we let the old fallback rot as we did it, the plot, the joint family, the village that could absorb the returning sons and daughters, and we put nothing in the city in its place that holds when a strait closes. Ration shops are open, and they will keep people alive. But straying alive is not the same as eating well. This war has shown us how thin the floor is under the people who cook for everyone else, and how many of them have nowhere left to fall.

Hussain is a chef and author

The stolen railway blanket belongs to all of us



SHAMA RANA

NEARLY 15 years ago, my father persuaded the administration to install solar streetlights along the winding footpaths leading to our village. My grandfather was delighted. For him, the lights meant something more than electricity. They meant progress finally finding its way to a place that maps often forget. Some village elders, however, seemed oddly unenthusiastic. My father mistook their indifference for the familiar suspicion that greets every new idea in rural India. "They'll come around," he said. They did, within a week. Not to admire the light, but to dismantle them. The solar panels disappeared first. Then the batteries. Only the poles re-

mained. It was my first lesson in development. Building public infrastructure is difficult. Building a public that believes it deserves that infrastructure is harder.

Earlier this month, this newspaper revealed that passengers stole 1.27 crore bed-sheets, towels, blankets and pillows from Indian Railways' AC coaches in just four years. The loss exceeded Rs 104 crore. The irony is almost unbearable. Those entrusted with cleaning and maintaining the coaches often bear the financial penalty for what passengers quietly carry home. The story made headlines because the number is staggering. But it is also utterly unsurprising.

A newly installed park bench disappears. A brass tap vanishes from a public toilet. Roadside railings are sold as scrap. Electrical cables are stripped overnight. Somewhere,

someone proudly narrates how they "managed" to bring back a railway blanket as though it were evidence of cleverness rather than confession.

The instinctive explanation is poverty. But the passenger travelling in air-conditioned coaches is rarely stealing because they cannot afford a bedsheet. The executive pocketing office supplies is not acting out of deprivation. Hunger explains survival. It

Nations are rarely weakened by grand corruption alone. They are quietly exhausted by ordinary people committing extraordinarily ordinary acts of dishonesty

does not explain entitlement. We have created two moral universes. In one, private property is sacred. Touch my car, my phone or my home without permission, and it is theft. In the other, public property is strangely ownerless. A railway towel does not belong to a fellow citizen. It belongs to "the government" — an abstract, faceless entity imagined to possess infinite resources and patience. The moral weight of theft evaporates because the victim has no face.

Yet every railway towel belongs to someone. To the taxpayer who paid for it. To the child whose school shoes find when public money is diverted to replace what should never have been stolen. To the commuter who eventually receives poorer services because amenities become liabilities. The tragedy is not merely financial, it is moral. India has invested trillions in physical in-

frastructure. Yet infrastructure can modernise a landscape only if civic culture modernises alongside it. We reserve our outrage for spectacular corruption. The scam worth thousands of crores, the politician caught taking bribes. Those deserve condemnation. But nations are rarely weakened by grand corruption alone. They are quietly exhausted by ordinary people committing extraordinarily ordinary acts of dishonesty while convincing themselves that no real harm has been done.

India often asks why public services are poor, why infrastructure deteriorates so quickly, why governments hesitate to provide better amenities. We rarely ask: Have we earned the public goods we demand?

The writer is a Gurugram-based writer and research scholar at MDU, Rohtak

Idea Exchange

MONDAY, JULY 27, 2026

NEWMAKERS IN THE NEWSROOM

WHY RAVI KISHAN

From playing a good-hearted cop in *Laapataa Ladies*, India's entry for the 97th Academy Awards, to the self-appointed moral guardian in *Maa Behen*, Ravi Kishan has emerged as one of the most reliably entertaining actors of Hindi cinema. He has worked across film industries and is well placed to talk about what it takes to entertain the masses. With the BJP beginning its campaign prep in poll-bound Uttar Pradesh, the actor, who is also MP from Gorakhpur — CM Yogi Adityanath's long held political bastion — is all set to be one of his leading campaigners. He also offers a perspective on why young voices matter

Pooja Pillai: You have agreed to talk to us at a very important moment in Indian history. PM Modi in his late night address said that there is going to be a new law to address some of the demands of the protesters. There seems to be a trust deficit between the government and the protesters. Is it enough to propose a new law and have fast-track courts to bridge this gap?

Yes, it is very important. And it is a great decision. I want to thank PM Modi from the bottom of my heart. JP Nadda sir went to Sonam Wangchuk and got him to break his fast. The PM, in his late-night video message, looked very concerned. I have four children and they are all students, so I can understand the pain these students have gone through. The 22 lakh children who gave the exam and those who lost their lives, it is very sad. I stand with the future of these children. I see their pain. The PM is also standing firmly with them.

We recently had a 'Mangal Meeting' with the PM on the parliamentary campus. The government wants dialogue with the Opposition. The Leader of the Opposition, Rahul Gandhi, was also there. The conversation could not progress. The PM wants fast-track courts. He said so in Tuesday's meeting because we, lawmakers, can create a new law. If the Opposition is ready for dialogue, everyone should make such a strict law that no one dares to leak papers in the future. There should be life imprisonment because you are playing with the lives of many families. Such a law can be made if there is a debate in Parliament. The government is completely ready and has answers to all the Opposition's questions. No one plays with the future of children. But what is happening is very sad. The PM is quite sad right now. He is also very sensitive. Those 13 people who have been caught will get such severe punishment that no one, for the sake of a few lakh or the greed of crores of rupees, will dare to do this again.

Pooja Pillai: What do you feel the government is still not addressing? Clearly, despite the outreach, they believe something is still missing.

If the PM is making a video at midnight, then he is listening. Their voice must have reached him; that's why he is speaking. He also spoke to us about it. So it's not as if there isn't a lot of discussion about this. And why wouldn't the Prime Minister listen to the 65 per cent of this country? They are the future, the next in line. The children at Jantar Mantar or in colleges are at a sensitive age where anyone can mislead them. But this movement should not go in another direction. It shouldn't be politically affected; countless other slogans shouldn't appear there. Children also get troubled, that the movement they came for, only their voice should remain, only that one demand should be raised. And others should not change their course. I can say with conviction that all of the children's demands will be met.

Pooja Pillai: You are also an actor and have acted in 760 films across languages.

I am the only actor who has worked in all languages. And pan-Indian. I am as popular as I am in Bihar, UP, or Northern India.

Pooja Pillai: And you began your career in Bhojpuri cinema.

I began my career first in Hindi cinema. In fact I began with theatre first. My first film came out in 1992. I did a film with Kajol. It was titled *Udhnaar Ki Zindagi*, which was released in 1994. Then with Akshay Kumar (*Zakhmi Dil* in 1994) and a film with Dhanendra (*Agne Mohan* in 1997). We (Akshay Kumar and Kajol) were all from the same batch of the '90s. I am a professionally trained actor in Urdu, horse riding, jumping, and leaping from buildings... I wanted to (learn) because I am fond of languages. I have a great passion for learning languages.

Pooja Pillai: It was Bhojpuri cinema where you got your stardom. But then you have done these very interesting films like *Laapataa Ladies* and a show like *Maamla Legal Hai*. Can you talk a little bit about this varied journey and how has your approach changed through these different mediums and languages?

My father is a priest and I come from a very humble background. I had neither a godfather nor money. But I had knowledge, spiritual power and strength. When I came to the city, then known as Bombay, the city of dreams, I found it very expensive. I am a dreamer and believe that through the power of manifestation, you can fulfil your dreams. I wanted to become a superstar, have luxuries and cars, and be known across the country. I always wanted to be number one. For that, I worked very hard and trained myself so I wouldn't fall short anywhere—voice, language, dance, performance, action, diction or modulation. I didn't think that because I was six feet tall and had big eyes, I would become an artist. I prepared and polished myself before starting my journey. For the first 15 years, I worked very little. I just asked people for work. They would say, 'Either take work or take money.' I chose work because I knew money follows success. Then I got tired. I did *Army* (1996) with Shah Rukh Khan and *Tere Naam* (2003) with Salman Khan, but it still felt like a very long journey. That's when I got an offer for a

ON TOUGHER ANTI-PAPER LEAK LAWS

If the Opposition is ready for dialogue, there should be such a strict law that no one dares to leak papers. There should be life imprisonment because you are playing with the lives of many



ON DONATION THEFT AND ITS IMPACT ON UPELECTIONS

The donation theft will not affect UP elections. Those eight people were caught, an SIT was formed by Yogi. Lord Ram is our deity and the trust of 100 crore Hindus remains unaffected



'Social media has emerged as a big, unknown power... It can create and it can also destroy overnight'

Actor and MP Ravi Kishan on Jantar Mantar protests, censorship, UP elections and his journey as an actor and politician. The conversation was moderated by Pooja Pillai, Senior Assistant Editor, *The Indian Express*. This session was held on July 24



Actor and MP Ravi Kishan (right) in conversation with Pooja Pillai, Senior Assistant Editor, *The Indian Express*. Renuka Puri

Bhojpuri film. I called my mother and told her no one watched Bhojpuri films. She said, 'No problem, just do it: the villages will see it.' I did *Saiyuan Hamar* (2003), and it became a cult classic. I became an overnight superstar in Bihar and UP. Then I decided to build the Bhojpuri industry. Using everything I had learnt in Hindi cinema, I created my own industry, gave employment to one lakh people, and helped build Bhojpuri cinema. One of our films, *Kab Hot Gawni Hamar* (2008), won a National Award. Then I became a parliamentarian, so my time and attention went there. Later, Hindi cinema came back into my life through Kiran Rao's *Laapataa Ladies*, which polished me. Recently, *Maa Behen* (2026) did well. I play a pirate in Ajay Devgn's *Dhamaal 4*, and *Maamla Legal Hai* is also there. Last year, I won the Best Supporting Actor award for *Laapataa Ladies* and the Best Parliamentary award. I think I'm the only parliamentarian to have won both. I have raised many questions from Uttar Pradesh in my second term, so I might win the Best Parliamentary award again.

Liz Mathew: As a leader, do you feel you can speak to the leadership during a crisis? Many BJP MPs privately feel things are sometimes not right, including over the current student protests. After 12 years in government, how much does the leadership listen to leaders like you who have their ear to the ground?

They listen to me. I can't speak for others. I stay with the Chief Minister (Yogi Adityanath) a lot. Even yesterday I was with him. I am a mess guy. I am a mess superstar. I have travelled Bihar and UP; there is hardly a village left where haven't shot or where I don't meet people every day. In Gorakhpur, I meet 500 to 1,000 people every day. I have four young children; I have all the 'Gen Z' crowd in my house. I have this fusion in my life. So yes, I have no complaints with my leader-

ship. Whatever I had to say, I have always said it. One day, when I was newly elected, I took time to meet the PM. He had a few questions about the industry. He spoke to me about a few names in the industry — how they think, how they look at the government — because artists are a different breed. Artists in India are more woke because they are well-read. People think they aren't, but they make cinema for the entire country. And they are very sensitive. The PM is a great listener. He received a country in 2014 that was hollowed out, which had to be built. Managing such diversity, such a large population, so many loopholes, and such big scams, is a lot of work. We used to travel abroad earlier too, and now when we travel, it's different. I am seeing it (the changes) in just 12 years. So for me, the leadership is a very good listener. Whatever I need to say, I just walk in and talk.

Liz Mathew: You are known to be close

to the 'Yogi camp'. Does it give you any special protection in the party?

That is because I am a parliamentarian from Gorakhpur, where Yogi served as MP for five consecutive terms and he is now the CM. I am really blessed parliamentarian because I get a budget from both the PM and the CM. And Gorakhpur has seen massive development. Our equation is good. So I am a bridge. There is no pressure. I will talk about party development. I have never had stupid conversations. I have stayed with the world's creative legends, so my exposure and creativity are very good. I don't have any vested interests. I am a happy parliamentarian. I want to do films. I do politics selflessly, from my own pocket. So I don't need anything. I work hard. That is why people call me the 'most viral man in the country', a 'national crust', 'Bihar's Brad Pitt'. What all names I have!

Sandeep Singh: Indian youth used to

be a BJP vote bank. Given this atmosphere in Delhi spreading to the rest of the country, how much concern is there regarding the UP elections?

The children know what the government has done for their families. Those who have come know that roads, electricity, water, and toilets have come to their villages. They are seeing the facilities and the country being upgraded. There are countless contributions for teaching girl children in Uttar Pradesh — from scooters to many other schemes. For girls' education, their fees, their care, their jobs — we have given more than nine lakh government jobs in Uttar Pradesh. We have recruited 2 to 2.5 lakh personnel in the police. This is on record. So there is a lot of trust among the children in UP. I am sure that in this hour of crisis, the pain the children have faced will find a solution through punishment in fast-track courts. The children also understand that the PM is not at fault. The paper leak has happened. The main issue now is that it shouldn't happen again. The children demand that in the future, no NEET candidate's family should be ruined and no child should lose their life. The Prime Minister is fully preparing for that. The children will calm down. I have full faith. There is no such cause for concern. It will not affect the UP elections.

Sandeep Singh: What about the resignation demands?

As a parliamentarian, I will say that it is the decision of the top leadership. It is better if I don't speak on it. If all parliamentarians — Opposition and the Government — come together, then we can easily give life imprisonment to those 13 people and anyone else who makes such a mistake in the future. We should let them rot in jail.

Shubhra Gupta: With the censorship of *Satluq*, how do you view censorship in general? As an artist, how do restrictions on your work affect you?

And what is your view of the CBFC increasingly shaping what filmmakers can make, rather than simply certifying films?

I don't know the details of the case and what objection was raised. There were some court orders from Punjab. I have zero knowledge of it. But I did find out the film came and then was taken down. The Censor Board should have freedom and we filmmakers should also have a responsibility to make cinema very thoughtfully while keeping the entertainment aspect in, but at the same time, we should not hurt any specific caste, society, or community. We shouldn't interfere with spirituality, history or the past. I wanted to watch the movie, but it was taken down. But yes, censorship has affected so many films. It has affected *Dhurandhar*. We were taught a lot of wrong history. We have the right to show that too. Provided we don't hurt anyone's personal feelings. The filmmakers are answerable to society because what we make affects the children and the next generation.

Shubhra Gupta: If someone curbs your speech and says you cannot do this, then what will you say about that?

I will first ask, why? I will also ask what is the mistake? What should I cut and remove? What is the problem? See, there is always a solution. During the Congress regime as well, Kishore Kumar was banned on the radio. If I'm hurting a community, if I'm hurting history or I'm trying to disrupt things if I'm giving a false narrative, I'm giving false messages just to entertain and run my movie, then I will chop it out on my own, because I want my film to come out because a lot of money has been invested.

Jatin Anand: Do you think the Ram Mandir donation theft case will impact the UP elections?

Those eight people were arrested. Our faith is in Lord Ram. He is our deity and the trust or faith of 100 crore Hindus in this country remains unaffected. An SIT was formed immediately by Yogi; those people were caught immediately. And now they will get strict punishment. This will not affect the UP elections because people have a lot of faith in Yogi; people respect him a lot. And sometimes it happens with us too, in our houses as well. Many people turn out to be *nalayak*. With the arrival of digital media and social media, *ab toh sabhi roki kaanph hai*. Earlier, too, many things kept happening in this country. But now the fire that has risen, social media: it can create and it can also destroy overnight. Social media has emerged as a very big unknown power.

Jatin Anand: About the ongoing CJP protest, it's clear that social media influencers have been a major driving force, and much of the reaction online has been critical of the government.

Don't harm the country, Ram money, let your followers increase.

Shubhra Gupta: Amir Khan was also a contender for that role in *Laapataa Ladies* and you were selected. How did you feel?

He wanted to play my character and even got his police uniform stitched. But Kiran Rao, somewhere down the line, made the choice. I had done a film with Anurag Kashyap, *Mukkabaaz* in which I was a Dalit boxer. She had watched that film and she wanted me only. She came to meet me in Delhi, narrated the story in 45 minutes. The budget of the film was only 5 crore. A very small film, it earned some 100-150 crores. After the film released, Amir Khan put out his audition. We missed out at the National Awards. There was no entry. I don't know why.

Niharika Yadav: One of your statements was quite viral on social media where you compare Gorakhpur to Spain. But two days of rain can bring it to a standstill.

Gorakhpur is like a bowl. Earlier, Gorakhpur used to remain completely submerged. There would be outbreaks of encephalitis. Every year, 250 children died from the disease. Murders happened there every day. Kidnappings, rapes happened. Mafia ran that district during SP's (Samajwadi Party) time. We did the Gaudayia canal for Rs 12,000 crore, so we are taking 17 wards out of the water. Nepal releases water, Gorakhpur gets submerged. We are working on a way out. I say Spain because I see it like Spain. In Spain, there is a water body; we have Ramgarh Lake. But we will fix things that need fixing. We will make Gorakhpur like Spain.

Liz Mathew: What excites you most? An election victory or a film award? When you see a film set or when you get into Parliament?

In eight years, the most development stones have been laid in Gorakhpur. There are two cruises in the water there. 14 aircraft run. Right now we are building an airport of 42 acres. There is a 500 crore railway station now. We have AINL. We have a fertiliser plant. 1 lakh crore of work has been done in eight years. We have one Chilliwa Tal. In that, for a 20 megawatt solar plant, we brought 134 crores from Coal India's CSR. The whole of Gorakhpur will get electricity from there. So now, we are using that stagnant water in different ways.



VEHICLE RETAIL SALES ROSE ALMOST 22% TO A RECORD 2.6 MILLION UNITS IN JUNE 2026

Small cars return to fast lane as first-time buyers drive surge

Soumyaendra Barik & Nil Sasi
New Delhi, July 26

INDIA'S AUTOMOBILE market has delivered an unexpected upshift against a gloomy backdrop of elevated fuel prices, uncertainty over the monsoon and concerns among motorists about the ethanol-blending mandate. Overall vehicle retail sales rose almost 22% to a record 2.6 million units in June 2026, while passenger vehicle sales jumped 29% year-on-year to about 410,000 units, the highest recorded for the month.

Within that surge is another surprise: the return of the first-time car buyer, and with it, a revival in small cars that many in the industry believed had been permanently beaten back by the rise of sport utility vehicles.

The clearest indication comes from Maruti Suzuki, the country's largest carmaker and the manufacturer with the widest entry-level portfolio. First-time buyers accounted for 51% of its sales in the fourth quarter of FY26, up from 42% in the first half and 48% in the third quarter. Replacement purchases formed 18% of sales, while households buying an additional car accounted for 3% of total sales.

The numbers are specific to Maruti rather than the entire passenger vehicle industry, but

they offer an important window into the market because of the company's dominance in small cars. They also suggest that the post-pandemic pattern — where existing car-owning households upgraded to larger vehicles while potential new buyers remained priced out — might be beginning to change.

This shift is visible in company sales. Maruti's domestic passenger vehicle dispatches rose nearly 24% in June to 1,47,187 units. Sales of its mini segment, comprising the Alto and S-Presso, increased 78%, while its compact and mid-sized car portfolio grew nearly 16%. Its utility vehicle sales also rose nearly 29%, showing that entry-level cars are returning alongside SUVs rather than replacing them.

Mahindra, which is overwhelmingly focused on SUVs, sold 60,393 utility vehicles domestically in June, up 28%. The passenger vehicle market, therefore, appears to be widening at both ends — aspirational buyers continue to purchase larger vehicles, while price-sensitive households are starting to enter the car market again.

GST tailwind

Part of this growth momentum is because of the GST 2.0 tailwinds, which seem to be continuing, given that June

• AUTO REVIVAL

MARUTI'S DOMESTIC passenger vehicle dispatches rose nearly 24% in June to 1,47,187 units. Sales of its mini segment, comprising the Alto and S-Presso, increased 78%.

FIRST-TIME BUYERS accounted for 51% of its sales in the fourth quarter of FY26, up from 42% in the first half and 48% in the third quarter.

THE HATCHBACK category is doing well again, largely due to lower GST aiding the base entry-



level cars. Alongside SUVs, sedans are also reclaiming their spot higher up in the sales charts

brings up nearly nine months of high growth. The hatchback category is doing well again, largely due to lower GST aiding the base entry-level cars. Alongside SUVs, sedans are also reclaiming their spot higher up in the sales charts. The cut lowered up nearly nine months of high growth. The hatchback category is doing well again, largely due to lower GST aiding the base entry-level cars. Alongside SUVs, sedans are also reclaiming their spot higher up in the sales charts.

Many of these consumers are two-wheeler owners upgrading to their first car. For such households, the buying challenge is shaped less by additional features and road presence but by purchase price, mileage, maintenance costs and

access to service centres. Small hatchbacks, which had steadily lost ground as prices rose and manufacturers prioritised more profitable SUVs, remain the most accessible bridge between two-wheeler and car ownership.

That bridge had weakened considerably over the past few years. Rising input costs, stricter safety and emissions requirements, and the withdrawal of several entry-level models had pushed up the minimum price of car ownership. At the same time, buyers who could afford a car increasingly stretched their budgets for compact SUVs, attracted by their higher seating position, styling and features.

Rural momentum

Rural India has been central to the recovery. Passenger vehicle registrations in rural markets grew by more than 35% year-on-year in June, outpacing the 24.7% increase in urban centres, according to data compiled by the Federation of Automobile Dealers Associations (FADA). Better rural demand, access to financing and wider dealership networks have combined with the GST benefit to bring customers back to showrooms. Urban markets, which had remained weak earlier, also recovered after the tax reduction.

The June numbers also point to rapid change in what powers the vehicles Indians buy. Electric, hybrid and compressed natural gas vehicles together accounted for 40% of passenger vehicle retail sales, up from around 38% in May. CNG alone comprised 24.3%, hybrids 8.3% and electric vehicles 7.5%, as elevated petrol and diesel prices strengthened the case for lower running costs.

The momentum was visible beyond cars. Two-wheeler sales returned to double-digit growth, three-wheeler registrations rose 16.2%, and tractors recorded their second-best June, despite the promise of a weak monsoon, underscoring the breadth of the demand recovery.

Trump's tariff threat on generics: Why it matters for Indian pharma firms

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, July 26

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump on Tuesday (July 21) said that tariffs on generic drugs in the US will be raised 100% after two years and to 200% thereafter to "reshore" generic pharmaceutical production in the US, adding that companies deciding against building plants in the US will be "penalised".

Trump's threat comes after several such ultimatums, largely designed to attract investment in the US. Actual tariffs on drugs have been exempted in most tariff instruments his administration has used, starting with those under the International Emergency Economic Powers Act, Section 122 of the 1974 Trade Act, and Section 232 of the Trade Expansion Act of 1962.

Here's why this assumes significance for India and how Indian pharma giants are already changing tack in terms of investments in the US.

Boosting investments in the US

On at least two occasions, Trump had threatened tariffs on medicines despite pushback from the industry. On April 2 this year, he announced tariffs of up to 100% on specified branded medicines starting July 31 under the Section 232 framework that invokes national security. On September 25, 2025, he announced plans for a 100% tariff on imported branded and patented medicines, but neither proposal has been implemented yet.

• PHARMA PUSH

THE US is India's largest pharma export market, accounting for nearly 40% of exports, with about 90% of shipments comprising generics

SUN PHARMA, India's largest pharma company, announced the acquisition of US-listed Organon & Co. for \$11.8 bn. This is an Indian pharma company's largest overseas acquisition to date.

Trade and investment experts said that these threats are largely aimed at pushing global pharma giants to boost investments in Washington, rather than increasing tariffs on drugs, which could trigger a backlash for the Trump administration, especially weeks before the mid-term elections.

This assumes significance for India as the US is India's largest market for pharmaceutical exports, accounting for an almost 40% share.

Around 90% of India's pharmaceutical exports to the US are generics. In 2025, India exported \$9.7 billion worth of pharmaceuticals to the US. The US imported \$21.5 billion worth of pharmaceutical products in 2025, including \$94.1 billion of finished medicines starting July 31 under the Section 232 framework that invokes national security. On September 25, 2025, he announced plans for a 100% tariff on imported branded and patented medicines, but neither proposal has been implemented yet.

largest pharma company, announced the acquisition of US-listed Organon & Co. for \$11.8 billion. This is an Indian pharmaceutical company's largest overseas acquisition to date.

Rising outbound investments

The outbound investments for pharma during the ongoing financial year, as per official data, is the highest compared with the last four years combined. As per the Commerce Ministry's reply to a Lok Sabha question on Tuesday, outbound investment from India to the US stood at \$4.08 billion in FY26, up from \$3.44 billion in FY25 and \$2.44 billion in FY24. Apart from the pharma sector, which could trigger a backlash for the Trump administration, especially weeks before the mid-term elections, India's steel companies are also stepping up investment in the US. Last month, US Ambassador to India, Sergio Gor, said that JSW Steel's \$500 million investment plans in Ohio and Texas would strengthen the India-US partnership.

A report by the research firm Global Trade Research Initiative (GTRI) said that several leading Indian drug makers already manufacture in the US. Sun Pharma, Zydus Lifesciences, Lupin, Aurobindo Pharma, Cipla and Reddy's Laboratories operate US-based manufacturing facilities approved by the country's Food and Drug Administration. Cipla is expanding production at plants in Massachusetts and New York, while Dr Reddy's Laboratories is willing to increase US manufacturing if it makes commercial sense, GTRI said. **FULL REPORT ON** WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Insurers seek first third-party premium hike in four years

George Mathew
Mumbai, July 26

NON-LIFE INSURERS are pushing for a revision in motor third-party premiums, the first in four years, as losses mount in the segment. Apart from underwriting losses in the Rs 1 lakh crore plus motor segment, the bottom line of insurers was also affected by a recent Supreme Court judgement on the calculation of the economic value of unpaid domestic work done by homemakers, which increased the cost of computing compensation.

The last implemented hike in third-party motor insurance premiums in India was effective from June 1, 2022. The revised base premium rates were notified by the Ministry of Road Transport & Highways (MoRTH), based on recommendations from the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI). Before 2022, third-party premiums had largely remained unchanged during the Covid-19 period (FY21 and FY22), with the government freezing rates to ease the burden on vehicle owners.

"The Motor Third Party line of business continued to be under pressure as there was no premium increase and claims inflation pressure continued. The significant spike in motor TP loss ratio had a severe adverse impact on the results. The industry is looking forward to a hike in Motor Third Party pre-

The recent judgment delivered by the SC on June 11 recognises the economic value of unpaid domestic work performed by homemakers while determining compensation under the Motor Vehicles Act

mium," said New India Assurance Chairman-cum-Managing Director Girija Subramanian. New India Assurance reported a higher underwriting loss of Rs 1,297.17 crore in the motor segment in the first quarter of FY27, compared with a loss of Rs 824.58 crore in the same period last year. It reported an operating loss of Rs 1,264.99 crore in the motor segment in the June quarter of FY27, compared with a profit of Rs 182.28 crore a year ago. The company reported an overall consolidated net loss of Rs 243.94 crore, compared with a profit of Rs 392.40 crore in the year-ago period.

An underwriting loss in motor insurance happens when an insurer pays out more in claims than it collects in premium from vehicle owners.

The recent judgement delivered on June 11, 2026 by the Supreme Court of India has re-

cognised the economic value of unpaid domestic work performed by homemakers while determining compensation under the Motor Vehicles Act. "This judgement provides for compensation under a distinct head, 'Loss of Domestic Care' based on a monthly income of Rs 30,000, with periodic increases to reflect inflation and socio-economic changes. Based on a preliminary assessment of the impact of this judgement, the Motor TP loss ratio of the industry is expected to increase in the range of 12% to 15%," said Sanjeev Mantri, MD and CEO, ICICI Lombard. "Given the significance of the judgement impacting motor TP portfolio of the industry, an upward revision of motor TP premium rates becomes both necessary and urgent in order to restore premium adequacy. That being said, the General Insurance Council has also filed a revision petition seeking review of the order," Mantri said last week while announcing the quarterly results.

ICICI Lombard, which reported a 46% decline in net profit for the June quarter, has, on a prudent and conservative basis, recognised claim reserves amounting to Rs 165 crore in the current quarter on the premium earned during the quarter following the Supreme Court judgement.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM



Finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman inaugurated 'Aayakar Sindhu', a new Income Tax Office Complex at Nariman Point, Mumbai, on Sunday. Ravi Agrawal, Chairman, CBDT, and other I-T department officials were present. **X/GENITHARAMAN**

Budget has buffers to absorb inflation risks: FM

Bengaluru: Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Sunday said there was no immediate need to revise the budget estimates despite risks from erratic monsoons and higher global oil prices, as the government had set aside sufficient buffers to absorb potential shocks.

Inflation is being driven by both external factors and erratic monsoon conditions, the

finance minister said. She said *EI Niño* was posing challenges for crop irrigation and drinking water availability. Less-than-normal monsoon rainfall could also push up prices, she added.

The government has created sufficient buffers to meet potential fiscal challenges, and Sitharaman does not expect to readjust the budget numbers at this stage. **REUTERS**

CBDT issues crypto asset reporting note aligned with OECD framework

Aanchal Magazine
New Delhi, July 26

THE CENTRAL Board of Direct Taxes (CBDT) has come out with a 198-page guidance note on crypto-asset reporting obligations in a move that will help in global sharing of information on crypto transactions from next year. The guidance note has been released in line with the crypto asset reporting framework (CARF) outlined by the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) putting greater onus on crypto exchanges for providing transactional information about crypto assets.

The CBDT said that guidance note intends to provide guidance to Reporting Crypto-Asset Service Providers (RCASPs) for compliance with the reporting obligations under section 509 of the Income-tax Act, 2025, and under Rules 241 to 244 and Form 167 of the Income-tax Rules, 2026. However, it pointed out that nothing in the guidance note and FAQs should be construed as affecting the permissibility, or the legitimacy of the transactions in crypto-assets as well as regulation for transactions in crypto-assets.

In the note's foreword, CBDT

Chairman Ravi Agrawal said the rapid growth of crypto-assets has brought with it a fresh challenge even as India's commitment to combating tax evasion and protecting its revenue base has remained steadfast. The note will help RCASPs in understanding and discharging their obligations under the Income-tax Act and Income-tax Rules in a clear and practical manner, he added.

The CARF defines "Crypto-Assets" as "a digital representation of value that relies on a cryptographically secured distributed ledger or a similar technology to validate and secure transactions", which includes cryptocurrencies, as well as cryptocurrency-based tokens.

The framework is expected to bring tax transparency to the crypto-asset sector as it will impose obligations on a new subset of service providers, RCASPs, which are the service providers collecting and reporting information on transactions of crypto-assets. The CARF requires RCASPs to identify their users and to report on specified transactions, with a view to ensuring the annualised reporting of tax-relevant information concerning certain activities in relation to crypto-assets, the note said.

Once received by tax authorities, the information will be automatically exchanged with the tax authorities of the jurisdiction(s) of residence of the crypto-asset users, pursuant to an international agreement that provides a legal basis for the automatic exchange of such information for tax purposes, the note added.

Experts said though there is no additional filing requirement for taxpayers under this guidance note, the importance of accurate reporting and documentation has increased considerably because the tax authorities will have greater access to transaction-level information. "Taxpayers should continue reporting crypto income in accordance with the existing provisions of the Income-tax Act; maintain proper records of purchases, sales, transfers and wallet movements; preserve exchange statements and supporting documentation; and ensure that the information disclosed in their income-tax return is consistent with the records available with crypto exchanges," Amit Agarwal, Senior Partner, Nagaria & Co LLP said. **FULL REPORT ON** WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

• THE ODYSSEY IS THE FIRST FEATURE FILM SHOT ENTIRELY WITH IMAX FILM IN THE LARGE-SCALE FORMAT

With Nolan's Odyssey taming camera noise, IMAX bets bigger on India

Anil Sasi
New Delhi, July 26

"A SEWING machine in a fight with a stapler" — that's how Matt Damon, who plays the lead role in Christopher Nolan's adaptation of the film version of Homer's *The Odyssey*, described the sound of the IMAX cameras rolling and the clatter created by the mechanism that pulled the film past the shutter.

The loud din prevented sync sound capture (the process of recording audio at precisely the same time as video) and was one of the two major challenges of this filming format, the other being that the IMAX camera needed to stop and be reloaded every two-and-a-half minutes or so. Given that the format is so huge, this is the most film the camera can hold at one time, making filming a constant stop-

and-go exercise.

Tech breakthrough

For *The Odyssey*, Nolan inspired the IMAX Corporation — the Canadian production theatre company that designs and manufactures cameras and projection systems — to engineer a soundproof enclosure for housing the camera, which, while being massive and cumbersome, worked to cut down the din by a third. According to Preetham Daniel, VP, Theatre Development, India, South East Asia and Australasia at IMAX, this new breakthrough blimp technology will likely be used by more filmmakers in the future.

"There was an extensive process to develop the new blimp technology, which was a critical piece of the production on *The Odyssey*. We anticipate this will be used extensively by future film-

makers, as it addresses one of the main challenges of shooting with IMAX Film Cameras, enabling for the first time sync sound capture," Daniel told *The Indian Express*.

The Odyssey is the first feature film shot entirely with IMAX film in the large-scale format, which uses considerably more film than standard 35mm cameras. Nolan has said he used more than 2 million feet — or over 600 km — of film for shooting the movie over 91 days.

Each frame has resolution or image quality up to three times higher than digital. Production challenges included the limited options in processing and colour correction, given the handful of production intermediaries in the business that can handle the requirements of this format. Photochem in Burbank, California, for instance, is the only mo-



Christopher Nolan said he used more than 2 million feet — or over 600 km — of film for shooting the movie over 91 days. **X/GENITHARAMAN**

tion picture film lab in the world that still produces 70 millimeter (mm) prints and the production crew had to rely on this one lab for getting the processing done.

The strip of film used in the format is the highest quality imaging format that's ever been devised, entailing a massive negative, which, when correctly

exposed, printed, and projected onto a huge screen, offers unmatched image quality. Both in terms of unparalleled sharpness and very little visible grain — yielding an image resolution equivalent to 18K and an imposing 14:31 aspect ratio. The aspect ratio refers to the proportions between the width and height of the image displayed, and a 14:31 essentially lends itself to a near squarish display. Common aspect ratios for non-IMAX formats are 1.85:1 and 2.39:1, which is far more rectangular from a display perspective.

India's IMAX gap

India, however, shall only be screening digital versions of the film across the various IMAX screens operated across the country. While the most 'IMAX theatres' in India offer bigger screens, and brighter projection

than regular theatres, they are not in a position to project the taller, squarish film prints that the native analog format entails and instead have to rely on purely digital formats displayed in retrofitted theatres. IMAX's proprietary system of high-resolution cameras, film formats, film projectors work best in theatres having steep stadium-style seating and large screens with a tall aspect ratio.

India does not have any commercial cinema equipped to screen the movie in its original IMAX 70mm version. But the Ontario-based, NYSE-listed firm, which has grown significantly in India by expanding its footprint by almost 60% since 2020 to 34 locations, plans to double down on its success here. India has ranked among IMAX's top ten markets for the past decade, and 2025 marked IMAX India's best-

ever box office year with a record haul of \$26 million, including \$8 million from global content.

"India is an incredibly important part of IMAX's growth strategy, and a priority global market. We've already made incredible strides in the country — our network in the country has grown by nearly 60% since 2020 with a handful more locations contracted to open this year, and has consistently been one of our top global markets for box office. IMAX is also dramatically expanding our Filmed for IMAX program in India, including the highly-anticipated *Ramayan* — Part I and *Vaaram*, showcasing a continued demand from audiences and filmmakers in India for IMAX. We plan to lean in and continue to build on our existing momentum in the market to fuel further expansion," Daniel said.

Israel to allow international force into Gaza, says official

Reuters
July 26

ISRAELI WILL allow a multinational security force to enter Gaza as proposed under US President Donald Trump's ceasefire plan for the enclave, an Israeli official said on Sunday, a day before Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu heads to Washington.

Netanyahu's security cabinet on Sunday approved the legal framework that would allow the force's entry to Gaza,

the official said.

The official said that the mission, called the International Stabilization Force, will include 200 members from "friendly countries such as Uganda and Morocco" deploying in areas that are not under Israeli control.

Each contingent requires individual Israeli approval to enter Gaza. It was unclear when the forces would deploy.

Much of Gaza remains in ruins from two years of full-scale war triggered by the

Hamas-led attacks on Israel on October 7, 2023.

Mosques attacked

Meanwhile, Israeli settlers attacked Palestinian villages in the occupied West Bank early on Sunday, setting fire to two mosques and scrawling graffiti on buildings, Palestinian officials said.

The attacks followed an incident Friday when four Palestinians and two Israeli soldiers, one of them acting as a security coordinator for an Israeli settle-



A man inspects the damage at a mosque in West Bank on Sunday.

ment, were killed when a crowd of Israeli settlers, some armed, approached Palestinian village

of Tal, southwest of Nablus. During the incident, villagers came out of their homes to confront settlers and stand-off ensued, with video appearing to show one of the Palestinians grabbing a settler's weapon. Palestinian local authorities say settlers provoked violence.

The incident was latest in a growing series of clashes involving settlers in which dozens of Palestinians have been killed and hundreds wounded, according to figures from UN and Palestinian Authority.



From Space To Home

NASA astronaut Christopher Williams (left) and Roscosmos cosmonauts Sergei Kud-Sverchikov (centre) and Sergei Mikaev sit on chairs shortly after exiting the Soyuz MS-28 spacecraft following their landing near Zhezkazgan, Kazakhstan, on Sunday. The US-Russian crew safely returned to Earth after spending 241 days aboard the International Space Station. AP

U.S. ENVOY TO UN SAYS TRUMP 'GIVING TALKS SOME SPACE'; IRAN, OMAN NEGOTIATE ON STRAIT SHIPPING

Ukraine's attack on vessel 'can't go unanswered', says Araghchi

US pauses attacks for 2nd straight day, Iran does too



Reuters
July 26

IRANIAN FOREIGN Minister Abbas Araghchi said on Sunday a Ukrainian attack on an Iranian commercial vessel "cannot go unanswered".

Iran said the attack in the Caspian Sea resulted in an explosion that killed one sailor and injured another. Araghchi made the comments in calls with EU foreign policy chief Kaja Kallas and Russian Foreign Minister Sergei Lavrov.

Lavrov, in a statement posted on the Russian Foreign Ministry's website, offered condolences in connection with the death of a sailor in the attack. Araghchi thanked local authorities in the Russian region of Astrakhan, for helping the crew "and stressed the need to put an end to such adventures by the Kyiv regime".

The statement said Araghchi informed Lavrov of "continuing diplomatic efforts aimed at de-escalating tension in West Asia".

Associated Press
Cairo, July 26

THE UNITED STATES paused its attacks on Iran for a second straight day Sunday and Tehran said it had done so too, as efforts continue to bring the countries back to negotiations on an interim ceasefire deal.

It was not clear why the US had paused after targeting Iranian coastal areas and infrastructure in a nearly two-week escalation sparked by Iran's firing at ships trying to transit the Strait of Hormuz.

The Pentagon did not respond to questions Sunday. US President Donald Trump's "giving talks some space. He's giving it a little bit of room," Mike Waltz, the US Ambassador to the UN, told Fox News. "We've had both Oman and Iran... engaged at every level, from most senior levels all the way down to technical level over past few weeks, and particularly in past few days."

Since the US has halted attacks for the past two nights, Iran has as well, its army spokesperson told Iran's state TV on Sunday. Tehran in recent days has counterattacked against countries in the region hosting



US military helicopters and personnel take part in operations to enforce a naval blockade against Iran in Arabian Sea. @CENTCOM, REUTERS

US military forces, killing at least three at a base in Jordan.

A regional official involved in mediation efforts said diplomacy was underway and that a pause in US and Iranian strikes was "a positive signal that helps their efforts to de-escalate."

The official said both countries want to return to the interim ceasefire deal and that a compromise being negotiated centres on having Iran run vessel transit through the Strait with fewer restrictions on ships.

Concerns continued about shipping on the strait and now

on another crucial waterway in the region, the Bab al-Mandeb strait to the Red Sea. Iranian-backed Houthi rebels in Yemen last week threatened a blockade of Saudi shipping there.

Iran on Sunday said it continued to speak with Oman about managing safe passage of ships on the Strait, which passes between the countries. Iran's Foreign Ministry spokesperson Esmail Baghaei said talks had made progress and continued.

Baghaei also said the Strait's status remained unchanged. "Tehran has asserted the in-

terim deal with the US allows it to manage shipping on the waterway for now, and it has objected to US efforts to support a route through the strait that passes close to Oman instead.

The US military Saturday said it recently reimposed naval blockade against Iran continued, with a dozen commercial ships redirected, two disabled and two boarded. US forces "remain highly vigilant, focused and ready," it added.

Meanwhile, Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu plans to travel to US and meet with Trump in Washington on Tuesday, his office has said. Netanyahu on Sunday told Fox News he "fully" backs Trump's efforts to weaken Iran and press it to end its nuclear program, adding: "If we can do so without returning to intense military fighting, that's fine. Why not?"

The PM indicated he would not present new information to "our good friend" Trump and instead would listen to "what he has in mind, because I think in many ways, it's his decision." But Netanyahu warned that if Iran again attacks Israel, directly or with armed proxies, "it will make a terrible mistake."

Kyiv hit with missiles; Russia, Ukraine report civilians killed in strikes

Reuters
Kyiv, July 26

THE UKRAINIAN capital Kyiv came under ballistic missile attack from Russian forces early Sunday, while other regions suffered bombardments later during the day that killed two people.

Russia, for its part, said four people were killed by a Ukrainian drone strike in the Russian-occupied Ukrainian city of Horlivka.

Ukraine's air force said Russian forces had targeted the capital with ballistic missiles, as explosions rocked the city.

In its morning note, the air force said Russia had launched seven ballistic missiles and 136 drones at Ukraine overnight.

In the eastern city of Kharkiv, one person was killed and twelve others required medical attention after a daytime drone attack. Meanwhile, a glide bomb attack killed one person and wounded six in the southern city of Zaporizhzhia, which has been under heavy bombardment in recent months.

Kyiv Mayor Vitali Klitschko said one blaze had broken out on the seventh and eighth floors of a multi-storey apartment block in a central district after the overnight missile attack.

Three people were wounded in the capital, and unofficial social media channels showed footage of fires burning.

President Volodymyr Zelenskyy had warned on Friday that Russian attacks were likely over the next 48 hours.

In Horlivka, a city in the Russian-occupied part of Ukraine's Donetsk province, Russian-installed Mayor Ivan Prikhodko said four civilians had been killed in a Ukrainian drone strike, Russia's TASS news agency reported.

On Saturday, Russian-installed authorities accused Ukraine of deliberately attacking civilians after 12 people were killed in a drone attack on a holiday camp in a Russian-held part of Ukraine's Zaporizhzhia.

Both Russia and Ukraine deny targeting civilians in the war launched by Russia's full-scale invasion in February 2022.

Romania shoots down 3rd Russian drone, president slams breaches as 'intolerable'

Bucharest: A Romanian F-16 fighter jet pilot shot down a Russian drone over the Black Sea, the defence ministry said Sunday, the latest in a series of breaches of the NATO member's airspace that President Nicușor Dan called "intolerable and intolerable".

Romania shares a 650-km land border with Ukraine and Russian drones have repeatedly violated its airspace during the more than four-year Ukraine war. Moscow is now stepping up attacks on Ukrainian ports across the Danube River.

Romania had not destroyed any drones until Friday when a Romanian pilot was able to safely bring one down in an uninhabited area. It has now shot down three in as many days.

"It is inadmissible and intolerable for the Russian Federation to continue violating Romania's airspace, which is, at the same time, NATO airspace and European Union airspace," Dan wrote on X on Sunday. REUTERS

10 killed, thousands affected as Typhoon Noul hits south China

Press Trust of India
Beijing, July 26

TEN PEOPLE were killed in rain-triggered floods in China as Typhoon Noul made landfall early Sunday in the southern province of Guangdong.

Noul, the 12th and the strongest typhoon to hit China so far this year, made landfall at Huizhou city in Guangdong around 3:50 am, bringing gale-force winds and heavy rain to large parts of the region.

Rain-triggered flash floods killed 10 in China's Guangxi region, state-run Xinhua news agency reported.

China's National Commission for Disaster Prevention, Reduction and Relief activated a Level-IV national disaster relief emergency response for Guangdong. Level-IV is the least severe tier in the four-tier emergency response system. Level I is the most critical/severe.

High-speed rail services and flights across Guangdong province were cancelled on Sunday after Typhoon Noul made land-

fall in the province, bringing heavy rainfall to large parts of southern China.

The National Meteorological Centre issued its first red alert for a typhoon this year on Saturday evening. The alert was downgraded to orange and later to yellow on Sunday as Typhoon Noul weakened. Red is the highest alert in China's four-tier, colour-coded warning system, in which blue is the lowest level.

The typhoon packed winds of up to 162 kilometres per hour, slightly stronger than Typhoon Bavi, which struck eastern and northeastern China about two weeks ago, the Hong Kong-based South China Morning Post reported.

A working team has been dispatched to the affected areas to assess the situation and assist local authorities in relocating and resettling residents, besides ensuring their basic living needs.

The National Development and Reform Commission also allocated about \$14.7 million from the central budget to support the post-disaster recovery efforts.

Bangladesh to probe corruption charges against former president

Dhaka: Bangladesh's former president Mohammed Shahabuddin, who resigned two days ago, will be probed for alleged corruption allegations, Law Minister Mohammad Asaduzzaman said on Sunday.

The 76-year-old Shahabuddin, a longtime ally of deposed prime minister Sheikh Hasina, resigned on Friday, citing health complications, two years ahead of the end of his tenure.

His resignation comes amid speculations that Prime Minister Tarique Rahman's government was uncomfortable with the largely titular head of the state.

"The government does not want to do injustice against any person. But the allegations of corruption before his assumption of presidency are being scrutinised thoroughly," Law Minister Asaduzzaman told reporters in Chattogram.

He said that due to public demand, legal action would be taken following investigations into the allegations against the former president. PTI

Suspect in Berlin Pride attack shot dead during operation, say police

Reuters
Berlin, July 26

BERLIN POLICE shot dead the suspect being sought over the Pride attack in the German capital, they said on X, after he tried to attack them with a bladed weapon at an allotment garden complex in the suburb of Spandau.

"According to initial findings, he ran towards officers while armed with a bladed weapon; police subsequently opened fire. Despite immediate resuscitation efforts by the fire department, he died at the scene," police wrote.

The attack happened in the Tiergarten park near the Brandenburg Gate at about 10 pm on Saturday, not far from one of Europe's biggest annual LGBTQ+ celebrations, Christopher Street Day. One person was killed and 29 were injured, authorities said.

Berlin police had identified the suspect as Abdul B. Zi, and published his picture, asking the public for information on his whereabouts. "Everything we see here indicates that we



Police search the area on Sunday after the incident in which a vehicle crashed into a crowd near Berlin's Pride parade. REUTERS

are dealing with an Islamist terrorist attack," Interior Minister Alexander Dobrindt told reporters at the scene.

The suspect had "attracted attention in the past through a high number of criminal offences, through radicalisation, through membership of the Islamist scene," Dobrindt said earlier, adding he was a German citizen of Lebanese heritage, born in Germany in 2005. It was the latest in a series of

• BRIEFLY

UNITED NATIONS

Ugandan diplomat Otunnu joins race to become next UN chief



Ugandan diplomat Olara Otunnu. FILE

UGANDAN DIPLOMAT Olara Otunnu has joined the contest to become the next secretary-general of the United Nations, the seventh contender to succeed Antonio Guterres when he steps down at the end of this year. Otunnu, a former UN under-secretary-general who served as a special representative for children and armed conflict, was nominated by Uganda in a letter on Friday to the presidents of UN General Assembly and Security Council. REUTERS

PERU

5 dead, 16 injured as 2 buses collide

TWO BUSES crashed into each other Saturday in south Peru killing at least five and injuring another 16, authorities said. It was "immediately clear what caused the crash. Eddy Vicente, director of the Hipólito Unzué de Tacna hospital, said the majority of those injured are stable, while another man is in serious condition. AP

UNITED KINGDOM

Gatwick airport hit by water crisis

A POWER outage at a water treatment plant in south east England left toilets out of order and forced the closure of restaurants at Gatwick Airport on Sunday. The airport apologized on X for the inconvenience to passengers using both terminals. The airport said it was providing bottled water, though some passengers disputed that. AP

• THE UNESCO COMMITTEE ALSO INSCRIBED ANCIENT JAPANESE CAPITALS OF ASUKA & FUJIWARA AND SOUTH SUDAN'S BOMA-BADINGILO MIGRATORY LANDSCAPE, HOST TO ONE OF WORLD'S LARGEST LAND MAMMAL MIGRATIONS

UNESCO adds France's D-Day landing beaches, Greece's Mount Olympus to Heritage List

Kim Tong-Hyung
Seoul, July 26

WORLD WAR II's D-Day landing beaches in northern France and the iconic Mount Olympus in Greece were among the sites added to the World Heritage List on Sunday at a U committee meeting in South Korea reviewing dozens of nominations.

The UNESCO committee, which meets in Busan through Wednesday, also inscribed the ancient Japanese capitals of Asuka and Fujiwara and South Sudan's Boma-Badingilo Migratory Landscape, host to one of the world's largest land mammal migrations and the country's first addition to the

World Heritage List.

The French designation covers the five Normandy landing beaches — Omaha, Utah, Sword, Gold and Juno — where more than 150,000 Allied troops came ashore on June 6, 1944, along with the Pointe du Hoc assault site, all central to the campaign to liberate Western Europe from Nazi occupation during World War II.

International Council on Monuments and Sites, which evaluates submissions to the heritage committee, said the sites contain extensive remnants, from German fortifications and bomb-scarred landscapes to Allied harbor structures and sunken vessels,

marking an "event widely perceived as having enabled the return of freedom and heralded a lasting peace on the European continent."

ICOMOS also called for stronger monitoring and preservation efforts on the sites, citing potential threats posed by tourism, climate change and rising sea levels, and the development of wind farms near the areas.



The Stefani Peak, known as the "Throne of Zeus," at sunrise on Mount Olympus; US infantrymen land at Normandy after the 1944 D-Day invasion of France. AP

Ahlem Gharbi, France's permanent delegate to UNESCO, said the Normandy landings marked a turning point from global conflict toward a post-war order built on peace and security, and that the designation of the sites carries added significance at a time of escalating

international crises and wars. "It's probably the greatest amphibious landing there's ever been. I thought to be remembered



for that alone," historian David Edgerton said in a recent interview with The Associated Press. The World Heritage inscription

of Mount Olympus, the mythical home of the 12 Olympian gods, rewarded a 12-year effort by Greece to secure recognition for its tallest mountain as a mixed cultural and natural heritage site. Rising 2,918 meters (9,573 feet) from a base near sea level, the mountain was believed to be the throne of Zeus, king of the gods, while also harboring rich biodiversity.

Evangelos Geroliotis, mayor of Dion-Olympus, a municipality at the foot of the mountain, said in a recent interview with the AP that inclusion on the World Heritage List "places greater obligations on our part to protect this environment," citing the potential impact of increased tourism.

"We reaffirm our unwavering commitment to safeguarding Mount Olympus for the

benefit of present and future generations," said Georgios Koumoutsakos, Greece's delegate to UNESCO. "As Greek mythology wisely reminds us, it is always best to remain on good terms with gods."

The designated Japanese locations in the western prefecture of Nara cover 19 archaeological sites from the 6th- to 8th-century capitals of Asuka and Fujiwara, where Japan established its first centralized state modeled after Chinese systems.

These sites preserve the largely buried remains of royal palaces, government offices, Buddhist temples and tombs from capitals that influenced the later capitals of Nara and Kyoto. AP

{ WEEKLY CAPSULE }

Canned juice linked to high BP

DRINKING FRUIT juice and sugar-sweetened beverages regularly from childhood into adulthood may increase the likelihood of developing high blood pressure later in life, according to research published by the American Heart Association. Participants who consumed two or more servings of sugar-sweetened beverages each day had a 52 per cent higher risk of developing high blood pressure later in life compared with those who drank fewer than three servings per week. Each daily serving of soda was associated with a 23 per cent higher risk, while that of sports drinks was linked to a 36 per cent higher risk.

**Magic mushrooms reshape brain**

ASINGLE DOSE of psilocybin (chemical in mushrooms) produced measurable changes in brain activity and possible changes in brain structure that lasted for up to a month. Participants who experienced the greatest increase in flexible, varied brain activity also reported more personal insight and later improvements in well-being. The findings by researchers at UC San Francisco and Imperial College London suggest that the psychedelic experience itself may help people break free from entrenched patterns of thinking. A month later, participants performed better on a test of cognitive flexibility.

**New strategy to halt cancer**

SMARTER TIMING may be one of the keys to making cancer treatment more effective. A new study by the University of London suggests that doctors could improve cure rates by changing therapies before a tumour has a chance to recover. Rather than waiting for cancer to return after an initial treatment, the researchers propose switching to another therapy while the tumour is still shrinking. The strategy is designed to address one of the biggest obstacles in cancer care: drug resistance. The idea may be helpful for cancers where even the most effective initial treatment frequently fails because of resistance.

**Food that helps vaccine efficacy**

ANATURALLY OCCURRING compound found in foods such as wheat germ, mushrooms and aged cheese may help older adults build stronger protection after vaccination. In a small pilot trial, researchers at the Max Delbrück Center for Molecular Medicine gave spermidine supplements to adults over 65 following their third COVID-19 vaccine dose. The biggest improvements appeared among people whose immune systems initially responded poorly, with higher antibody levels and stronger activity against several variants. Older adults often develop fewer protective antibodies and T cells after receiving a vaccine.

**Old antibiotic revived**

SCIENTISTS HAVE found a way to revive vancomycin, a powerful antibiotic that some dangerous bacteria have learned to resist. Instead of creating an entirely new drug, researchers paired vancomycin with a small molecule called pghi-4, which blocks a bacterial enzyme linked to resistance. The combination restored the antibiotic's ability to kill drug-resistant *E. faecium*, raising hopes that similar chemical helpers could rescue other failing medicines. This is the idea behind antibiotic adjuvants, which are companion molecules that do not kill bacteria directly but instead restore the power of antibiotics.

**CONSULTATION ROOM****DR SK SARIN**

DIRECTOR, ILBS, NEW DELHI

Hepatitis B: Only a treat-all policy can save lives**Low cost generics can safely and effectively suppress the virus lifelong**

THIRTY-SEVEN-YEAR-OLD Anand, an engineer from Begusarai, was admitted to hospital with deep jaundice, liver failure and a small tumour caused by hepatitis B infection. He needed an urgent liver transplantation. Sadly, he was unable to get a donor as his only brother was also found to have the infection. He received his diagnosis nearly 12 years ago but was never put on treatment as he had no symptoms and his liver function tests (LFT) were normal. His death was a stinging pain for me. A life was lost because of inept policies.

Hepatitis B is a DNA virus that causes chronic but silent viral infection of the liver. In 10 per cent of the infected, hepatitis B can remain silent — show no symptoms — yet cause cirrhosis (scarring of the liver), liver failure and liver cancer. Globally, 1.1 million lives were lost due to the infection in 2024 — 17 per cent more than the numbers in 2015. And, in India, around 29 million people live with the infection. Global estimates show that around 15 to 25 per cent of the infected are likely to die due to delayed diagnosis as well as treatment restrictions as seen in the case of Anand. Only three to five per cent of the infected persons get the antiviral drug.

For decades, hepatitis B treatment has been offered only to those who have a high viral load, raised liver enzymes, or scarring or stiffening of the liver. Unfortunately, seven in 10 infected patients do not get the treatment based on these guidelines.

These restrictions may be valid when the treatment is unaffordable or drug resistance is common. When it comes to India, as the pharmacy of the world, the country supplies generic antivirals globally. Potent low cost (less than Rs 1,000/month), once-daily generics, such as tenofovir and entecavir, which are part of the National Viral Hepatitis Control Programme (NVHCP), can safely and effectively suppress the virus life-long.

The theme of this year's World Hepatitis Day (July 28) is 'Let us break it down'. This is good news for the people living with Hepatitis B. The new Asian guidelines released in June 2026 have made very important recommendations. These recommend treatment at any level of detectable hepatitis B DNA and above normal liver enzyme levels, irrespective of scarring. This, in a way, supports 'Treat All' rather than 'Treat Select' policy. This is already true for the country's AIDS control programme, which initiates antiretroviral therapy for any detectable level of viral load. The AIDS programme demonstrates that it is possible.

It would be a matter of pride for India if the NVHCP moves towards early viral suppression and cancer prevention. We should not wait for hepatitis B to produce advanced fibrosis, cirrhosis or liver cancer before offering protection. Some fear that patients without symptoms may not take the drugs regularly. This is ill-founded as more than 75 per cent patients adhere to treatment and reach virus undetectable state. Like the HIV, the treatment should not be stopped.

Another key issue is the social stigma as hepatitis B is often clubbed with HIV.

Marriages break if the wife tests positive for hepatitis B during pregnancy. Job offers are withdrawn, promotions are denied. Students are excluded. Surgery or dental care are refused. Families isolate individuals who pose no risk through ordinary social contact. This injustice is due to sheer ignorance. In India, a majority of hepatitis B infections are transmitted from mother to baby. The infected child can choose their mother, they have no choice but to receive and silently carry the virus. Decades later, once detected, the person is deemed as one with moral failing and shamed publicly. This is the reason most relatives of a patient never get tested and treated. Overcoming the stigma is as important as providing treatment.

The Kerala High Court in 2025 held that denial of public employment solely because a candidate had hepatitis B violated Article 14 of the Constitution and is "illegal, unfair and unjustifiable" if the person is otherwise medically fit. India already has an instructive model on the HIV and AIDS Act, 2017. But, does India need a change of mindset or would millions approaching the court for their justified status and rights in the society?

We, at the Institute of Liver and Biliary Sciences, launched a campaign, EMPATHY (Empowering People Against Hepatitis), in 2018 to address stigma through advocacy, behaviour-change communication and patient empowerment. This should become part of national policy. There is also a need to prevent mother-to-child transmission. Every pregnant woman should be screened and those with high hepatitis B DNA should receive antiviral prophylaxis. Every newborn should receive hepatitis B vaccination, preferably within 24 hours. As for the millions already living with chronic infection, antiviral treatment is prevention, of fibrosis, decompensation, liver cancer and premature death. For them the new Asian guidelines open a way to get antiviral medications. Now, general physicians are empowered to diagnose and prescribe antiviral therapy and not refer all patients. India can surely build and showcase the most effective model for elimination of hepatitis B.

With elderly cancer cases rising, India gets 60-plus therapy model**Tata Memorial and cancer centres recommend geriatric assessment for patients over 60****Purnima Sah**

AT 72, two cancer patients may appear similar on paper. But one still walks several kilometres every morning, cooks independently and manages his medications without help. The other has diabetes, mild memory problems, has fallen twice in the past year and needs assistance with everyday activities. Yet both receive similar cancer treatment simply because they are the same age although their ability to tolerate surgery or chemotherapy is different. India's first geriatric oncology guidelines say that approach needs to change.

In a first, Indian oncologists and geriatricians have issued comprehensive guidelines recommending that every cancer patient aged 60 years and above undergo a structured geriatric assessment before starting cancer treatment, particularly chemotherapy, to identify age-related vulnerabilities that could influence treatment tolerance and outcomes. Published in the *Journal of Geriatric Oncology*, the recommendations are India's first consensus guidelines on geriatric oncology. They were developed by a multidisciplinary task force led by Tata Memorial Hospital, Mumbai, in collaboration with all India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS), New Delhi, and several other cancer centres across the country.

Dr Vanita Noronha, lead author of the guideline, professor and medical oncologist at Tata Memorial Hospital, Mumbai, says the recommendations address an important gap in cancer care in India. "Geriatric oncology itself is still under-practised in India and there are very few geriatricians. Most older patients with cancer continue to be evaluated much like younger patients because oncologists have not traditionally been trained to assess them differently," she says.

The recommendations come at a time when the number of older adults with cancer is steadily increasing. According to the guideline, adults aged 60 years and above already account for more than one-third of patients treated at tertiary cancer centres. Community-based cancer registry data suggest the proportion may be as high as 45 per cent, and it is expected to rise further as India's population ages.

What the guidelines say

The recommendations call for every cancer patient aged 60 years and above to undergo a comprehensive geriatric assessment, preferably before chemotherapy begins, with a repeat assessment three months later to identify any decline in



GETTY IMAGES

physical or functional status during treatment. The guidelines further recommend that, wherever available, older adults with cancer should be registered at geriatric oncology clinics, where care is delivered by a multidisciplinary team, comprising geriatricians, medical oncologists, physiotherapists, occupational therapists, dietitians, clinical pharmacologists, psycho-oncologists or psychologists, and social workers.

The assessment should go well beyond routine cancer evaluation and include physical function, nutritional status, co-existing illnesses, risk of falls, inappropriate medications and polypharmacy, cognition, depression, anxiety, chemotherapy-related toxicity, and social support. Where resources are limited, the expert panel recommends that clinicians should, at a minimum, assess physical function, nutrition, comorbidities and chemotherapy toxicity risk before initiating treatment.

So, an otherwise healthy 68-year-old man with early-stage colon cancer may be able to tolerate standard chemotherapy and recover well after surgery. But a 68-year-old woman with the same cancer, who also has diabetes, hypertension, mild kidney disease, poor nutrition and a history of falls, may face a much higher risk of severe treatment-related complications despite being the same age. "While both patients might appear equally eligible for treatment based on their chronological age, a geriatric assessment can identify these underlying vulnerabilities, allowing doctors to modify chemotherapy doses, improve nutrition, optimise existing medical conditions or choose a less intensive treatment plan without compromising outcomes," says Dr Noronha.



SCAN THE QR CODE TO READ MORE HEALTH SPECIAL STORIES

Looking beyond the tumour

Unlike routine cancer evaluations, which primarily focus on the tumour and whether major organs can tolerate treatment, a geriatric assessment provides a much broader understanding of an older patient's health.

"Older patients with cancer are not simply older versions of younger patients. They have several vulnerabilities that are unrelated to the cancer itself but significantly influence how well they tolerate treatment and how they fare overall. As a result, patients may experience greater toxicity from chemotherapy, poorer quality of life and an overall worse treatment experience," Dr Noronha says.

Indigenising a global formula

Dr Noronha, who established the geriatric oncology clinic at Tata Memorial Hospital and later launched a fellowship programme in the specialty, says India needed recommendations tailored to its own patient population rather than relying solely on international guidance. "There are global guidelines from organisations such as the American Society of Clinical Oncology (ASCO) and the International Society of Geriatric Oncology (SIOG), but our patients are different. Indian patients often have lower muscle mass, different literacy levels, social circumstances and support systems. These factors influence treatment decisions, so we needed guidelines relevant to the Indian context," she says.

How guidelines help

Studies have shown that a geriatric assessment may lead to interventions such as improving nutrition before chemotherapy, prescribing supervised strength and balance

exercises, reviewing medications, or modifying chemotherapy doses and schedules, helping older patients complete treatment more safely and with fewer complications.

If assessment reveals weight loss or malnutrition, patients may be referred to a dietitian, started on high-protein/high-calorie supplements, encouraged to eat small frequent meals and receive aggressive anti-nausea treatment before chemotherapy. Patients with poor mobility or a history of falls may undergo a programme of strength, balance and endurance exercises with a physiotherapist before and during treatment. This can improve their ability to complete chemotherapy and reduce falls. Older adults often take multiple medicines for diabetes, hypertension or heart disease. A pharmacist or geriatrician reviews these medications to stop unnecessary drugs and reduce harmful interactions with chemotherapy.

Rather than giving a standard full-dose combination regimen, clinicians may begin with a reduced dose (for example, a 20 per cent dose reduction), use a single drug instead of two drugs, or space treatments differently, with more frequent monitoring, particularly in patients at intermediate or high risk of toxicity.

Survivor stories

One of the strongest pieces of evidence comes from the GERICCO trial in Denmark. Older patients with colorectal cancer under a geriatric assessment before chemotherapy. Those with nutritional or physical impairments were referred to dietitians, received structured exercise programmes and had other age-related problems addressed before and during treatment. Compared with standard care, they completed their planned chemotherapy without dose reductions or delays and also reported better mobility and quality of life.

The 2018 ASCO Geriatric Oncology Guideline includes a real clinical case. It describes a 75-year-old man with stage III colon cancer who appeared fit enough for chemotherapy based on routine oncology assessment. However, a comprehensive geriatric assessment revealed hidden vulnerabilities: he had recently suffered multiple falls, required help with managing his medications and finances, lived alone for much of the day, and had mild cognitive impairment that had not been detected during the standard cancer evaluation. Rather than simply proceeding with chemotherapy, the assessment prompted medication support, fall-prevention measures, involvement of his caregiver in treatment planning and a reassessment of chemotherapy toxicity risk before finalising treatment.

Ultimately, the guidelines encourage doctors to look beyond the number of years a patient has lived and instead assess how well they are functioning. "When older adults are treated as individuals rather than numbers, they feel valued and fight the disease better," says Dr Noronha.

• DOC I HAVE A QUESTION**Why hidden fat in pancreas matters more than being lean****Experts have proposed recognising fatty pancreas as a condition, saying it may be an early sign of diabetes****Express News Service**

FOR YEARS, doctors often dismissed fat in the pancreas as an incidental finding on scans, possibly a by-product of ageing or weight gain. But an international panel of experts is challenging that assumption, arguing that excessive fat in this small but vital organ may represent an overlooked disorder linked to diabetes, pancreatitis and even pancreatic cancer.

Published in *Nature Reviews Gastroenterology and Hepatology*, the consensus statement proposes a new framework for understanding Fatty Pancreas Disorder (FPD). Dr Anoop Misra, Chairman, Fortis-CDOC for Diabetes and Allied Sciences, who is part of the international committee, says the consensus assumes significance for Indians.

Is the evidence strong enough to change how clinicians approach

patients today?

The Melbourne Consensus is important because it establishes FPD as a distinct pathological state characterised by excessive intra-pancreatic fat deposition that poses a risk to health. While it does not support population-wide screening or pancreas-specific treatment at present, it does change the way clinicians should think about pancreatic fat. For endocrinologists, an incidental finding of pancreatic fat should no longer be dismissed as a benign imaging observation. Instead, it should prompt a comprehensive assessment of cardiometabolic health, including obesity, Type 2 diabetes, dyslipidaemia, fatty liver and cardiovascular disease. Routine MRI screening solely to detect FPD is premature until standardised diagnostic thresholds are drawn up.

One of the paper's findings is that fatty pancreas isn't just a



GETTY IMAGES

Type 1 fatty pancreas disorder occurs in individuals without excess body fat, and Type 2 in those with obesity

consequence of obesity, lean individuals can develop it too. What do you think drives this?

The expert panel recognises two forms: Type 1 FPD, occurring in individuals without excess body fat, and Type 2 FPD, occurring in those with obesity. The mechanisms in lean individuals are likely to be multifactorial and include genetic susceptibility, insulin resistance, ageing, environmental fac-

tors and abnormal fat processing by pancreas, rather than excess body fat.

Importantly, the consensus also states that intrapancreatic fat cannot be explained by BMI, waist circumference or liver fat alone. This is particularly relevant for Asian Indians, who frequently have excess body fat and also fat in various organs ("ectopic fat") at normal or low BMI. Endocrinologists should therefore assess metabolic risk using waist circumference, body composition, biomarkers and family history rather than relying on BMI alone.

What about the emphasis on links between fatty pancreas, type 2 diabetes and pancreatic cancer?

The strongest clinical evidence is for the association between FPD and Type 2 diabetes. This is supported by longitudinal cohort studies showing that pancreatic fat independently predicts future diabetes even after adjustment for BMI and liver fat. The association with pancreatic cancer has also been seen strongly though this does not yet justify pancreatic cancer screening based solely on pancreatic fat.

CWG's lifting queen

Mirabai Chanu wins third straight CWG gold, but her relationship with the Games has evolved over the 12-year period

Mihir Vasavda
Mumbai, July 26

WHEN MIRABAI Chanu walked into Glasgow's SEC Arena as a 20-year-old in 2014, the Commonwealth Games felt enormous.

They were her first major multisport Games, and perhaps her first chance to announce that India had another weightlifting star ready to emerge. Every lift carried consequence. Every kilogram mattered. Twelve years later, she leaves the same city and same venue with her fourth consecutive Commonwealth Games medal — and a golden hat-trick. With nobody to challenge her, Mirabai's wins came up by failing to lift in her first attempts in the snatch as well as clean and jerk sections. But once she got her bearings, she continued to rule the 48kg category in the Commonwealth like a monarch.

Her yet another dominant run on Sunday, lifting a total of 190 kg (85kg in snatch, 105kg in clean and jerk) to win the gold medal, completed a remarkable streak unmatched in Indian weightlifting. It also underscored how Mirabai's relationship with the event had fundamentally changed over her four appearances. The competition that once represented the biggest stage of her career has gradually become a carefully managed stop on a much longer journey.

That evolution mirrors her own. In Glasgow in 2014, Mirabai was still introducing herself to the sporting world. Indian weightlifting was searching for its next face after the generation of Karnam Malleswari and Kunjarani Devi, and the soft-spoken Manipuri knew she belonged among the elite. She lifted fearlessly, pushing eventual champion Sanjita Chanu all the way before settling for silver with a total of 170kg.

That medal became the foundation of a Commonwealth Games career that would stretch over more than a decade, surviving changing weight categories, injuries, Olympic cycles and the relentless demands of staying at the top. If Glasgow was about ambition, Gold Coast in 2018 became about redemption. Few athletes have arrived at the Commonwealth Games with such a record. She no longer needed the Games to establish



Mirabai Chanu lifted 190 kg to win the gold medal (right) Chanu in action during the clean and jerk section. **PHOTO: AP**



ing the emotional baggage Mirabai did. Less than two years earlier, she had walked off the Rio Olympic platform without registering a single successful clean and jerk, one of the most painful afternoons of her career. The failure lingered long after the Games ended. Rebuilding her confidence became as important as rebuilding her technique.

By the time she reached Australia, she was the reigning world champion. This time, there was no uncertainty. Mirabai produced one of the most dominant performances in Commonwealth Games history, totalling 196kg for a gold. The improvement from Glasgow was staggering — 26 kilograms added to her total in four years.

At one level, even that commanding victory reflected an athlete still trying to prove something, as every successful lift was a statement that Rio had been an aberration. By 2022, that need had disappeared.

Between Gold Coast and Birmingham, Mirabai had become an Olympic silver medalist, one of India's biggest sporting icons and arguably the finest weightlifter in the Commonwealth. She no longer needed the Games to establish

her credentials. Her victory was comfortable, almost inevitable. She defended her title with another Games record, lifting a total of 201kg.

Clear priorities

Long before arriving in Glasgow, Mirabai had made her priorities clear. The Commonwealth Games, she admitted, would not receive her absolute focus because she remained the real objective. She spoke openly about avoiding unnecessary risks, about resisting the temptation to chase symbolic milestones such as a 90kg snatch, and about preserving her body for Aichi-Nagoya, where the level of competition rises dramatically with the presence of China, North Korea and other Asian powerhouses.

A fourth successive Commonwealth medal, therefore, says less about her dominance

over this field than about her longevity. Across 12 years, the sport has evolved around her. Rivals have emerged and disappeared. Weight categories have been restructured. Injuries have interrupted momentum. Younger challengers have arrived with bigger ambitions and fresher bodies. Yet Mirabai has remained the constant, adapting not only her lifting but also her understanding of where each competition fits within the larger picture.

And today, the larger picture extends far beyond Glasgow. The Asian Games have long remained the missing piece in an otherwise extraordinary collection. Mirabai owns an Olympic silver medal, a world championship title and now three Commonwealth Games gold medals. Yet, an Asian Games podium finish has eluded her, partly because

Rishikanta lifts 264 kg to win silver medal



Rishikanta Singh. **PHOTO: AP**

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 26

RISHIKANTA SINGH Channabam won India's second medal, a silver, at the Glasgow Commonwealth Games. The weightlifter heaved a Commonwealth Games record of 121kg in snatch, before lifting 143kg in the clean and jerk to finish second in the men's 60kg event at the SEC Armadillo.

Rishikanta was joined at the top by Malaysia's Mohamad Aniq Bin Kasdan, who also lifted 121kg in the snatch. Rishikanta had lifted 143kg in his first clean and jerk attempt, but failed his subsequent lifts of 148kg and 151kg. Bin Kasdan set a Games record with a total weight of 273 kg (121 in snatch and 152 in clean and jerk).

Kenya's Joshua Atwanga Mbaya claimed the bronze medal with a total lift of 260kg (115kg+145kg), edging out Sri Lanka's SDSS Wiriduwa, who managed 244kg (109kg+135kg).

He became the first male lifter from Manipur to win a medal at CWG 2026.

of injury and partly because the continental field is considerably stronger than anything the Commonwealth can assemble.

In many ways, the Asian Games has become the challenge that the Olympics once represented — a medal that would complete the story rather than merely embellish it.

These Games were a carefully calibrated checkpoint. Every training session, every attempt selection and every kilogram lifted in Glasgow has been planned with Japan in mind. Unlike the eager youngster of 2014, who chased every possible lift because every lift could change her career, today's Mirabai understands that sometimes greatness lies in knowing exactly what not to chase.

Four Commonwealth Games. Four medals. Four very different versions of Mirabai Chanu.

Protistha's journey to final: 4:30 am alarms and a mother's grit

Shivani Naik
Mumbai, July 26

PROTISTHA SAMANTA'S mother, Shubhada, recalls the number of Kolkata monsoons both of them would literally run the two whole stops from Chingrighata to Salt Lake. Getting stuck in potholed vehicular traffic was no excuse for the strict coach Jayprakash Chakraborty, who passed away in 2024. "If practice was at 9 a.m., even reaching the SAI centre at 9:01 a.m. invited a scolding from the coach. So both of us would leave the rickshaw if we thought we were late, and start running," Shubhada recalled.

All those long days that started at 4 a.m. and ended at 10:30 p.m., including overseeing Protistha's homework sitting under a tree between two training sessions, yielded results. At the Glasgow Commonwealth Games, the Howrah resident and Dipa Karmakar understudy for five years recorded two vaults of 12.950 and 12.700, plus a 0.2 bonus mark, to average 12.525, which put her 7th in the Apparatus finals for Vault. Protistha also recorded strong routines on the floor exercise and beam and is third reserve for All Around Finals.

Father Suman Samanta recalled his daughter being fascinated by a gymnastics club in their neighbourhood, run by a coaching couple. "Protistha thought it was 'dhamal-type' activity so she insisted on joining. I am in private service, and we are middle-class. But I never could play football or cricket because we came from poverty. So when she said 'sports', we didn't think twice. But it's fully credit to her mother — she is the engine to Protistha's gymnastics," he said.

At Glasgow, the 22-year-old joined two other teammates on the Tsukahara full layout, a solid execution of takeoff and turn of 12.950, which could've been higher if not for a slight stop back. On the second vault, a handspring front pike half, she scored 12.700.

It was in pursuit of that strength in her routines that Protistha had moved for five and a half years to Agartala, training under BS Nandy, an understudy to Dipa. "She was super talented. She's always had good speed, strength, stamina, and flexibility for that pike front somersault," Nandy said. "She picked things early, and didn't need too many repetitions to get it right. In a few practices, she would get really good. But the biggest difference from many other gymnasts was her strong mind. Unbreakable."



Protistha Samanta. **PHOTO: AP**

he recalled.

Medals at state and four at Khelo India followed, as she completed her graduation and took a job with Railways, returning to Kolkata. "Sir dhamta" (Sir will cook), used to be the buzzword in her early years, around which the Samanta family planned their wake-up alarms for 4.30 a.m. "Even for 6 a.m. practice, the day would begin at 4.30 for Shubhada and Protistha. Rains, traffic jams, packing school bag, cooking — we had to keep all that in mind, because studies and graduation were important. They would sit under a tree and do homework when there were two trainings," Suman recalls.

Shubhada was a homemaker and devoted to Protistha's neighbourhood, run by a coaching couple. "Protistha understood her dream and stubbornness. Even as a kid, she would enter the house with a cartwheel and spin and twist and tumble around the house. The discipline came from training," she said.

The other hobby was music, which developed her sense of rhythm. It showed on her floor exercise lines too. Though Eshtiaq Rawale's Kuchipudi-inspired choreography from Bhool Bhulaiyaa was a hit with the commentators, Protistha riffs off the Dance of Envy, weaving in Shiamak Davar's hook steps from Dil Toh Pagal Hai and combining it with serious acrobatics, gained praise. The front layout bit was seamless, and she stuck a good double tuck landing with a tiny hop for 10.750. Her front layout also salvaged an otherwise wobbly balance beam routine. In vault qualification, World Championships medalist Lisa Monica Fontaine topped with 13.750, which is 0.725 more than the Indian's 7th place start. Protistha will need to nail the landing, cut out deductions, maybe add half a twist to go from 360 to 540 and raise difficulty, to get in medal contention. Pranati Nayak is third reserve, finishing on 12.575.

Indian athletes look for bigger medal haul

Pritish Raj
New Delhi, July 26

THE 32-member Indian athletics contingent will face the litmus test at the 2026 Commonwealth Games after an incredible domestic season where more than 25 national records were shattered.

Led by double Olympic medalist Neeraj Chopra, the Indian contingent will be targeting medals in the field events as track events have a highly competitive field with the presence of the African nations. India won eight medals (three with five coming in field events and three on track) including the historic 3000m steeplechase medal of Avinash Sable.

Focus on jumps

India's major expectations will be from the jumps squad with latest high jump national record holder Sarvesh Kushare leading the field.

Apart from Sarvesh, Tejashwari Devi and Aashish Ram are the other Indians in contention with Tejashwari being the bronze medalist from the previous edition.

"I know a lot of eyes are on me. I think competing at Monaco Diamond League gave me more confidence," Sarvesh told The Indian Express.

Sarvesh, who set the new national record of 2.31m, will be up against NCAA champion Selva Prabhu but will be in

India's major expectations will be from the jumps squad with latest high jump national record holder Sarvesh Kushare leading the field.

Similarly in the men's long jump, India's hope rests on Sreesankar Murali who is having a fantastic year with a season best of 8.38m. Along with him, NCAAA indoor champion Lokesh Satyanarayan will be competing in the event.

"The Commonwealth Games is always a tough field. We have the likes of Tajay Gayle and Liam Adcock in the field," said Sreesankar in a media interaction. "I have been jumping consistently and the key will be to continue my form outside of India also," he added further.

Sreesankar won silver last time in Birmingham and will hope to better the colour of his medal this time.

Triple jump was the most successful event for India last time in CWG. With those Paul and Abdulla Abobackar winning gold and silver and Praveen Chithravel finishing fourth.

This time, Praveen and recently crowned NCAA champion Selva Prabhu will be in



National record holder Sarvesh Kushare (left) and long jumper Sreesankar Murali will be India's biggest medal hopes. **FILE**



action for India.

Apart from the jumps, Javelin will be the event with the most medal hopes as Neeraj is participating along with Rohit Yadav, who has the best throw in the country this season.

In men's shot put, Tajinderpal Singh Tomar and Samardeep Singh Gill will have an outside chance after Jacko Gill of New Zealand pulled out.

Nigeria's Chukwuebuka Enekwechi, England's Scott Lincoln along with reigning champion Tom Walsh will be their main competitors.

While India has outside

chances of medals in events like 100m, 200m and 400m, there is a big chance of national records improving in Glasgow. The likes of Gurinder Singh, Animesh Kujur, and Vishal TK will be running in a high quality field and such races often result in new national records.

100m national record holder Gurinder Singh is placed 8th in heat 4 of 100m where he will be up against Jamaican Rohan Watson who has a personal best of 9.91s.

In the 400m, national recordholder Vishal TK will be up against the likes of Zakithi

Nene of South Africa who has a personal best of 43.76s.

Indian pole vaulters Dev Meena and Kuldeep Kumar have improved the national record five times this year and the duo will expect to put up a good show again.

"See, I know that the competition is going to be very tough at the Commonwealth Games. Our boys have been doing well and we will look to do our best instead of thinking of what others are doing," Dev and Kuldeep's coach Chanshyan Yadav said.

Indian long distance runners Parul Chaudhary and Gulveer Singh will be making their debut at the multi-sport event but their medal chances are extremely slim with the presence of the African nations.

Parul, who will compete in 3000m steeplechase, will target the national record that stands at 9:12.46 in the event. A lot of eyes will be on high jumper turned Decathlete Tejashwari Singh. He recently broke the 8000 points barrier at Federation Cup Ranchi. He will be competing in a tough field but there is an outside chance if he improves his throw events, he can win a bronze medal.

It will be tough for India to better the last edition's performance but given the current momentum of Indian athletics, a lot of national records can be ruled out.

Why Animesh prefers running in the outside lanes in 200m

Nihal Koshie
New Delhi, July 26

MARTIN OWENS isn't a weather whiner but he wasn't pleased with the gloomy skies in Glasgow on Friday, the day he landed in the host city of the Commonwealth Games.

Owens knows the ins and outs of speed as he is the man Animesh Kujur, the 200 metre national record holder, trusts as his coach. Owens hopes it gets a little brighter by the time Kujur settles into the starting blocks. "If Animesh goes below 20 (seconds) in Glasgow on a grey, miserable afternoon, it will be a phenomenal run," Owens said. "He just needs to focus on racing. It isn't about chasing records. Championships are about medals," Owens said to put in perspective what is at stake.

At the 2025 Asian Athletics Championships, Kujur lowered his 200 metres national record to 20.32 seconds. This year, he's run two blistering 100 metres — 10.14 seconds in Wetzlar, Germany, and 10.15 seconds in Ranchi. The run in Wetzlar was the fastest by an Indian in the foreign soil. But at the Commonwealth Games, Kujur will focus on his pet event, the 200 metres.

If Kujur does not qualify for the final, Owens said he would be disappointed because the 23-year-old sprinter has im-



Animesh Kujur will look to script history in Glasgow. **FILE**

proved on multiple fronts — the start, running on the curve and top speed. "He has improved his start immensely, he is running his bend so much better, his top speed is better, and his endurance is better," Owens, the head coach at the discredited Reliance Foundation High Performance Centre, said.

"If you look at what his 100 metres time was when he came to the high performance centre in Odisha, you'll see that he's come down by something like 0.7. And then he's improved his 200m by 0.8. He's in good shape at the moment — but the next part is just learning to run technically," Owens said.

The coach wants Kujur to remain unflustered when the gun goes off and not let his race be dictated by what others are doing.

"Obviously, because of the radius of the circle everybody starts in a stagger. So it's about not panicking if things aren't going right, or people appear ahead. Do the first 30 (metres) very hard and then the next part is about coming off the bend. It's all about trying to be as effective and as efficient as possible. And running your own race, especially when he gets to these better metres. You know, in India, he can just turn up and win," Owens said.

Owens is also hoping that Animesh can run the 200 in his preferred outer lanes. "We like the outer lanes, really. The curves are a little bit kinder. If you are on the inner lanes, you can watch what everybody else is doing and can follow what's going on. So that's an advantage there. But people tend to run the 200 in the next part is about coming off the bend. It's all about trying to be as effective and as efficient as possible. And running your own race, especially when he gets to these better metres. You know, in India, he can just turn up and win," Owens said.

With the Asian Games starting in the third week of September, Owens is confident Animesh can hit peak form twice — at the CWG and then at the Asian Games. "It is possible for an athlete to peak twice in a year. I am hoping he will peak here (Glasgow). We will go back and do some work after the CWG and then he will peak at the Asian Games again."

Anand to run with Turlov as Deputy Prez in FIDE elections



Viswanathan Anand. FILE

Express News Service
Mumbai, July 26

FIVE-TIME world champion Viswanathan Anand, who is currently serving as the Interim President of FIDE, has confirmed that he will run for the Deputy President's role in the upcoming FIDE elections along with Timur Turlov, who will be running for the top post. Turlov was initially running for the Deputy President's role in the upcoming elections with Arkady Dvorkovich running for a third term as president. But sanctions from European Union meant that Dvorkovich holding the post of chief's position became untenable.

Anand had recently spoken about wanting to not contest for the elections again to spend more time with family.

"I simply wanted to have more time at home. My son will probably go to university in three years, I thought these are the years I should be here. That was a big motivation to get a different role. But I am still very much part of the team."

But with Dvorkovich out of contention, Turlov stepped up to run for president's role while Anand will be his running mate. Anand also is the interim president of FIDE for the next two months, until election happen during the Olympiad in Samarkand.

"Over the past four years, it has been an honour to work at FIDE and contribute to the development of chess. I have worked with colleagues from grassroots programmes to elite competitions. Together, we have made significant progress in expanding opportunities for players, federations and organisers, while making chess more accessible. I am proud of what we have achieved as a team, but I also believe there is much more that can be accomplished. That is why I have accepted Timur Turlov's invitation to continue serving as FIDE Deputy President as part of this team," Anand wrote on X on Sunday.

"I believe Turlov has the vision, energy and expertise to showcase the power game that has made him one of India's most exciting young players, but there was greater control to his aggression. He did not wait for losses deliveries, attacking from the outset. A loofed punch-drive off Sikandar Raza, a pull off Blessing Muzarabani over long leg and a strike over deep mid-wicket against Wellington Masakadza showed his ability to clear the boundary.

But Zimbababwe made him work hard. Muzarabani challenged him with pace and bounce, while Nymahuri and Evans repeatedly attempted to cramp him with wide yorkers and slower deliveries. Sooryavanshi responded by finding gaps, rotating strike and waiting for the right moments to attack.

At the other end, Kishan

Jr Worlds out of way, Asiad gold next target for Anahat, mentor Ghosal

Shivani Naik
Mumbai, July 26

IT'S JUST the way GenZ is wired. When newly-crowned squash Junior World champion Anahat Singh was lacing up her shoes to face Ruqaiya Salem in the finals at Ontario, mentor and coach Saurav Ghosal dropped a snide one: "Are you carrying your brass knuckles today?"

It was a remark meant to awaken the 18-year-old from possibly being slightly casual and ending up underwhelming in the title match. She retorted: "Braincells are awesome today." Saurav left it at, "That's debatable..."

The Delhi teen went on to nail her fifth attempt at a junior

world title to settle the debate. "She's got a few doses (read as scoldings) this week. But we do it because we know she can take doses. She doesn't go into a shell," Saurav says.

Anahat's scorelines across 6 matches don't even begin to tell the whole story. She dropped only two sets in the quarters and semis that might point to dominance, even as she beat three Egyptians in a row. Behind the scenes though, the game jarred. She's capable of making them uncomfortable. "But there were matches where she didn't put it together. We were left scratching our heads, hitting head on walls when her game would go to sleep. We needed to trigger her. She got better with every match,



Mentor Saurav Ghosal with Anahat Singh. INSTAGRAM

and in the final, was at 92%, barring the middle of the third game," he describes of the 11-3, 11-7, 11-9 win.

Anahat's game isn't unidimensional and she can play in different styles to manipulate opponents and change things around with Plan B or C. "She can. But it needs high intensity play, even while keeping a balanced head." But the team used every subsequent match to fine-tune how to attack the Egyptian gamestyle, and sharpen her tactical brain for the next match. Like, going up video game levels.

Anahat had 3 quarters and a semifinal from her last 4 Worlds - with Egyptians halting her most times. "We never talked about it (overcoming 3 Egyptians) as a challenge. Just used each match to test tactics for the next," Saurav says.

The scars of the previous 4

losses were gushing red. "We hammered into her head that you didn't lose matches but just couldn't execute the plan, while the other person was better." Up-skilling will continue into her senior career. She needs pace - to take the ball early, get stronger at T. "She has it all in the locker. But it isn't second nature to her still."

Saurav knows it can't all be stern. "She needs to have fun when she plays. It can't be all serious. So we make fun of her," he says. Braincells get dared.

An Asian Games gold can assure her of an Olympic spot, but the World No 20 has two Top 10s from Malaysia and Japan to contend with. On the circuit, there's a yawning gap between Top 5 and the rest.

Former Top-10 ace Dipika Pallikal believes Anahat is special due to how composed she is for someone so young. "She doesn't look rushed, constructs points patiently, has excellent court awareness and is willing to work for every rally instead of searching for quick winners," she says, adding that she has finesse, deception and a read of the game. "What's different is her maturity in decision-making. Many juniors rely purely on pace, but she already understands variation, tempo and shot selection."

The areas of improvement are obvious. "Becoming physically stronger, adding even more attacking intent when opportunities arise, and continuing to

build the confidence to dictate play against very best. Those things naturally come with experience and time on the professional tour," she says.

Dipika hopes the youngster continues to genuinely enjoy the sport. "Something I hope she never loses." But after deserved celebrations, she would like to see the reset kick in. "One title doesn't define your career, just as one loss doesn't define it either. Stay curious, keep improving every day and don't let outside expectations dictate your journey," she urges.

"The potential is certainly there, but the focus should remain on steady progress rather than chasing milestones too early," Dipika stresses.

T20I SERIES

Routine demolition secures clean sweep in Zimbabwe

After difficult start to his captaincy, Iyer finally finds some joy as India win series 3-0

Shankar Narayan
Mumbai, July 26

SHREYAS IYER's first assignment as India's T20I captain had begun with setbacks in Ireland and England. In Zimbabwe, however, he found the turn around he was looking for, leading India to a 3-0 sweep after a 35-run win in the final game in Harare. The foundation to Sunday's win was laid by the top order. A 75-run second-wicket stand between Vaibhav Sooryavanshi and Ishan Kishan helped India reach 192/5, with the two left-handers combining aggression and composure against a disciplined Zimbabwe attack.

After Abhishek Sharma's lean run continued with another low score, India needed a partnership that could restore momentum without allowing Zimbabwe to build pressure. They got exactly that from Sooryavanshi and Kishan, who brought contrasting styles to the same result.

Sooryavanshi continued to showcase the power game that has made him one of India's most exciting young players, but there was greater control to his aggression. He did not wait for losses deliveries, attacking from the outset. A loofed punch-drive off Sikandar Raza, a pull off Blessing Muzarabani over long leg and a strike over deep mid-wicket against Wellington Masakadza showed his ability to clear the boundary.

But Zimbababwe made him work hard. Muzarabani challenged him with pace and bounce, while Nymahuri and Evans repeatedly attempted to cramp him with wide yorkers and slower deliveries. Sooryavanshi responded by finding gaps, rotating strike and waiting for the right moments to attack.

At the other end, Kishan



India's third successive win over Zimbabwe came from the top order dominating proceedings on Sunday. CREAMS

provided the stability India needed after the early loss of Abhishek. He survived a disciplined opening spell from Nymahuri, who consistently tested him outside off stump with movement and accuracy. Once settled, Kishan found his range, guiding behind square before taking on Evans with back-to-back boundaries.

The partnership grew as both batters adapted to Zimbabwe's plans. When Zimbabwe missed their lengths, they capitalised. Kishan's slog-sweep against Masakadza and Sooryavanshi's reverse-sweep against Madhevere were examples of calculated aggression rather than reckless hitting.

Zimbabwe's bowlers, though, refused to let India run away. Madhevere and Bennett kept the batters quiet during the middle overs, while Raza's variations forced them to manufacture scoring opportunities. Their disciplined lines made the partnership even more valuable.

Kishan fell soon after the drinks break for 29, attempting to take on Raza but missing a delivery that crashed into his leg stump.

Sooryavanshi reached his second T20I fifty off 31 balls and then added 50 runs for the third wicket with captain Iyer. He looked set for a maiden international hundred before Evans produced a stunning low catch at long-off to dismiss him for 81 off 49 balls, an innings containing eight fours and four sixes.

Iyer added a quick 27 off 18 balls, while Tilak Varma and Rinku Singh provided useful contributions in the final overs, the building blocks of which were laid by Sooryavanshi and Kishan, whose partnership helped India overcome Zimbabwe's disciplined bowling and post a challenging total.

Mayank impresses

Mayank Yadav began the series on Thursday by claiming 2/18 in his four overs. The spell gave a glimpse of his high

pace, with deliveries clocking near 150 kph. The challenge was whether he could replicate that again, and on Sunday, he showed he could.

Brian Bennett had faced the brunt of his high pace when he nicked Mayank's first delivery of the match on Thursday. Lightning struck the same place on Sunday, when the 24-year-old removed the right-hander on the first ball of the innings, a 147kph thunderbolt taking the outside edge and Sooryavanshi taking the catch at the lone first slip.

What stood out was Mayank's ability to sustain that pace through his spell. He was consistently in the high 140s, troubling batters with deliveries of 145kph, 147kph, 148kph and 149kph. Mayank later removed Wesley Madhevere for 28 to break a 60-run stand with Ryan Burl before dismissing Brad Evans in the final over to end with 3/29 in his four overs.

Mayank was supported by Yash Thakur, who took 2/45 in

his four overs, which included wickets in successive deliveries. He dismissed Dion Myers and Sikandar Raza in the fourth over to leave them 34/3. His figures could have been a lot better had the fielders held on to their chances, with three dropped catches off his bowling not allowing him to add to his tally.

Ashok Sharma, the other debutant on this tour with Thakur, took 1/20 in his four overs, but like his bowling partner could have had a wicket early in his spell had Ishan Kishan held on to a top-edge.

Only Ryan Burl offered resistance, remaining unbeaten on 54, but it was not enough as India completed an easy win.

BRIEF SCORES: India 192/5 in 20 overs (Vaibhav Sooryavanshi 81; Brad Evans 2/41) beat Zimbabwe 157/7 in 20 overs (Ryan Burl 54; Mayank Yadav 3/29; Yash Thakur 2/45) by 35 runs.

Sooryavanshi 2.0: Template more impressive than score

Shankar Narayan
Mumbai, July 26

THE CRICKETING world has quickly come to associate Vaibhav Sooryavanshi with one thing — boundaries. Fours punched through the infield, towering sixes into the stands and an ultra-aggressive approach that leaves bowlers with little room to settle into a rhythm. At 15, he has already forged a reputation for measuring innings not in runs, but in the damage they leave behind.

On Sunday, however, in the third T20I against Zimbabwe, Sooryavanshi revealed another side to his batting. While the boundaries were still there in his 81 off 49 balls, beneath the spectacle lay an innings built on attacking intention and game awareness. It was a knock that suggested there is far more to his game than brute force.

There were still moments that reminded everyone why he is regarded as one of most exciting young batters in the world. Blessing Muzarabani banged one into his body, and Sooryavanshi swivelled into a pull that disappeared over backward square leg. Wellington Masakadza floated one into his arc, and it sailed over deep mid-wicket. Wesley Madhevere was driven straight to the fence before reverse-swept to become the very next ball.

Living on the edge

Those shots were in line with Sooryavanshi's penchant for living on the edge. But while they were spectacular, the defining feature was everything in between. Unlike many of his previous knocks, Sooryavanshi was content collecting singles. Off his 81 runs, 19 came through singles and six more through three twos from nudging Sikandar Raza to deep mid-wicket, tapping Wellington Masakadza into the off-side, working Brian Bennett into the leg side and driving T20 cricketer as much about denying bowlers control as it is about overpowering them, and strike rotation, game awareness and selective aggression often separate explosive talents from complete batsmen.

Sooryavanshi's innings suggested he is beginning to appreciate that distinction. The swagger remained, but so did the discipline.



Vaibhav Sooryavanshi scored 81 runs off 49 balls. CREAMS

line regardless of the outcome. Today, however, he was happy to be beaten outside off, defend the yorker or chase a single when the opportunity arose. Dot balls did not automatically trigger a high-risk response.

His shot selection against spin also stood out.

Zimbabwe's spinners rarely offered freebies after the power-play, but Sooryavanshi resisted the temptation to manufacture boundaries every over.

Instead, he manipulated the field. The reverse sweep appeared not as a desperate option but as a calculated scoring shot, first fetching a couple over point before later producing a boundary behind backward point. Perhaps the biggest takeaway was his tempo. There was no visible panic when the boundaries briefly dried up. He trusted that singles would keep him ahead of the game before accelerating once the bowlers missed their lengths. His fifty came off 31 balls, but he built towards it rather than merely blasting his way there. That represents an important evolution.

For young power hitters, the challenge is rarely clearing the ropes. It is learning to build an innings — absorbing pressure, rotating strike and then capitalising when bowlers err. T20 cricket is as much about denying bowlers control as it is about overpowering them, and strike rotation, game awareness and selective aggression often separate explosive talents from complete batsmen.

Sooryavanshi's innings suggested he is beginning to appreciate that distinction. The swagger remained, but so did the discipline.

Slow start, perfect finish as U Mumba defeat Goa to retain UTT crown

Bhuvan Gupta
Pune, July 26

U MUMBA TT started the season with heavy defeats to Dempo Goa Challengers (5-10) and Ahmedabad APL Pipers (6-9) and nearly faced three straight losses. Anusha Kutumbale had ensured that did not happen, breaking the streak with a clutch golden point win over Dabang Delhi TTC, then repeated her heroics on Sunday to secure U Mumba's second consecutive Ultimate Table Tennis (UTT) title.

At the receiving end were the same Goa team who were undefeated going into the final. They fell prey to Manush Shah's all-round brilliance on the second evening running, before Kutumbale finished things off calmly.

Captain Manush had won the singles and mixed doubles

rubbers on Saturday to fashion U Mumba's semi-final triumph over HVR Kolkata Thunder Blades. He did the same in the final, usurping five of six possible points in the matches he played as the defending champions pipped Goa 8-5 in a tantalising tie.

Just like their story in the league phase, U Mumba started the summit clash too with back-to-back defeats. Lilian Bardet and Anna Husey were on the wrong side of two riveting singles matches, with Abhinandh PB and Bernadette Szocs shining through. Having blanked Bardet 3-0 in the league phase in the back of inside-out crosscourt forehand drives, Abhinandh came out with a different strategy against him in the final. The 18-year-old chose to attack Bardet's forehand and body down the middle, and

the Frenchman had few answers in Game 1.

The senior pro, called 'T-Rex' for his victory celebration style, upped the ante with powerful inside-out forehands of his own early in the second game. But the Chennai lad responded beautifully with a mix of short and long third-ball attacks, winning nine out of 10 points from 1-5 down. It was a sight to behold as Abhinandh remained dauntless amid scoreboard pressure, delighting the partisan crowd with his aesthetically pleasing shots.

Abhinandh later thanked his coaches for helping him build mental composure for times like these. "Many times before I had panicked, but I've worked hard on my mental strength in the last one year with my coaches," he said.

The match was lost, but



U Mumba were the winners of UTT season 7. UTT

Bardet managed to wrest the initiative in the last game to snatch a crucial point for U Mumba. The second match pitted league veteran Szocs versus the in-form Husey. The players, bearing similar styles and evenly matched on

paper, produced a duel worth the billing.

Husey, arguably the best women's singles player on show this season with six wins and one loss amid illness, ran away with Game 1. The better-ranked Szocs (world number

At the receiving end were the same Goa team who were undefeated going into the final. They fell prey to Manush Shah's all-round brilliance.

24 as against Husey's 34) used all her experience to fight back superbly in the next two games. She repeatedly used her tomahawk serve to induce errors in Husey, and pounced on them with glece.

The rallies lengthened as the match wore on, but 'Bernie' prevailed in more counter punches, and kept letting out roars before clinching it 5-11, 11-7, 11-7. She then explained the rationale behind her vociferous display. "This was the only match I was playing in the final; I was not playing the mixed doubles rubber. I had a lot of pressure on me, a lot of emotions. When I won points, I let out some of that emotion. So I screamed like crazy in the latter points."

But the 20-year-old Husey soon redeemed herself in the mixed doubles alongside a charged-up Manush. They one-upped Alvaro Robles and Syndrela Das in straight games (11-8, 11-7, 11-9). The match was far closer than the scoreline suggested, and it was Manush's ability to land the top-spin winners in the corners on the vital points that shaped the result.

Manush was only half done. He took on Alvaro Robles in a fourth rubber that proved decisive to the contest.

The battle of the south-

paws opened up fresh angles on the table. Manush, like he did the previous night against Ankur Bhattacharjee, moved swiftly in anticipation of returns and kept lining up the forehand. He targeted all parts of the court as per the situation, and was not averse to directing traffic at Robles' body.

The Spaniard, though he took Game 1 with an emphatic 11-6 margin, started coming up short when initiating attacks in long rallies. Manush took charge. By snaring the golden point in the second game, he swung the match and the tie's momentum Mumba's way.

By the end of this match, U Mumba needed just one more point. Kutumbale delivered it right away against the rising young Syndrela, just like she had against Delhi to spark their victory juggernaut.